

History Refresh for Adults

Michael Gannotti

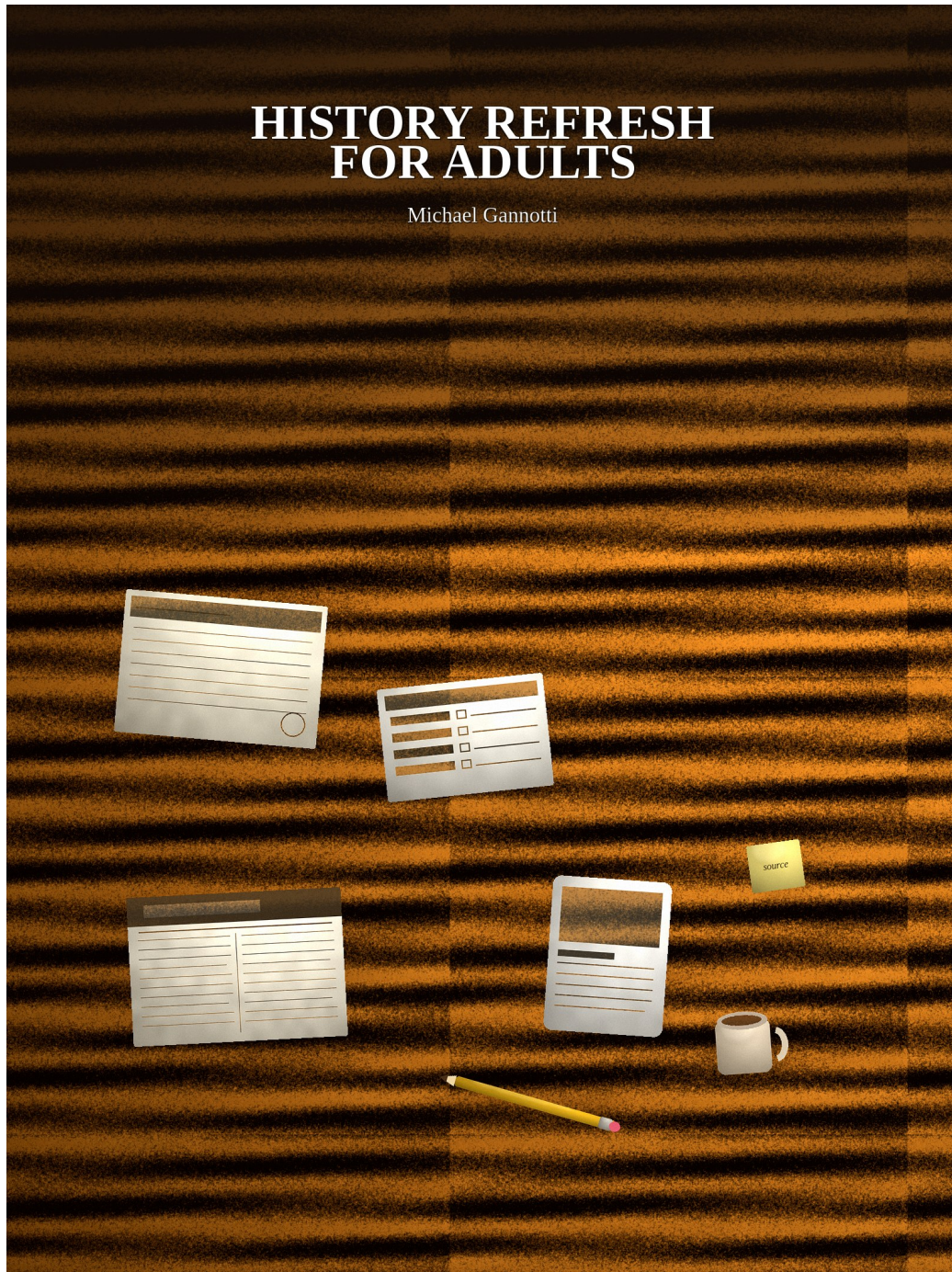


Figure 1: Cover

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This illustrated edition is the teaching-manual of 13 September 2026. Endnotes run in one series. Chapter-opening images are original still-lives, not portraits of persons or children. Documents still constrain the facts.

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Welcome

This book exists because usable civic literacy is ordinary adult work — a feed card about a founding anniversary, a ballot pamphlet in the mail, a museum caption, a courthouse plaque, a historic newspaper page, a short civic excerpt with a credit line, a workplace claim that “the law has always said.” There is you, the piece in front of you, and today’s looking move. You already have a life. The hour is the work.

I wrote this for a capable, busy, willing adult. You may be on a train, at a desk, on a shift, in a trade bay, a clinic, a warehouse, a retail counter, or at a kitchen table after the kids are in bed. Many adults feel rusty when they sit down to history they last saw in school. That feeling is common. It is not a verdict, and it is not proof of a history gene. This book will make you fluent enough in today’s looking move to hear a caption offered as the event, a summary before a byline, a tidy “they were just stupid,” one account treated as a verdict, a model précis offered as a primary, and a feed-first reflex — and to ask yourself one good question before you grab the feed or the chatbot.

You do not need to be a historian. You do need to hear a caption offered as the event, and to open the piece first.

Ordinary stakes live on the go and in deeper sits: a pamphlet you already hold, a plaque, a museum label, a public-domain founding phrase, two short accounts of one event, a feed card *about* a clause. Civic life and work motivate. They do not replace the looking move.

The cover says *History Refresh for Adults*. The work is this commute, this desk, this weekend sit. A job and a degree are not a bicycle you now ride on every document and every feed.¹ You already consume history in pockets of life. That

¹Willingham, “Critical Thinking” (*American Educator*, 2007): thinking is not a bicycle skill.

is not the same as having rebuilt usable looking — primary before feed; source before body; a short claim with a named source and a named limit. Adulthood is not a civic birthday.

A large adult skills survey places U.S. literacy near the international average — mean 258 versus about 260 — with about twenty-eight in a hundred U.S. adults at Level 1 or below.² That survey is why dense founding prose needs short excerpts. It is not a grade for you. Named civic-fact surveys tell a limited story: many adults can name the three branches; fewer can name a Senate term.³ Those figures are population context, not this book's pretest, and not historical thinking. The pamphlet or credited excerpt on the table tomorrow is the work.

What a good History Refresh Hour looks like

You sit down already knowing today's looking move. An object is on the table — a short credited excerpt, a pamphlet page, a plaque photo, a historic newspaper header, a feed card you will treat as a later telling. You retrieve a little. Then you source before the body. Then you look — Observe, then Reflect, then Question — or you hop once off a feed to ask who is behind it. Then you try a parallel item unaided. Then you ask one good self-question and wait before the key, the feed, or the chatbot. Then you leave a short sticky or dated line you could almost show a colleague. *The History Refresh Hour* will teach this in full — micro-session, desk sit, weekend deep sit, talk-to-yourself shape, on-the-go and deeper try-its, and the AI rules once for adults. Later chapters will not reinvent it.

Adults can rebuild usable civic literacy. Place by looking-move strip, not by birth-

A job and a diploma are domains — not all document and feed surfaces. Access date for URLs in these notes: 13 September 2026.

²NCES/IES, *Highlights from PIAAC 2023* (ages 16–65): U.S. literacy mean **258** vs international about **260**; Level 1 or below **28%** (was **19%** in 2017; 2017 mean **271**). Survey, not a trial of this book. Adjacent reading stock, not historical thinking. Not teen NAEP. Not mashed with PIAAC numeracy.

³Annenberg Public Policy Center, Constitution Day Civics Survey 2025: **70%** of U.S. adults named all three branches (was **65%** in 2024); **79%** named speech among First Amendment rights; **40%** named a majority of First Amendment rights. Phone-to-internet methodology shift in 2023 — recent figures are not directly comparable to older phone eras. Pew Research Center short-read, 7 November 2023 (ATP, 5–11 June 2023, n=5,115): Court tenure about **75%**; House apportionment **68%**; chamber control about **66%** / **63%**; Senate term **44%**; Electoral College tie **40%**. Labelled population context. Not this book's pretest.

day and not by diploma year.⁴ A person who can name three branches is recalling. They have not finished the dual job of opening a piece before a thread and writing a short claim that names a source and a limit. We practice on surfaces you already meet.

If you used *History for Little Thinkers*, *History for Young Minds*, *History for Emerging Adults*, or *History for Homeschooling* at a kitchen table, one pointer each, then this desk and this commute. Those books keep a parent in the room or a grade-by-grade survey. This book does not. You are the learner. This is not a reprint of those lesson banks.

Publius owns the Federalist newspaper war at book length. One pointer for a Federalist deep week — then stay here. *Critical Thinking for Adults* owns present-tense reasons and myside craft. One pointer, then history. *Math Refresher for Adults* owns the commute/desk/weekend architecture and the rust rule. Literacy is not numeracy. One pointer, then history.

What you will actually get

Each teaching chapter does seven jobs, always in the same order. You will learn why this week's looking move is worth the struggle, and understand it yourself. You will get a session you can run this week: named try-its across **commute/lunch**, **desk-or-shift**, and **weekend deep sit**, and a talk-to-yourself box. Tools stay optional. "Done enough" places by skill, not age or diploma year.

The seven teaching chapters follow the looking-move strip, not twelve thin survey labels: what civic literacy looks like for adults (primary before feed); reading a primary; feed versus primary; two accounts and corroboration; civic texts as documents; context, maps, and timelines on the go; talking and writing a short civic claim. Keeping track and resources come last.

Today you can put a pamphlet, a plaque, a credited excerpt, or a feed card on the table, name who made it and whether you are looking at the piece or at a feed about the piece, try a parallel item, and leave one exit sticky.

⁴National Mathematics Advisory Panel, *Foundations for Success* (2008), Finding 15 — adult flip, continuity from *Math Refresher for Adults*: place by skill strip, not "too old." Diploma year is not current looking skill.

What this book will not do

This book will not hand you 180 days of worksheets. Coverage is a map. Depth is the hour.⁵

It will not treat rust as destiny, a feed summary as the source, or naming three branches as graduation. It will not use teen test percentages as if they measured working adults. It will not invent History Refresh for Adults I, Emerging Adults History I, or a certificate of civic literacy. The promise is a path through ordinary civic life — not a fake diploma.

It is not a reprint of the school-age history manuals named above, and it is not a sequel to *Critical Thinking for Adults* or *Math Refresher for Adults*. It is not a curriculum sales pitch or a guaranteed score. It is not a culture-war pamphlet, a campaign speech, or a Federalist monograph. It is not a weekly AP document dump.

It is not medical advice, lending advice, or campaign speech dressed as civic literacy. We practice leaving a pamphlet, a plaque, a museum label, and a short credited civic excerpt. Live controversy stays off this table.

The promise

If you only remember one sentence, remember this: a path through ordinary adult civic life is the promise. A fake certificate is not.

Age is not placement. Diploma year is not a window that closed.

Three things have to hold. You understand today's looking move well enough to hear a wrong turn — including from yourself. You retrieve, look at a credited piece, and try a parallel item before any tool finishes the attempt. Any helper — including an AI tool — stays a supplement you host and constrain, not a partner for the first attempt, not a generated primary, not a model summary offered as the source, not a secret friend, and not a paste of proprietary workplace data into a public chat.

You can do this. You do not have to know next week's move today. You have to know this week's move well enough to sit still while you struggle, then ask one

⁵Wineburg, "Crazy for History" (2004): light-rail coverage leaves few traces. Depth is the hour.

good self-question. Start here. Read *How to Use This Book This Week*, then the five things, then *The History Refresh Hour*. Open the chapter that matches the looking move in front of you. You will have something to try on the commute, and something to try in a deeper sit. We can do this.

How to Use This Book This Week

Start at the looking move in front of you, not on page one because a diploma year said so.

This book is a handbook you open to this week's looking-move strip, not a novel. Teaching chapters run the strip from primary-before-feed through a short civic claim. Keeping track and resources come last. Context bands — **commute/lunch**, **desk-or-shift**, and **weekend deep sit** — live *inside* each chapter. They tell you the grain of the same idea, not where *you* sit by age.

This book does not replace a transcript if you need credit, or a method that already holds. If something is working, keep it. The title is the skill you are rebuilding — not History Refresh for Adults I.⁶

Pick the chapter by looking move, not by birthday

Open the chapter you think is right. Skip to **What “done enough” looks like** at the end of the *previous* chapter, or to **If it isn't clicking** in the one you opened. If you can already do those checks unaided, you are too early in that chapter. If the checks from two chapters back are still failing, drop back.

If every caption still feels like the event, you are still in the first looking strip, whatever your diploma.⁷ If you cannot yet cover a body until who / when / for

⁶Dated looking note; annotated excerpt; two-source card; looking-move strip log; optional CLEP report. Never History Refresh for Adults I or a civic-literacy certificate. Access date: 13 September 2026.

⁷Place by looking-move strip and life demand (ballot pamphlet, workplace policy, museum visit, family argument about a founding clause), not by diploma year. NMAP Finding 15 adult flip, continuity from *Math Refresher for Adults*.

whom are said, stay. “I once took APUSH” is not placement. A binge-watched docuseries is not placement either.

If you can already do those checks unaided, skip ahead. A chapter label is a scope, not a birthday.

The strip, in order: source before body → primary before feed → Observe–Reflect–Question → corroborate two accounts → civic text as a sourced object → claim + named source + warrant. Optional CLEP sits at the edge when credit is the goal. It is not the spine.

How you use a teaching chapter

Each teaching chapter has the same seven headings, always in this order, so you always know where the explanation, the session, the named try-its, the talk-to-yourself box, and the tools box live.

Why this matters tells you what this looking move unlocks. **Understand it yourself** gives one everyday picture, one precise picture, and three to five wrong answers you should be able to hear — including from yourself.

How to try it this week assumes the session shape from *The History Refresh Hour*. It will not rebuild the hour. It will give you this week’s named try-its — at least one on the go and one in a deeper sit — and a talk-to-yourself box with an exact opening question.

Practice that actually builds it names try-its with time, materials, safety, and the move. Plaques, pamphlets, and feeds *are* the practice. They do not replace the looking structure. **Tools, including AI** is optional. The rules live once in *The History Refresh Hour*. **What “done enough” looks like** is unaided work on the strip — not a chatbot diploma.

You do not have to read the whole chapter tonight. You do have to read *this week’s* move before you put the object on the table.

The five-minute warm-up

Five minutes. Phone face down — or at least not on a feed, a key, or a chatbot. Object in reach.

1. Read today's looking move until you can say it in one sentence.
2. Look at one object yourself. Ask, out loud, who made this, when, and for whom — and whether you are looking at the piece or at a feed about the piece. Stay off any tool until you have looked.
3. Glance at the “wrong answers you should be able to hear.” Name the one you would have given last year.
4. Write one sentence you will actually ask yourself. Not a speech. Example: “Who made this, when, and for whom?” Or: “Am I looking at the piece or at a feed about the piece?”
5. Close the book to the try-it. You are ready.

If you are learning the move *while* you are stuck mid-look, you will grab the feed too soon. Prepare first.

This week's shape

Pick **one** focus looking move. Run three to five micro-sessions plus one desk sit when life allows. Optionally one weekend deep sit. Banks in the later chapters are menus, not calendars. Borrow one support bank if you need it. End the week with an exit sticky on Friday — one sentence a colleague could almost follow.

Space across days when you can. A massed Sunday dump feels productive. Spacing usually wins more for retention.⁸ If you miss Tuesday, resume from the last sticky.

Point to **Keeping track** for the file. Point to **Resources** for the next door: library and museum first; Library of Congress Free to Use; OpenStax *U.S. History*; optional CLEP if credit is the goal.⁹

⁸Dunlosky and colleagues (2013): practice testing and distributed practice rated high utility — technique ratings, not an adult-history programme evaluation. Useful study, not a promise that every adult will see the same result.

⁹Library and museum first. LOC Free to Use; OpenStax *U.S. History*. CLEP titles **\$97** plus fees; remote proctoring **\$30** on Quick Reference 2026–27. Institution sets credit. Sitting is not finishing this book.

On the go and in deeper sits

Every teaching chapter names try-its across commute/lunch, desk-or-shift, and weekend deep sit. The talk-to-yourself box travels. The live fight does not. If a workplace claim is too hot today, pick a public-domain excerpt, a labelled composite, or a pamphlet you already hold.

Sister history books stay at their tables. This book does not reprint those lesson banks. Pictures show objects. Notes live at the back.

Safety is ordinary. No public quiz. No workplace sting. No photographing strangers without consent. Noticing is not an audit. No proprietary paste into public tools. A civic try-it uses a public-domain or archive-credited text, a labelled composite, or a pamphlet you already hold.

When to skip ahead

Skip ahead when this chapter's "done enough" checklist is already true *unaided*. Slow down when the same caption-as-event grab repeats after a clear look at the credit line, or when a finished-looking chatbot summary still stands in for your attempt. **If it isn't clicking** will give you three likely causes and a next move.

A stranger-readable record is a dated looking note, an annotated excerpt, or a two-source card. Never History Refresh for Adults I. Never a chatbot certificate. Optional CLEP is a bridge when credit is the goal — not the spine.

You hold the account. Try unaided first. The full allow-and-ban list lives in *The History Refresh Hour*.

For this week: pick the chapter by looking move. Do the five-minute warm-up. Run the hour. Space across days. Stop peeking sooner than you want to.

If You Only Remember Five Things

Keep this page. The chapters will add wording, objects, and this week's questions. They will not replace these.

1. Primary before feed summary. A feed card, a podcast host recap, a news chyron, a search snippet, or a model précis is a later telling until the piece is opened.¹⁰ Library of Congress language is plain: primary sources are the raw materials of history — original documents and objects created at the time under study. Open the piece first. Then judge the card.

2. Source before body. Who made this, when, what kind of text it is, for whom, and against what problem — before the body is absorbed as slogan.¹¹ Cover the first paragraph until attribution is said. If you cannot name the maker, mark unknown. Unknown is honest. Guessing a founder because the prose sounds old is not.

3. Presentism is the mind at rest. Viewing the past only through today's map is not a kid problem that expires at eighteen. It is how the mind sits when no one rings a bell.¹² Interrupt with a their-world question: what would have to be true in *their* world; who else was in the room; what this document cannot tell you. You can understand a line without approving it. Understanding and approving are different jobs.

¹⁰Library of Congress, Teaching with Primary Sources, "Getting Started with Primary Sources," accessed 13 September 2026. Civic Online Reasoning (McGrew, Ortega, Breakstone, and Wineburg, 2017) is the feed neighbor — portable moves, school/college populations labelled, not an adult-commute trial.

¹¹Martin and Wineburg (2008): sourcing is attribution before the body. Historians sourced about **98%** of the time; AP seniors about **31%** — labelled contrast, not an adult-home effect size.

¹²Wineburg (1998): presentism is "our psychological condition at rest." Interrupt without a scold.

4. A short claim needs a named source and a named limit. “According to [credit line], ...” is the floor. Then one warrant — why that line counts. Then one limit — what this claim does not settle.¹³ Fluency without a named source is theater. A thesis without a piece on the table is a speech. Dual perspective — the other side’s best point in one sentence — when a prompt asks for it. It is not assumed.

5. Tools after you try. A helper, including an AI tool, is a supplement you host. It does not sit in the chair during the first attempt. A model summary is not a source. A generated diary is not a primary. You hold the account. COPPA’s under-13 line does not apply here — that is not a licence for a secret friend.¹⁴ A path through ordinary civic life is the promise. A fake diploma is not. There is no History Refresh for Adults I.

You look, wait, and try before the tool. You hold the account. Five things. Then sit down and try.

¹³Monte-Sano neighbor for claim and evidence. Kuhn and Udell (2007): even adults manage dual-function argument about half the time under favorable conditions — prompt it. Wilke and colleagues (2022): looking can improve without automatic transfer to democratic dispositions.

¹⁴COPPA under-13 does not apply — not a companion licence. Full AI rules live in *The History Refresh Hour*. Never History Refresh for Adults I, Emerging Adults History I, or a chatbot civic-literacy certificate.

The History Refresh Hour



Figure 2: A desk still-life: credited excerpt, honesty card, micro/desk/deep stickies, notebook, commute mug, ballot pamphlet — no people, no logos, no readable UI.

The hour has a shape. Learn it once. Later chapters will give you today's looking move. They will not rebuild this hour. When a chapter says "run the session," it

means this.

You do not need a school bell. You need the piece on the table, a try that could come out otherwise, you doing the sourcing and the looking, a record you could almost show a colleague, talk-to-yourself about who made this and what you notice, and stop. Three shapes carry the week: a **micro-session** on the commute or at lunch (~15–20 minutes), a **desk sit** (~25–40 minutes), and a **weekend deep sit** when needed (~45–75 minutes). Space them across days when you can. Cramming one Sunday feels productive. Spacing feels harder and usually wins more for retention.¹⁵ Three to five micros plus one desk sit in a week, with an occasional deep sit, is the honest ambition — not under-running of a proven adult commute history trial, because there isn't one at this grain.

Sit down having already done the five-minute warm-up from *How to Use This Book This Week*. The object changes. The shape does not.

1. Micro-session (~15–20 min, commute/lunch)

One looking move. Brief feedback. No high-stakes countdown timer as default rigor. Interruptible without shame. If the session becomes scrolling, it is not a session — set a fifteen-minute clock, one object, stop.

Retrieve yesterday's attribution sticky (2 min). Close the book. Write or say who made yesterday's piece, when, and for whom — or mark unknown. Prefer retrieve over reread.¹⁶

One short primary or one feed claim plus the primary it points at — honesty card (3 min). Name what you are holding: original, excerpt, translation, later printing, modernized spelling, screenshot, or AI-generated. A feed card is a pointer until the piece is open.

Source before body (3–4 min). Talk to yourself: who / when / what kind / for whom / against what problem. Cover the first paragraph until those are said. Then one short look.

¹⁵Dunlosky and colleagues (2013): practice testing and distributed practice rated high utility — technique ratings, not an adult-history programme evaluation. Useful study, not a promise that every adult will see the same result. Access date for URLs in these notes: 13 September 2026. Session minutes in this chapter are pedagogical design, not a national adult-history-minutes table.

¹⁶Retrieve over reread is the same house preference as *Math Refresher for Adults*. Attribution stickies are the history object.

Parallel try (4–5 min). One sentence of limit, or one other-side best point, or one “this card is a later telling because...” sticky. Hands off the key. Hands off the chatbot. If you stall: ask yourself one question, wait, hint, then look — not the reverse.

Exit sticky (2 min). One line dated: the move, one check, one wrong twin you now hear. Put the phone away.

2. Desk sit (~25–40 min)

Start from a real artifact when you can: a ballot pamphlet, a workplace policy that cites a statute, a museum caption, a news claim about a founding clause, a nonprofit explainer about an amendment. Order: the primary or statute excerpt first when it is available; then the workplace or feed layer; one lateral hop (Who is behind this? What is the evidence? What do other sources say?).¹⁷

Source before summary (5–8 min). Honesty card. Observe column only first if the object is dense.

Short look (10–15 min). Reflect and Question. One historical or civic question the text can actually speak to.

One move from another strip (5–10 min). A corroboration soft, a context sticky, or a claim-plus-warrant sentence.

Exit ticket (3–5 min). A dated note a colleague could follow. Name tomorrow’s retrieval flash.

Proprietary names and unpublished employer numbers stay off public consumer tools. Strip to a public-domain twin or use a tool your employer allows. Open *your* acceptable-use page.

¹⁷Civic Online Reasoning questions (McGrew, Ortega, Breakstone, and Wineburg, 2017): Who’s behind the information? What’s the evidence? What do other sources say? School/college task populations labelled. Portable moves, not an adult-commute trial. Wineburg and McGrew (2019): even historians can fail digital evaluation when they read vertically.

3. Weekend deep sit (~45–75 min, when needed)

One central question. Short background — five to eight minutes at most. Two or three short documents, or one denser document plus one feed. Sourcing, then corroboration, then a thin then-world. One dual-perspective sentence when the question asks for it. A claim paragraph with a named source and a named limit. Stop while a look remains.

A deep sit that becomes “finish the survey textbook” is a coverage dump wearing a weekend hat. One question deeply beats seven skimmed.

Open with a diagnostic wrong when you can — the caption treated as the event, the summary before the byline, the “they were just stupid,” the one-must-be-lying, the model précis filed as a primary. Fade scaffolds: first pass guided; second pass you withhold the gloss. Run the chapter’s “done enough” checklist. Schedule next week’s three micro cues on a calendar — not vibes.

The talk-to-yourself shape, once

Later chapters fill the exact opening. The shape lives here.

Opening question. Authentic. About today’s strip. No recitation answer already written on your page. Use one: Who made this, when, and for whom — and am I looking at the piece or at a feed about the piece? What do I notice that I didn’t expect — before I decide what it means? Is this card the evidence or a later telling? Where do these two agree — and where not — without calling a liar? What did this word mean *then*, to *whom* — as a document, not as a slogan? What would have to be true in *their* world — and where / how long as tools, not trivia? What do I claim — which named source shows it — and what does this claim not settle?

Three to five follow-ups. Pick; you do not need all five every Tuesday. Meaning: What do you mean, *later telling*? Representation: What does the header, credit line, or map show before the body? Alternative: Is there another legal reading of this line? Check: What can this source not tell me? Revise or diagnose: You may change your mind — where could someone go wrong?

How to wait alone. After you ask yourself, cover the answer or the feed. A slow three is a convention, not a sacrament — Stahl’s think-time is classroom-origin;

Rowe's wait-time is science class; neither is an adult history trial.¹⁸ After you stop mid-reason, wait again before peeking. If the silence is hard, look at the credit line, the plaque, the map, or the clock — not at the phone's answer key or the feed. Rescue at one second is still rescue. Abandonment for forty minutes of scrolling is not a micro-session.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was vague; wait-time after the question was zero; you are searching for a word; you are guessing what a textbook would want; the question was a recitation item in disguise; you offered a keyword where a looking move was asked for; you think "history person" means leave; you think a finished-looking chatbot paragraph is already a check; anxiety is eating working memory — shorten the session, do one attribution win, come back tomorrow. Your job is to pose, wait, and point back at the object — not to fill the silence with the right answer from a model summary.

You do not need five questions stacked. You do not need to perform Socrates. You do not need a live controversy. You do not photo-to-key mid-attempt.

The on-the-go try-it shape, once

Time. Fifteen to twenty minutes, then stop.

Materials. A saved feed card about a founding anniversary, a short civic excerpt with a credit line, a plaque photo you already took, a pamphlet page, a podcast-host claim you will check against a named transcript or primary.

Safety. Curious, not courtroom. No public humiliation of yourself or a colleague. No proprietary paste into public tools. No culture-war sting. Noticing is not a sting. Phone is allowed as a *surface* — not as an answer key during the attempt.

The move. Name who made this, when, and for whom. Name whether you are holding the piece or a later telling. One honesty card. One exit sticky.

Types you will meet, not a lesson bank: attribution flash; feed-card lateral hop; one-paragraph civic excerpt; plaque skim; podcast-host-versus-primary check.

¹⁸Stahl (1994), ERIC ED370885, think-time — classroom-origin. Rowe (1972) wait-time is science class. Adult translation: pause-before-lookup / pause-before-feed. Not an adult history trial.

The deeper try-it shape, once

Desk or weekend. Same safety. More room for Observe–Reflect–Question, two voices on one question, and a short claim.

Types you will meet: Observe–Reflect–Question on a short primary; two-source corroboration; amendment then-meaning sticky; museum label honesty; claim-plus-warrant paragraph; dated note a colleague could follow.

These are not the hour: a gotcha audit of a workplace; a live-controversy field trip; a 180-day worksheet dump; a generated Founder letter filed as a primary; a model summary offered as the source.

The AI rules, once

Later chapters will point here. You talk to the page and to the check. You may use a tool. A chatbot is never the only partner during the first attempt. An agent is not the history partner for the first attempt. The unaided try is still yours. You hold the account. COPPA's under-13 line does not apply to an adult reader. That is not a history birthday and not a licence for unsupervised chat or a secret friend.¹⁹

The history is on the table, the phone note, or the page: a named piece-from-then; attribution before body; two or more accounts; a claim with named sources; a presentism interrupt; civic texts as credited documents; a blank timeline or map; a short essay, a labelled op-ed draft, or a workplace-adjacent civic memo *you* drafted first. You attempt first. You hold the answer key on **YOUR** side.

After you have tried, you **may**:

- Explain this idea *to yourself* from a **named** lesson, textbook page, or credited primary (title, page, today's micro-goal).
- Ask for **extra isomorphic practice**, with answers on **YOUR** page (practice sheet plus key).
- Use a labelled **SCRIPT** only **after you tried** — a short spoken or written sequence for *you* to say, not a paragraph to copy as your essay or op-ed.
- Ask for **revision questions** after *your* claim, essay, labelled op-ed draft, or civic memo — not a rewrite as the only draft, and not “fix to publishable.”

¹⁹COPPA covers operators directed to children under 13. It does not gate this book. Holding the account is not a companion licence.

- Ask for a **hint** after an attempt. A hint is a question or a named idea, not the finished paragraph.
- Ask a tool to **diagnose work you already did** (crop to paper or note — no face).
- Use **discussion questions** you vet and ask yourself.

You **may not**:

- Paste tonight’s worksheet, civic packet, map, or employer sheet and ask the tool to complete it (**photo-to-key**).
- Ask “write my essay / op-ed” or “fix to publishable” as the only draft.
- Generate a diary, letter, or speech from then as if it were a real primary.
- Park an unsupervised chatbot as your only partner during the attempt.
- Treat “I am an adult / I hold the account / COPPA is off” as a permission slip or companion licence.
- Put a model summary on the table as the source.
- Use spoken rewrite or a voice toy to replace looking at today’s piece.
- Invent research or trust a fluent citation without opening the paper.
- Detector-grade your own unaided write-up. Detectors have mislabelled a large share of human writing as machine-written in published tests; a detector score is not a grade for your practice note.²⁰
- Paste proprietary employer data into a public consumer tool. Strip proprietary rows to invented isomorphic prompts on YOUR practice sheet, or use an enterprise tool your employer allows. Open *your* acceptable-use page. This book will not invent a federal workplace chatbot statute for you.
- Hand yourself an **agent** (Hermes Agent, Grok Bot, or any cloud-computer worker) as a history partner for the first attempt.
- Print a certificate of civic literacy from a chatbot.
- Treat a generated painting of the past as a primary (looking together is fine; filing it as evidence is not).

One mechanism sentence, labelled OFF-AGE for literacy/history, then teach.

In a high-school math field experiment (grades 9–11, nearly 1,000 students, Turkey), an unguarded chatbot made practice look better and left students worse on the test with the window closed.²¹ **Not an adult history trial. Not this history**

²⁰Liang, Yuksekogonul, Mao, Wu, and Zou, *Patterns* (2023): average false-positive rate **61.22%** on human TOEFL essays (arXiv 2304.02819). A detector score is not honesty.

²¹Bastani and colleagues, *PNAS* (2025): Turkish high-school math, grades 9–11, nearly 1,000 students. GPT Base +48% assisted practice, –17% closed exam; GPT Tutor +127% practice,

band. *Math Refresher for Adults* may call the same paper nearby for math. This book does not. The lunch-break rule it supports: the model may prepare you and the next looking page; it may not do your looking, sourcing, claim, essay, or op-ed when those are the lesson.

One looking sentence: sources do not by themselves constitute evidence; ask who made this, when, for whom, and why — on a real credited piece, not on a model summary.²²

Names, in ordinary language. Hermes 4 is a chat model. Hermes Agent is a different runtime — a computer that can keep going. Grok is a chat assistant. Grok Bot is a cloud-computer agent. A public-school partnership is a third Grok. Game artist makes pictures. None of these is a history refresher class. A chatbot answers in a window. An agent has tools and can keep going. Neither is a partner for the first attempt.

Not a secret friend. A tool that talks in the first person is still a tool. It does not get a private channel or a seat in the chair during the first attempt.

Language models invent citations. Open the source.²³ Works cited only for what you opened.

You can practice this entire book with no AI.

A life of the habit

Growing fluency is more miles on the same road. Revisit the same strip next Tuesday. Mix last week's piece into this week's warm-up. Space across days. Stop when the exit sticky is honest. Placement is by looking-move strip, not diploma year. Optional CLEP is a bridge when credit is the goal — sitting an exam is not finishing this book.²⁴ The honest pitch is *often enough that the question is familiar*.

unaided $\approx$ control. **OFF-AGE for literacy/history. Not an adult history trial.** *Math Refresher for Adults* may label the same paper ON-AGE-adjacent for math. This book does not mash that label. Numbers here are the paper's, not "what AI does to adult civics."

²²C3 Framework (NCSS, 2013) Dimension 2 History: sources do not by themselves constitute evidence. Map, not a statute, not this book's table of contents.

²³Walters and Wilder, *Scientific Reports* (2023): GPT-3.5 55% / GPT-4 18% fabricated citations; real citations still err on dates. Open the source.

²⁴CLEP History of the United States I/II, American Government, Western Civilization I/II, Social Sciences and History: \$97 each plus fees; remote proctoring \$30 on Quick Reference 2026–27.

Anxiety around founding prose you last saw in school is common. It can eat working memory. Short sessions, early attribution wins, and no countdown timer as default rigor are posture, not a therapy manual. If a session is eating you, shorten it, win one attribution item, return tomorrow.

Looking does not automatically mint citizens.²⁵ Teach looking because it is how history and civic texts work. If citizenship craft is a separate aim, point once to *Critical Thinking for Adults* or to *Publius*. Then come back to the piece.

A Tuesday, said plainly

Here is an illustration, not a reported workplace. Someone opens a saved anniversary card on the train, covers the caption, names the credit line on the linked excerpt, waits before a tidy recap, and leaves a dated line: *piece opened; card compressed the audience*. Later chapters will say: run the session as in *The History Refresh Hour*.

Institution sets credit. AP is not the adult default.

²⁵Wilke, Depaepe, and Van Nieuwenhuyse (2022): inquiry skills can improve without significant overall transfer to democratic dispositions. Teach looking. Point separately for citizenship craft.

Chapter 1 — What civic literacy looks like for adults



Figure 3: A still-life: honesty-card sticky, historic newspaper header with greek-ing, a described feed card with no product chrome, a courthouse-plaque scrap. No people. No logos. No readable UI.

Why this matters

You already meet history most days. A feed card about a founding anniversary. A ballot pamphlet in the mail. A museum caption. A courthouse plaque. A work-place sentence that “the law has always said.” The trouble is not that adults “cannot do history.” The trouble is that the feed arrives first, the credit line arrives last, and the looking move never gets a turn.

This chapter is the orientation. Later chapters will teach Observe–Reflect–Question, lateral reading, two accounts, civic texts as documents, maps and timelines, and a short civic claim. All of them lean on the same quiet skill: knowing whether you are looking at a piece from then, or at a later telling about the piece — and naming who made it, when, and for whom before the body becomes a slogan.

Civic literacy in this book is sourced looking. It is not a talent you either have or lack. It is not a three-branch flashcard you finish and frame. Named civic-fact surveys are useful as limited population context. In one recent survey, about seven in ten U.S. adults named all three branches; fewer named a majority of First Amendment rights.²⁶ In another, majorities knew Court tenure and House apportionment; fewer knew a Senate term.²⁷ Those figures describe recall items. They are not historical thinking, not this book’s pretest, and not a certificate. An adult who can source a plaque and still miss a Senate-term quiz item is not failing this book. An adult who names branches and treats every caption as the event is not done.

A large adult literacy survey sits nearby as reading stock, not as a history grade. U.S. adults 16–65 averaged 258 in literacy, with about twenty-eight in a hundred at Level 1 or below.²⁸ Dense founding prose needs short excerpts and honest scaffolds. That survey is not a promise that this book will move a score. It is a reason

²⁶Annenberg Public Policy Center, Constitution Day Civics Survey 2025: **70%** named all three branches (was **65%** in 2024); **79%** named speech among First Amendment rights; **40%** named a majority of First Amendment rights. Phone-to-internet shift in 2023 — recent figures not directly comparable to older phone eras. Access date: 13 September 2026. Labelled population context. Not this book’s pretest.

²⁷Pew Research Center, 7 November 2023 (ATP, 5–11 June 2023, n=5,115): Court tenure about **75%**; House apportionment **68%**; chamber control about **66%** / **63%**; Senate term **44%**; Electoral College tie **40%**.

²⁸NCES/IES, *Highlights from PIAAC 2023* (ages 16–65): U.S. literacy mean **258** (intl $\approx$ **260**; 2017 **271**); Level 1 or below **28%** (was **19%**). Adjacent reading stock. Not historical thinking. Not teen NAEP. Not mashed with PIAAC numeracy.

to keep Tuesday's object short.

Place yourself by looking-move strip, not by diploma year. Having sat a survey course once is not a sourcing test. Feeling rusty is ordinary. Anxiety around prose you last saw in eleventh grade is real and common; it loads working memory; it is not proof of a history gene; and this book is not a clinical protocol. Short sessions and early attribution wins belong here on purpose. Untimed looking beats a countdown timer dressed up as rigor.

What this chapter unlocks is usable order. When you can cover a body until attribution is said, and name whether today's object is the piece or a feed about the piece, the rest of the book has a floor. Feed hygiene later. Two voices later. A short claim later. Today: maker before body; primary before feed.

Rust is not failure. Refresh means rebuild usable looking and short civic claim craft. Start where the order is inverted. The rest of the book will still be there when the order holds.

One more reason this strip earns a full chapter: returners often arrive coverage-anxious ("I should restart at 1492") or quiz-fluent ("I can name the branches, so I am finished"). Coverage is a map. Depth is the hour.²⁹ Recalling a civic fact is useful context. It is not the looking move. This chapter refuses choosing sides between "I already know this" and "I am too rusty to start." You start at the object in front of you.

Looking does not automatically mint citizens.³⁰ Teach looking because it is how history and civic texts work. If citizenship craft is a separate aim, later chapters will point once to *Critical Thinking for Adults* and to *Publius*. Today the job is smaller and harder: open the piece first.

Understand it yourself

Everyday picture. Think of an anniversary week on your phone. A card arrives: a painted scene, a short caption, a date in large type. The caption feels like the event. You could share it in four seconds. You could also cover the caption, find the credit,

²⁹Wineburg, "Crazy for History" (2004): light-rail coverage leaves few traces. Depth is the hour.

³⁰Wilke, Depaepe, and Van Nieuwenhuyse (2022): inquiry skills can improve without significant overall transfer to democratic dispositions.

and open the piece the card is talking about — a letter, a clause, a newspaper page, a museum object. The first path is efficient and inverted. The second path is the hour.

Hold a mental picture of two piles. **Pile A** is the piece-from-then: a credited excerpt, a scan with a header, a statute paragraph, a plaque text, a letter with a date and a sign-off. **Pile B** is a later telling: a feed card, a podcast host recap, a search snippet, a textbook paragraph, a model précis, a generated “letter from 1776.” Civic literacy for adults starts by sorting the piles *before* you decide what the story means.

Precise picture. Source before body means attribution first: who made this, when, what kind of text it is, for whom, and against what problem — before the first paragraph is absorbed as slogan.³¹ Historians do this almost automatically in published contrasts with able seniors; the contrast is labelled school-origin, not a promise about your kitchen table. The portable habit is the order. Cover the body. Say the credit line. If the credit line is missing, mark unknown. Then look.

Primary before feed means the same order when the spark was a card. Library of Congress language is plain: primary sources are the raw materials of history — original documents and objects created at the time under study.³² A viral thread was not created at the time under study as the governing text. A model paraphrase was not. A two-sentence chyron was not. Feed literacy is a neighbor skill. It does not replace opening the piece.

Presentism is the mind at rest — including for adults.³³ Viewing 1787 only through today’s party map, or treating a textbook recap as “just the facts,” is the same rest state as a senior who overrode documents with present common sense. Interrupt without a scold. Ask what problem *they* were trying to solve. Ask who else was in the room. Ask what this document cannot tell you. You can understand a line without approving it.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear (including from yourself).

1. **“I already learned this in school / I have a degree, so I’m done.”** Diploma year is not current skill. Unused pathways rust. Civic-fact scores and literacy stock move at the population level; neither proves you are finished.

³¹Martin and Wineburg (2008): sourcing = attribution before the body. Historians about **98%**; AP seniors about **31%** — labelled contrast, not an adult-home effect size.

³²Library of Congress, Teaching with Primary Sources, “Getting Started with Primary Sources,” accessed 13 September 2026.

³³Wineburg (1998): presentism is “our psychological condition at rest.”

Place by the object in front of you. If you still absorb a caption as the event, you are still in this strip.

2. **“The caption is enough.”** The caption is a later telling until the piece is opened. Virality is not corroboration. A tidy sentence can be accurate, compressed, or wrong. You will not know which until you look.
3. **“Naming the three branches means I’m done.”** Recalling branches is a useful fact. It is not sourcing, not dual-document looking, and not this book’s finish line. The hour is not flashcard prep.
4. **“Adults don’t do presentism — that’s a kid problem.”** Presentism is how the mind sits when no one rings a bell. Age does not expire it. The repair is a their-world question, not a sermon.
5. **“The feed summary is the source.”** A summary can point. It cannot stand in for the piece. A model précis filed as evidence is the same inversion with better grammar.

Five-minute warm-up before you try. Put one object in reach — a saved anniversary card, a pamphlet page, a short civic excerpt with a credit line. Cover the body or the caption. Say who made this, when, and for whom — or mark unknown. Then say, out loud: “Am I looking at the piece or at a feed about the piece?” Glance at the wrong answers above. Name the one you would have given last year. Write the locked opening once. Close the book to the try-it. If anxiety spikes, stop after the warm-up and count it as a win. Come back for the try later the same day or tomorrow.

What “fluent” is not. A fluent recap is not a check. A fluent chatbot paragraph is not your work during the attempt. Speed without attribution is theater. Attribution without any look at the piece is a stall. Build both, in short doses, on objects you actually meet.

Common adult scars, named gently. Some of you were timed until panic. Some of you were told to “just remember the branches.” Some of you were praised for a tidy essay and never asked who made the document. None of that is a life sentence. This week’s repair is small: credit line first, piece before card, tool third. If a scar flares, shorten the session and keep the early win. You are allowed to be an adult who rebuilds a foundation without apology.

Piece versus feed-about-piece, said again. A Constitution PDF you open is the piece (still a later printing — honesty card later). A thread that quotes one clause

without a link is a feed about the piece. A museum object in front of you is the piece. The caption under it is a later telling *about* the piece — useful, credited if you are lucky, still not the object. A workplace policy that cites a statute is a later telling until the statute excerpt is open. Sort first. Then look.

Unknown is a legal answer. Many feed cards have no maker you can name in thirty seconds. Many plaques name a dedicating club and not the author of the sentence. Mark unknown. Then decide what would count as a next hop — a library catalog, a LOC page, a named archive — without turning the micro-session into a forty-minute scroll.

Podcasts and documentaries sit in pile B. A confident narrator is still a later telling. Use a show to map a question or to stay company on a commute. Then open a piece. A documentary is not a primary because the lighting is good. Chapter 3 will teach feed hygiene in full. This chapter only needs the sort.

Materials nostalgia, named once. “I did document lessons in school, so I still source” is a cousin of diploma nostalgia. Materials on a table, years ago, are not this Tuesday’s move. A classroom study of document lessons found that handing out packets did not by itself produce discussion.³⁴ Solo adults still need talk-to-yourself and an exit check that forces the order. Copy the *shape*. Leave the old packet in the past.

What this book is not asking you to become. You are not training to be a professional historian this week. You are training to hear a caption offered as the event, and to open the piece first. Dual perspective — the other side’s best point — will be prompted later. It is not assumed today. Citizenship dispositions are a separate aim. Today is order.

How to try it this week

Use the History Refresh Hour shapes you already have: a micro-session on the commute or at lunch, a desk-or-shift sit when you have a quiet surface, and a weekend deep sit when you need a longer look. This week’s strip is civic literacy as sourced looking — primary before feed; maker before body. Three to five micros plus one desk sit, with an optional deep sit, is the honest ambition — not

³⁴Reisman (2012), Reading Like a Historian: grade 11 classroom; Historical Thinking $\eta p^2 = .09$; materials did not by themselves produce discussion. Copy *shape* only. Not a commute result.

under-implementation of a proven adult-commute history trial, because there is none at that grain.

Session shape (all bands). Warm-up retrieval: cover notes; say yesterday's maker / date / audience, or mark unknown. Short model: one sourced look at a short credited excerpt (honesty card, then who / when / for whom). Your attempt: a parallel object — often a feed card you will treat as a pointer. One good self-question (the locked opening below). Mixed practice only after a few blocked wins — a piece, then a card, then a plaque. Exit sticky: *piece / feed-about-piece; I named ____ / I marked unknown; next cue is ____.*

Fade help on purpose. First item: you may glance at a credit line after your guess. Second item: cover the body until attribution is said. Third item: unaided, then check. When to stop looking up: when you have named maker-or-unknown and piece-or-feed twice in a row on objects you used to swallow whole.

Commute / lunch (about 15–20 minutes). Materials: phone note or scrap; one saved feed card about a historic or civic claim; optionally one short public-domain excerpt the card points at. Safety: no public quiz that humiliates you or a colleague; no photographing someone else's screen as a sting; noticing is not an audit; no proprietary paste. The move: cover the caption; name what kind of object you are holding; say who / when / for whom or mark unknown; open the piece if you have it before you decide the card is enough. Say the locked opening once. Wait. Exit sticky before you scroll. If the session becomes scrolling, it stopped being a session — set a 15-minute boundary and one object.

Desk or shift (about 25–40 minutes). Materials: a real pamphlet you already hold, a workplace policy that cites a statute (public language only), a museum caption photo, or a news claim about a founding clause plus the clause. Safety: strip proprietary names; invent an isomorphic twin if the real memo is sensitive; open *your* acceptable-use page before any public tool. The move: primary or statute excerpt first when available; then the pamphlet or feed layer; one honesty card; one dated note a colleague could follow. Include one interloper only after two clean attributions: a feed card slipped into the same sit so you choose the move.

Weekend deep sit (about 45–75 minutes when needed). Materials: one central question; one short background card (five to eight minutes at most); two short objects — one piece, one later telling; calendar for next week's three micro cues. The move: sort the piles; source each; answer only what the piece can answer;

write one “later telling because...” sentence about the card. Schedule Mon/Tue/Fri micro cues — spacing across days beats one heroic dump. A useful technique rating supports distributing practice; it is not a promise that every adult will see the same result.³⁵

Exact wording you can say to yourself. “Who made this, when, and for whom — and am I looking at the piece or at a feed about the piece?” Then wait. Cover the answer or the feed. A slow three is a convention, not a sacrament (classroom think-time research is the neighbor; this is an adult pause-before-lookup, not a history trial).³⁶ Look at the credit line or the plaque, not at a chatbot recap.

First try-it this week (on the go). Cover one caption. Name maker-or-unknown. Name piece or feed-about-piece. That is enough for a micro-session. On a deeper sit later: a pamphlet or statute excerpt first, then the layer that pointed at it, then a dated note.

A sample micro, narrated once (composite). You open a note on the train. Retrieval: “Who made yesterday’s plaque sentence?” Dedicating club named; author of the sentence unknown. Solved twin glance: yesterday you covered a Preamble phrase until you said “Philadelphia, 1787, a convention writing a frame” — first useful move was the credit, not the recitation. Parallel try: anniversary card about a rights line. Cover caption. Card is a later telling. Open a public-domain amendment text for sixty seconds. Exit sticky: *feed-about-piece; piece opened; next cue is pamphlet header*. Close the note. That is a History Refresh Hour micro — not a chapter binge.

Worked pictures you can steal (then put away)

These are composite illustrations, not reported workplaces. Use them as models. Then close them and try a parallel item unaided.

Picture 1 — Two piles on a napkin. Draw two boxes. Label *A piece-from-then* and *B later telling*. Drop four scraps: a credited letter excerpt (A); a feed card about the letter (B); a museum object (A); the caption under it (B). Say aloud:

³⁵Dunlosky and colleagues (2013): distributed practice rated high utility — technique rating, not an adult-history programme evaluation. Useful study, not a promise that every adult will see the same result.

³⁶Stahl (1994) think-time, classroom-origin; Rowe (1972) is science class. Adult translation: pause-before-lookup / pause-before-feed.

“Sort first. Then look.” If you feel the urge to start with the tidy caption, notice that urge — captions can fool order until the piles are back.

Picture 2 — Cover-the-body autopsy. Write the wrong claim: “I already know what this says.” Cross it out. Underneath: who / when / what kind / for whom / unknown. Uncover one sentence only after those are said. The first useful move was not a plot summary. It was a credit line.

Picture 3 — Anniversary card as pointer. A card says a founding phrase “means” a present slogan. Cover the slogan. Open the phrase as a sourced object (who / when / audience). Write one limit: “This card cannot settle ____ because it never opened the line.” You are not picking a party. You are restoring order.

Picture 4 — Workplace ‘the law has always said.’ A policy sentence cites “the statute.” Open a public excerpt of the cited section first — or mark that you have not. Then read the policy as a later telling. Dated note: *statute opened / not opened; policy compresses ____.* Proprietary rows stay off public chat.

Picture 5 — Three-branch flashcard as context, not graduation. Write the three branches on a sticky if you want. Then write underneath: “Recall $\neq$ looking.” Put a plaque photo on the table. Source the plaque. The sticky was optional context. The plaque was the hour.

Picture 6 — Museum caption honesty (preview). Stand in front of an object, or a photo of one you already took. Read the object first — material, wear, size, a date if stamped. Then read the label as a later telling. One honesty sentence: “The label claims ; *the object shows* .” Full museum-label practice can wait for an out-of-home week. The sort can start now.

Before each picture becomes a crutch, close the page and invent a parallel: a different card; a different pamphlet header; a different plaque. Struggle before rescue. Try unaided first.

Practice that actually builds it

Blocked practice first: several attribution flashes in a row, then several piece-or-feed sorts. Mixed practice later: a piece, a card, a plaque, a pamphlet header — so you have to choose the move. Plaques, pamphlets, and feeds *are* the practice surfaces. They do not replace the looking structure.

Knowledge first, then fluency on the same objects. Hearing a wrong reason — including your own — then asking a better question, then naming a better reason, is the work.

Talk-to-yourself box

Opening (locked): “Who made this, when, and for whom — and am I looking at the piece or at a feed about the piece?”

Follow-ups: 1. What do you mean, *later telling*? 2. What does the header or credit line show before the body? 3. Is there another legal reading of this line once the maker is named? 4. What can this source not tell me? 5. You may change your mind — where could someone go wrong?

How to wait alone. After you ask, cover the answer or the feed. Count a slow three. If you stop mid-reason, wait again before peeking. Look at the credit line, the plaque, the pamphlet header, or the clock — not at the phone’s recap. Rescue at one second is still rescue. Abandonment for forty minutes of scrolling is not a micro-session.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was vague; wait-time one was zero; you are hunting for a vocabulary word instead of a maker; you are guessing what a textbook would want; you offered a branch name where a looking move was asked for; you think “history person” means leave; you think a finished-looking chatbot paragraph is already a check; anxiety is eating working memory — shorten the session, win one attribution item, come back tomorrow. Your job is to pose, wait, and point back at the object — not to fill the silence with a model summary.

Named try-its

Try-it A — Attribution flash on saved cards (commute / lunch) — AS-04

Time: 8–12 minutes.

Materials: five screenshots or cards you already saved (anniversary post, pamphlet header, plaque, news blurb, civic excerpt).

Safety: private; no public quiz; blur faces and workplace chrome.

The move: For each, in under thirty seconds: maker / date / type / or unknown. Write five scrawls. Skipping unknown is the miss — mark it explicitly.

Try-it B — Cover the body until who / when / for whom (commute / lunch)

Time: 5–10 minutes.

Materials: one short civic excerpt with a credit line (public-domain Preamble phrase or one amendment — as a sourced object, not a pledge).

Safety: ordinary; no campaign speech as the hour.

The move: Cover the body. Say attribution. Uncover. Write one sentence: “I was looking at the piece / a later printing of the piece.” CIV-06 grain: even a beloved line still gets a sourcing card.

Try-it C — Piece or feed-about-piece sort (commute / lunch)

Time: 8–12 minutes.

Materials: five labelled-composite scraps or screenshots (illustration, not a reported workplace).

Safety: composites labelled as such; no live controversy.

The move: Sort into two piles. One honesty sentence per pile. Exit sticky: *I sorted ___ as a later telling because ____.*

Try-it D — Observe-only minute on a header (commute or desk) — AS-01

Time: 5–8 minutes.

Materials: one letter header, newspaper masthead, or plaque; notes app.

Safety: ordinary.

The move: Sixty to ninety seconds of concrete notices only — no story yet. Five notices. If you jump to “what it means,” you left Observe.

Try-it E — Pamphlet or policy as later telling (desk or shift)

Time: 20–30 minutes.

Materials: a ballot pamphlet you already hold, or a workplace policy that cites a public statute; the statute excerpt if available.

Safety: no proprietary paste into a public tool; no advice to colleagues dressed as a sting; ordinary noticing.

The move: Open the cited excerpt first when you can. Source both. Dated note a colleague could follow: maker / date / what the pamphlet compresses / one limit.

Try-it F — Civic text is still a source (desk or lunch) — CIV-06

Time: 10–15 minutes.

Materials: one beloved civic excerpt you can almost recite.

Safety: refuse pledge-theater; this is a document with makers, not a loyalty test.

The move: Run a full sourcing card anyway — genre, audience, date. Exit: one genre + audience sentence.

Try-it G — Generated / model refuse drill (commute or desk) — AS-08

Time: 8–12 minutes.

Materials: one deliberately labelled fake “primary” (a model letter marked illustration) and one real LOC or archive item.

Safety: the fake stays labelled; it never enters the evidence pile unmarked.

The move: Say the refuse lines aloud: “A generated diary is not a primary. A model summary is not the source.” Rewrite the session plan using the real item.

Try-it H — One-question look (weekend deep sit)

Time: 45–60 minutes.

Materials: one central question; one piece; one later telling; short background max 5–8 minutes; calendar.

Safety: ordinary stakes; stop while a look remains.

The move: Sort. Source. Answer only from the piece. Write “later telling because...” about the card. Schedule three micro cues for next week.

Incorrect example to diagnose (blocked, then name the error).

Someone says: “I read the anniversary caption. I know what happened.”

What went wrong: caption-as-event; feed-first reflex.

Repair: cover the caption; name the card as a later telling; open the piece or mark that you have not.

Say the repair out loud. Silence in the face of your own wrong reason is not kindness.

Second incorrect twin (for the deep sit).

Someone says: “I can name the three branches, so this week is done.”

What went wrong: recall treated as looking.

Repair: put a plaque or excerpt on the table; source it; leave the flashcard as optional context.

Mixed pair (after a few blocked wins). One attribution flash + one piece-or-feed sort + one cover-the-body sit in the same hour. The point is choosing the move, not racing. Near transfer is the honest hope: the same order on a pamphlet *and* a feed card *and* a plaque in the same week. Far transfer to an unseen domain without knowledge is not promised — vary jackets, keep structure.

How to keep a tiny record. After a micro, one dated line is enough: date; object; piece or feed-about-piece; maker-or-unknown. After a desk sit, keep the pamphlet note. After a deep sit, keep the two-pile sketch and the “later telling because...” sentence. A colleague who missed your session should almost be able to follow the note. That is the work product — not a fake certificate, not a percentile, not “History Refresh for Adults I.”

Spacing the week (seed, not a 180-day plan). Mon micro: attribution flash (AS-04). Tue micro: cover-the-body on one civic excerpt (CIV-06). Wed desk: pamphlet or policy with the cited excerpt first. Thu off or light retrieval of yesterday's sticky. Fri micro: piece-or-feed sort plus the diagnostic caption twin. Optional Sun deep sit: one-question look + calendar cues for next week. If you miss Tuesday, do not punish yourself with a double dump; resume from the last sticky. Consistency of cueing beats perfection of minutes.

Maintenance after done-enough. When this strip clears, do not ghost it. Two micros a week of retrieval plus one interloper keeps the order warm while you open Observe–Reflect–Question. Rebuild weeks return when a diagnostic wrong reappears — caption-as-event relapse, diploma-year skip urge, three-branch graduation.

If it isn't clicking

Diagnostic 1 — Diploma nostalgia.

Likely meaning: “I already learned this” is standing in for a skill check.

Next move: give yourself a three-item diagnostic — cover one body, sort one card, name one maker-or-unknown. If any item fails, stay. A forty-five-year-old who still sources before reading can deepen later chapters; a thirty-year-old who treats every caption as the event needs maker-before-body first — regardless of diploma year.³⁷ Place by strip. Shame is not pedagogy.

Diagnostic 2 — Quiz-prep reflex.

Likely meaning: Annenberg-style recall feels like the finish line because it is measurable and familiar.

Next move: write “recall $\neq$ looking” on a sticky. Put a piece on the table. Source it. Keep the fact inventory as optional context, never as this week's graduation. If you enjoy a personal curiosity baseline on a civic-fact item, label it curiosity. It is not a grade for this book.

Diagnostic 3 — Shame spiral.

Likely meaning: rust feels like a character flaw; wait-time one was zero; anxiety is eating working memory.

Next move: shorten the session; win one attribution item; stop. Point back to

³⁷NMAP Finding 15 adult flip, continuity from *Math Refresher for Adults*: place by skill, not “too old.”

the History Refresh Hour: short sessions beat marathon “prove you’re tough” sits. Come back tomorrow. Optional light calm-down before the next try is fine; this book does not promise a cure for anxiety and does not turn into therapy.

Extra signals and next moves. If you only succeed when the object looks like a worksheet, change the jacket — use a pamphlet or a plaque. If you freeze at founding prose, shorten the excerpt to one sentence and keep the sourcing card. If a marathon sit leaves you worse, you overdosed — return to the micro shape. If a chatbot paragraph already “finished” the look, you practiced fluency theater; close the window and source the piece unaided.

When to slow down. If caption-as-event returns after a good day, return to blocked pile-sorts. If anxiety spikes, cut the session in half and keep the early win.

When to go ahead. When you can cover a body until attribution is said, name piece versus feed-about-piece on ordinary objects, refuse three-branch flashcards as the week’s finish line, and leave one dated sticky, you are ready to lean into Observe–Reflect–Question on a short primary.

When to ask a human. A colleague who is good at explaining, a librarian, a tutor, or a class can help when self-talk loops. Bring a concrete object and a wrong twin, not “I’m bad at history.” Correct the reason without crushing the attempt — applied to yourself. “Never correct yourself” is not this book’s rule.

Tools, including AI

Keep tools short and late. Point back to the History Refresh Hour AI box for the full allows and bans. This chapter is not an AI policy paper.

Library of Congress Free to Use and Reuse sets are a first free surface after you know today’s move.³⁸ OpenStax *U.S. History* can sit nearby as a secondary account — label it an account, not a primary. A pamphlet you already hold beats a new app.

After you have tried: you may ask a chatbot to explain *this idea* to yourself from a named lesson (title, page, today’s micro-goal). You may ask for isomorphic practice with answers kept on *your* page. You may ask for a labelled SCRIPT —

³⁸Library of Congress Free to Use and Reuse sets; TPS analysis tool (Observe, Reflect, Question) — curiosity and observation-to-inference, not an adult RCT.

a short sequence for *you* to say, not a paragraph to copy as your work. You may ask for a hint after an attempt — a hint is not the finished answer. You may ask it to diagnose work you already did (crop to the paper — no face).

You may not photo-to-key during the attempt. You may not paste a worksheet or employer sheet and ask for completion. You may not generate a Founder letter and file it as a primary. You may not put a model summary on the table as the source. You may not ask for an op-ed as the only draft. You hold the account; unaided first. COPPA's under-13 line does not apply to you — that is not a companion licence. Strip proprietary employer data. An agent is not a first-attempt history partner. A chatbot certificate of civic literacy is receipt theater.

The lunch-break rule from the Hour still holds: the model may prepare you and the next looking page; it may not do your looking when looking is the lesson.

What “done enough” looks like

Use this looking-move checklist before you move on. Placement is by skill, not birthday and not diploma year. A chatbot certificate of civic literacy is receipt theater — this book never invents one, and never invents “History Refresh for Adults I” as a credit title.

- ☐ I can cover a body until who / when / for whom are said — or I can mark unknown honestly.
- ☐ I can name whether today's object is the piece or a feed about the piece.
- ☐ I can refuse a three-branch flashcard as this week's finish line and still put a piece on the table.
- ☐ I can hear “the caption is enough” and “I already learned this” as wrong twins, including from myself.
- ☐ I can leave one dated sticky a colleague could almost follow.
- ☐ I know the locked opening and can wait a slow three before the feed.
- ☐ My exit sticky this week names one cue for next Tuesday — not a fake diploma.

When those boxes are true *unaided*, open Chapter 2 and give a short primary the Observe minute it has been waiting for. If two boxes fail, stay. Rust is ordinary. The plaque will still be there on Thursday.

Life of the habit, in one line: revisit this strip next Tuesday; mix last week's card

into the warm-up; space across days. The file you keep lives in *Keeping track*. The session rhythm already lives in *The History Refresh Hour*.

Chapter 2 — Reading a primary



Figure 4: A still-life: letter header and sign-off on a scrap, honesty-card sticky (original / excerpt / later printing / screenshot / AI-generated), Observe–Reflect–Question columns on a dated notebook. No people. No logos. No readable UI.

Why this matters

Chapter 1 restored order: maker before body; piece before feed. This chapter teaches the look itself. Without a way to stay with a short credited piece — and without an honesty card that says what kind of reproduction you are holding — a denser adult information diet flips the order again. The body arrives first. The maker never does. The snippet feels incomplete, so a recap fills the hole. A model précis fills it faster.

Library of Congress Teaching with Primary Sources calls primary sources the raw materials of history — original documents and objects created at the time under study.³⁹ Analysis, they say, can prompt curiosity. Students move from concrete observations and facts to questioning and making inferences. Sources are incomplete snippets. That incompleteness is a feature. It forces a further question. It is not a defect you repair by grabbing a tidy summary.

What this chapter unlocks is a usable look on a Tuesday. Observe for a minute before you decide what it means. Reflect with a because-link to something you actually saw. Question what the piece can and cannot answer. Fill an honesty card so a later printing, a translation, a screenshot, or a generated letter cannot sneak into the evidence pile unmarked.

Adults already consume long recaps. A podcast host can sound like an archive. An encyclopedia paragraph can feel like “just the facts.” A chatbot can write a Founder letter in the time it takes to wait for a train. None of those is the look. The look is slower and smaller. One excerpt. One question the text can actually speak to. One limitation named.

Place yourself by this move, not by diploma year. If you can already source a pamphlet and still jump from a letter’s first sentence to a moral, you are still in Observe. If you can sit with a header for sixty seconds and then name one thing the text cannot tell you, you are ready to borrow a second account next chapter — after this week’s honesty card is a habit.

Rust is ordinary here too. Many adults last annotated a document in a survey course. The muscle is not gone. The order is rusty. Short sessions and one unexpected notice beat a Sunday packet dump.

³⁹Library of Congress, Teaching with Primary Sources, “Getting Started with Primary Sources,” accessed 13 September 2026: primaries as “the raw materials of history”; incomplete snippets; Observe, Reflect, Question. Curiosity and observation-to-inference. Not an adult RCT.

Looking still does not mint citizens. A careful Observe column is not a virtue badge. It is how you keep your own mind from writing the story before the piece has spoken. That is worth the struggle for ordinary adult civic life — a museum afternoon, a pamphlet night, a workplace claim that points at a statute, a family argument that cites “history.”

Understand it yourself

Everyday picture. Think of a letter on the table — or a scan of one. Your eye wants the news in the first paragraph. The useful adult habit is the opposite of inbox skimming. Read the header first: who is writing, to whom, from where, on what date if the date is there, how they sign off. Hypothesize the audience. Then read the body. Then revise the hypothesis. A petition, a private note, a public open letter, and a bureaucratic request are different kinds of objects even when the ink looks similar.

Hold a mental picture of three columns on a scrap of paper: **Observe, Reflect, Question.** Observe is what you can point at — words, marks, layout, a stain, a printed header, a crossed-out line. Reflect is a hypothesis tied to a notice: “I think ____ because I saw ____.” Question is what you would need next — and what this piece cannot settle. If Reflect starts before Observe has five concrete notices, you are sermonizing. If Question is a gotcha for a present opponent, you left the piece.

Precise picture. Observe–Reflect–Question is the Library of Congress analysis tool, aged into adult self-study.⁴⁰ It is not an independent-historian exam. It is not an adult trial. It is a way to move from what is on the page to a reasoned inference without skipping the page.

An honesty card sits beside the columns. Name what you are actually holding:

- original or high-quality scan of an original
- excerpt (how much is missing?)
- translation (whose?)
- later printing or reprint
- modernized spelling or punctuation
- screenshot of a feed (not the underlying page)
- memoir written decades later

⁴⁰Same LOC TPS analysis tool. Careful selection and planning still apply when you select your own Tuesday excerpt.

- textbook or encyclopedia paragraph (a secondary account)
- AI-generated text or image (not a primary from the past)

A primary is created at the time under study. A secondary retells, analyzes, or interprets at a distance. Both can be useful. They are not interchangeable. A textbook paragraph is an account with a publisher and a year — source it as an account. It is not automatically truer than a letter, and a letter is not automatically truer in every respect. The honesty card keeps those jobs from collapsing.

Incomplete snippets are the point. A one-page excerpt cannot tell you “what the decade thought.” It can tell you what this maker, on this occasion, offered this audience. Name the limit. Then decide whether you need a second piece — later, not as a panic recap.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear (including from yourself).

1. **“I’ll summarize first, then glance at the byline.”** Summary-as-floor. The tidy story becomes the knowledge. Looking never starts. Repair: cover the body; header first; one limitation.
2. **“The encyclopedia paragraph is the primary.”** It is an account. Source the publisher and year. Compare it to a piece from then when you can. Notice compression. The encyclopedia can be careful and still not be the raw material.
3. **“This generated Founder letter is close enough to use as a source.”** A chatbot in a historical voice was not created at the time under study.⁴¹ Label it fiction if you use it as a prop. Never file it under sources. Adults can type a prompt. That does not mint an archive.
4. **“I already know what it means — skip Observe.”** Then you will see what you expected. The locked opening this week exists to interrupt that. What do you notice that you *didn’t* expect — before you decide what it means?
5. **“If the snippet is incomplete, a model summary can finish it.”** A model summary is another later telling. It can prepare a next page after you tried. It cannot stand in for the look that is the lesson.

Five-minute warm-up before you try. Put one short credited excerpt in reach — a letter header, a newspaper masthead, a public-domain speech opening, a LOC

⁴¹Walters and Wilder, *Scientific Reports* (2023): fluent citations can be fabricated. Open the source. A generated letter is not a source.

image with a record page. Set a sixty-second timer. Observe only. Write five concrete notices. Do not interpret yet. Then fill one honesty-card line: original / excerpt / later printing / screenshot / other. Say the locked opening once. Close the book to the try-it. If the page feels dense, shorten the excerpt. PIAAC literacy stock is why this book keeps objects short — not as a grade for you, as a design courtesy.⁴²

What “fluent” is not. A fluent plot summary is not a check. A fluent chatbot précis is not your Observe column. Speed without notices is theater. Notices without any Reflect will stall you on a noisy commute. Build both. Question last, and keep it answerable.

The attribution ladder, said plainly. Start with what the object itself states: a printed name, a date, a place, a masthead, a sign-off. Climb one rung if needed: the archive record, the LOC bibliographic line, the pamphlet’s own title page. Stop before you invent a famous author because the prose “sounds like” one.⁴³ Mark unknown when the rung is missing. Unknown plus a next hop is adult work. A guessed founder is fan fiction.

Reproduction tells. A later printing may modernize spelling. A textbook crop may cut the masthead. A screenshot may hide the URL and the date you captured it. An AI image may look “old” and still be new. Sort by reproduction type *before* you trust the scene. Chapter 3 will teach leaving a webpage. This chapter only needs you to say what kind of copy is in your hand.

What counts as a source this week. A credited piece-from-then you can point at. A labelled secondary account you treat as an account. A feed card you have already marked as a later telling — useful as a pointer, not as the look. A generated letter does not count. A model summary does not count. A painting the model made of a battle does not count as a primary, even if looking at it together is a fine warm-up *after* you name it as made this week.

Common adult scars, named gently. Some of you were told to find the “main idea” before you were allowed to notice the odd word. Some of you were handed a packet of five documents and a quiz. Some of you were praised for a moral and never asked what the text could not answer. None of that is a life sentence. This

⁴²NCES/IES, *Highlights from PIAAC 2023*: U.S. literacy mean **258**; Level 1 or below **28%**. Adjacent reading stock. Not historical thinking. Not a promise this book moves a score.

⁴³Martin and Wineburg (2008): attribution before body. Labelled contrast (historians ~**98%** / AP seniors ~**31%**), not an adult-home effect size.

week's repair is small: sixty seconds of notices; one honesty card; one limit. If a scar flares, shorten the excerpt and keep the early win.

Incomplete snippets as mercy. A one-paragraph letter cannot carry a century. That is a relief, not a failure. LOC language treats the hole as a reason to ask a further question.⁴⁴ You do not owe the book a finished story. You owe the piece one honest look and one named limit. If the hole makes you anxious, write the limit first: "This excerpt cannot tell me ____." Then Observe. The recap can wait.

Memoir written later is a special honesty-card line. A person who was there may write fifty years later. That is still a source. It is not the same kind of source as a same-week letter. Flag "written later" on the card. Chapter 6 will treat process duration and later-flag more fully. Today, the flag is enough to keep the look honest.

Dual perspective is not this week's exit ticket. If a second voice appears on the weekend, list one agree and one differ without liar language. You are not required to produce an unprompted dual-function paragraph. Even adults manage that about half the time under favorable conditions; civic fights are not easy.⁴⁵ Prompt it when the chapter asks. Do not assume it.

How to try it this week

Use the History Refresh Hour shapes. This week's strip is reading a primary: Observe–Reflect–Question plus an honesty card. Three to five micros plus one desk sit, with an optional deep sit, is the honest ambition — not under-implementation of a proven adult-commute history trial, because there is none at that grain.

Session shape (all bands). Warm-up retrieval: cover notes; say five notices from yesterday's piece, or redo sixty seconds on a header. Short model: one sourced look (honesty card → Observe 60 seconds → one because-link → one thing the text cannot answer). Your attempt: a parallel excerpt, new object, same move.

⁴⁴Library of Congress, Teaching with Primary Sources, "Getting Started with Primary Sources," accessed 13 September 2026: primaries as "the raw materials of history"; incomplete snippets; Observe, Reflect, Question. Curiosity and observation-to-inference. Not an adult RCT.

⁴⁵Kuhn and Udell (2007): coordinating own and other perspectives — adults succeed at dual-function arguments about half the time when content is not demanding. Prompt later; do not assume this week.

One good self-question (the locked opening below). Mixed practice only after a few blocked Observe wins — then add Reflect, then a Question column. Exit sticky: *honesty card = ____ ; one unexpected notice; this source can / cannot tell me ____.*

Fade help on purpose. First item: you may use a labelled analysis grid. Second item: Observe unaided, then Reflect. Third item: unaided through one limit, then check. When to stop looking up: when you have one unexpected notice and one named limitation twice in a row without a recap finishing the attempt.

Commute / lunch (about 15–20 minutes). Materials: phone note; one short excerpt ≤200 words with a credit line, or one letter header / masthead image from a public archive. Safety: no public quiz; no proprietary paste; phone is a surface, not a key. The move: honesty card; Observe 60 seconds; answer *only* one question the text can speak to; note what it cannot answer (DOC-01 grain). Say the locked opening once. Wait. Exit sticky before you scroll.

Desk or shift (about 25–40 minutes). Materials: a letter or petition with salutation and sign-off; or a historic newspaper page with masthead visible (Chronicling America / LOC / library database); scratch ORQ grid. Safety: ordinary; paywalled blur without provenance is a weak object — pick a credited page; no culture-war cartoon as a gotcha. The move: header or masthead before body (DOC-03 / DOC-02). Hypothesize audience; read; revise. Fill Observe, then two because-links (AS-02), then three questions ranked by answerability (AS-03). Dated note.

Weekend deep sit (about 45–75 minutes when needed). Materials: one historic newspaper voice or two short sources on one question; one textbook or encyclopedia paragraph on the same topic; honesty cards for each; calendar. The move: masthead and layout first (DOC-02); optional invitation to next chapter's corroboration — list one agree and one differ without liar language if a second voice is on the table (AS-07). Label the textbook as an account (DOC-07). Name compression. Stop while a look remains. Schedule next week's three micro cues.

Exact wording you can say to yourself. “What do I notice that I didn't expect — before I decide what it means?” Then wait. Cover the recap and the feed. A slow three is a convention, not a sacrament.⁴⁶ Look at the header, the ink, the layout, or the clock — not at a model précis.

⁴⁶Stahl (1994) think-time, classroom-origin; Rowe (1972) is science class. Adult translation: pause-before-lookup / pause-before-feed. Not an adult history trial.

First try-it this week (on the go). One question, one excerpt, honesty card, sixty seconds of Observe, one cannot-tell-me sentence. That is enough for a micro-session. On a deeper sit later: letter header before body, or newspaper voice with the masthead in the frame.

A sample micro, narrated once (composite). You open a LOC letter excerpt on the train. Honesty card: excerpt; later digital scan; English original. Retrieval: yesterday's five notices on a masthead. Observe now: unexpected cross-out; place name you did not expect; sign-off colder than the greeting. Reflect: "I think the audience is official because the sign-off is formal — I saw the title under the name." Question: what the letter cannot tell you about anyone who never wrote back. Exit sticky: *excerpt/scan; unexpected cross-out; cannot tell me the reply*. Close the note. That is the look — not a chapter binge.

Worked pictures you can steal (then put away)

These are composite illustrations, not reported workplaces. Use them as models. Then close them and try a parallel item unaided.

Picture 1 — Letter header before body. Cover everything below the greeting. Write: writer, addressee, date if present, place if present, sign-off guessed from layout. Uncover. Revise one line. If you skipped to the news, you practiced inbox habit, not DOC-03.

Picture 2 — Observe-only minute. A historic newspaper page. Masthead, date, city, one headline shape, one advertisement border — five notices, no story. If you wrote "bias" in minute one, you jumped to Reflect without a because.

Picture 3 — Honesty-card sort. Four scraps: a LOC scan with a record line; a textbook crop missing the masthead; a screenshot of a thread; a labelled generated "1776 letter." Sort before labels are revealed, then check. The generated letter never enters pile A.

Picture 4 — One question the text can answer. Question on the table: "What does this speaker ask the audience to do?" Excerpt: a public-domain speech paragraph. Answer only from the paragraph. Then: "This source cannot tell me whether anyone did it." DOC-01 exit.

Picture 5 — Encyclopedia as an account. One encyclopedia paragraph on the week's topic; one short primary on the same topic. Source the encyclopedia (pub-

lisher/year). Note one compression the primary still shows. The encyclopedia is not a villain. It is a later telling with a name.

Picture 6 — Cartoon after Observe. One historic cartoon with creator and date if known. Symbols and words first. Issue and audience second. Context card *after* Observe — not before, or you will see only what the card primed.⁴⁷ You are not hunting a present opponent.

Before each picture becomes a crutch, close the page and invent a parallel excerpt. Struggle before rescue. Try unaided first.

Practice that actually builds it

Blocked practice first: several Observe-only minutes, then several honesty-card sorts. Mixed practice later: a letter header, a masthead, a speech excerpt, a textbook paragraph labelled account — so you have to choose the move. Documents and images *are* the practice. They do not replace the columns.

Knowledge first, then fluency on the same objects. Hearing a wrong reason — including your own — then asking a better question, then naming a better reason, is the work.

Talk-to-yourself box

Opening (locked): “What do I notice that I didn’t expect — before I decide what it means?”

Follow-ups: 1. What do you mean, *notice* — can you point at it on the page? 2. What does the header, credit line, or layout show before the body? 3. Is there another legal reading of this line once the unexpected notice is included? 4. What can this source not tell me? 5. You may change your mind — where could someone go wrong?

How to wait alone. After you ask, cover the recap and the feed. Count a slow three. If you stop mid-reason, wait again before peeking. Look at the credit line, the header, the image, or the clock — not at a chatbot précis. Rescue at one second is still rescue. Abandonment for forty minutes of scrolling is not a micro-session.

⁴⁷LOC teacher’s guides for analyzing newspapers and political cartoons inform header-first and symbol-first order. Portable *shape*, school-labelled origin.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was vague; wait-time one was zero; you are hunting for a theme word instead of a notice; you are guessing what a textbook would want; the question was a recitation item in disguise; you offered a moral where an Observe was asked for; you think “history person” means leave; you think a finished-looking chatbot paragraph is already a check; anxiety is eating working memory — shorten the session, win five concrete notices, come back tomorrow. Your job is to pose, wait, and point back at the object — not to fill the silence with a model summary.

Named try-its

Try-it A — One question, one excerpt (commute / lunch) — DOC-01

Time: 12–18 minutes.

Materials: one short primary excerpt (≤ 1 page or ≤ 200 words) with clear attribution; one historical question the text can actually speak to.

Safety: public-domain or archive-credited; no live controversy as the question.

The move: Honesty card → Observe 60 seconds → read → answer *only* the question from the text → note what the text cannot answer. Exit: “This source can / cannot tell me ___ because ___.” Refuse a packet of five documents.

Try-it B — Observe-only minute (commute / lunch) — AS-01

Time: 5–8 minutes.

Materials: ORQ grid (paper or notes); one source.

Safety: ordinary.

The move: 60–90 seconds Observe only — no story yet. Exit: five concrete notices. If Reflect opinions appear, cross them out and return to the page.

Try-it C — Letter header before body (commute flash + desk) — DOC-03

Time: 10–20 minutes.

Materials: letter or petition excerpt with salutation and sign-off; date if known.

Safety: ordinary.

The move: Header and signatory first; hypothesize audience; then body; revise hypothesis. Exit: audience sticky plus one revised note. Inbox skimming applied to the letter is the miss.

Try-it D — Attribution flash (commute / lunch) — AS-04

Time: 8–12 minutes.

Materials: five screenshots or cards.

Safety: blur workplace chrome; private.

The move: Maker / date / type / unknown in under thirty seconds each. Exit: five scrawls. Unknown must be marked, not skipped.

Try-it E — Reproduction honesty sort (desk or shift) — AS-05

Time: 15–25 minutes.

Materials: a mix of original scan, reprint, textbook crop, screenshot, and a labelled AI image (labels revealed after the sort).

Safety: generated items stay labelled after the reveal; they never enter the evidence pile unmarked.

The move: Sort by reproduction type first. Discuss tells with yourself. Exit: sort photo or list plus an error log.

Try-it F — Reflect with reason + Question column (desk) — AS-02 / AS-03

Time: 15–25 minutes.

Materials: a completed Observe list from earlier in the week.

Safety: ordinary.

The move: Two because-links: “I think ____ because I saw ____.” Then three questions ranked by answerability. Refuse vibes without notices. Refuse rhetorical gotchas.

Try-it G — Newspaper voice (desk; weekend with a second voice) — DOC-02

Time: 25–40 minutes desk; up to 60 on a weekend.

Materials: one historic newspaper page or article with masthead visible (Chronicling America / LOC / library).

Safety: modern headline outrage is not the object; a paywalled blur without provenance is a weak object.

The move: Masthead, date, and place before body. Observe layout. Read one article. Reflect audience and purpose. Exit: “Masthead told me ____ before the story.”

Weekend option: invite one agree / one differ with a second short account — still without liar language.

Try-it H — Speech excerpt soft (desk) — DOC-05

Time: 15–25 minutes.

Materials: short public-domain speech excerpt; occasion card.

Safety: no quoting out of occasion to win a feed fight.

The move: Occasion and audience before body. One claim the speaker makes. One line they offer as support, even if rhetorical. Exit: speaker–audience–purpose in three bullets.

Try-it I — Political cartoon soft (desk) — DOC-04

Time: 15–20 minutes.

Materials: one historic cartoon with creator / date / publication if known.

Safety: not a gotcha for present opponents.

The move: Observe symbols and words first; Reflect issue and audience; Question; minimal context after Observe. Exit: “Symbol X likely stands for ____ because ____.”

Try-it J — Textbook / encyclopedia is an account (desk) — DOC-07

Time: 20–30 minutes.

Materials: one textbook or encyclopedia paragraph; one primary on the same topic.

Safety: ordinary.

The move: Label the textbook as a secondary account; source publisher and year; compare; note compression. Exit: “The textbook compressed ____ that the primary still shows.” The primary is not automatically truer in every respect — name that limit too.

Try-it K — Image pair, same event (desk or weekend) — DOC-06

Time: 20–40 minutes.

Materials: two images of the same event, place, or time window; attribution for each.

Safety: ordinary; no declaration of “propaganda” without criteria.

The move: Source each. Observe differences. Ask what each framing includes or excludes. Exit: one difference that changes what a viewer might conclude.

Try-it L — Further investigation mini (commute) — AS-06

Time: 8–12 minutes.

Materials: one Question from AS-03.

Safety: ordinary; this is a plan, not a doomscroll.

The move: Name where you would look next (archive, newspaper database, map, second secondary). Exit: a two-step investigation plan. Curiosity without a next action is a stall.

Try-it M — Two pieces, one question (desk or weekend) — AS-07

Time: 25–40 minutes.

Materials: two short sources; one shared historical question.

Safety: ordinary stakes; do not ignore the piece that complicates you.

The move: Light ORQ on each. Answer only from both. Note residue. Exit: answer + residue. Full corroboration craft lives in Chapter 4; this is the invitation.

Try-it N — Generated / model refuse drill (commute or desk) — AS-08

Time: 8–12 minutes.

Materials: a deliberately labelled fake “primary”; a model summary; one real LOC or archive item.

Safety: the drill is not permission to keep fakes in the binder unmarked.

The move: Practice the refuse lines aloud. Rewrite the session plan using the real item. Exit: refuse lines written once.

Incorrect example to diagnose (blocked, then name the error).

Someone reads a letter body, writes a tidy moral, and never looks at the sign-off.

What went wrong: summary-before-byline; Observe skipped.

Repair: cover the body; header first; five notices; then one because-link.

Say the repair out loud. Silence in the face of your own wrong reason is not kindness.

Second incorrect twin (for the deep sit).

Someone files a generated “letter from camp” as archival practice because it “feels period.”

What went wrong: generated-primary-as-real.

Repair: honesty card; LOC definition; AS-08 refuse lines; replace with a credited LOC item.

Mixed pair (after a few blocked wins). One Observe-only minute + one honesty-card sort + one DOC-01 cannot-tell-me sentence in the same sit. The point is choosing the move. Near transfer is the honest hope: the same columns on a letter *and* a masthead *and* a speech excerpt in the same week.

How to keep a tiny record. After a micro: date; honesty-card word; one unexpected notice; one cannot-tell-me. After a desk sit: the ORQ grid and the audience sticky. After a deep sit: newspaper masthead note plus, if you used two voices, one agree and one differ. A colleague who missed your session should almost be able to follow the note. That is the work product — not a fake certificate, not “History Refresh for Adults I.”

Spacing the week (seed, not a calendar). Mon micro: AS-01 Observe-only. Tue micro: DOC-01 one question, one excerpt. Wed desk: DOC-03 letter header or DOC-02 masthead. Thu micro: AS-08 refuse drill or AS-04 flash. Fri exit sticky: unexpected notice + limitation. Optional weekend: DOC-02 with a second voice invitation, or DOC-07 encyclopedia-as-account. Banks are menus. You do not owe the book all fourteen try-its.

Maintenance after done-enough. When this strip clears, do not ghost it. One Observe-only minute a week keeps the column warm while Chapter 3 teaches feed versus primary. Rebuild when summary-before-byline returns, or when a model *précis* starts to feel like a source.

If it isn't clicking

Diagnostic 1 — Observation stays blank.

Likely meaning: you are waiting for a theme instead of pointing at the page; wait-time one was zero; dense prose froze the hand.

Next move: return to Observe for sixty seconds on a *header only* — masthead, greeting, sign-off, or image edge. Five concrete nouns. Shorten the excerpt. If founding prose is the freeze, PIAAC-adjacent design applies: shorter is kinder, not lesser. Come back tomorrow if anxiety is eating working memory.

Diagnostic 2 — Reflect becomes a sermon.

Likely meaning: you arrived with the moral; notices were recruited to decorate it.

Next move: require a because-link. “I think ____ because I saw ____.” If you cannot point at the page, it is not Reflect yet. Separate understanding from approving — you can describe a speaker’s ask without joining it. Present-grid only (“they were just corrupt / stupid”) is the rest state; ask what would have to be true in *their* world, then return to the notice you actually have. Full their-world work lives in Chapter 6.⁴⁸ Today, one because-link is enough.

Diagnostic 3 — Question becomes a gotcha.

Likely meaning: the question is aimed at a present opponent, or it is a recitation item in disguise.

Next move: rank three questions by answerability from *this* text. Keep the one this excerpt can touch. Send the rest to AS-06 as a next-hop plan — archive, newspaper database, map — not as a fight. Name one thing the text cannot answer, out loud.

Extra signals and next moves. If every session becomes a plot summary, cover the body again. If you only succeed on typed transcripts and freeze on handwriting or layout, spend two micros on mastheads and headers only. If a chatbot already “observed” for you, you practiced fluency theater; close the window and do sixty seconds unaided. If you keep filing later printings as originals, slow down at the

⁴⁸Wineburg (1998): presentism as mind at rest — interrupt with notices and their-world questions, not a scold.

honesty card — that card *is* the work.

When to slow down. If Observe stays blank after a good day, return to blocked header minutes. If anxiety spikes, cut the session in half and keep five notices as the win.

When to go ahead. When an honesty card is filled without fuss, one Observe lands before Reflect, one limitation is named, and you have said the generated-primary refuse once, you are ready to treat a feed card as a later telling on purpose — Chapter 3.

When to ask a human. A librarian, a colleague who is good at slowing down, a tutor, or a class can help when self-talk loops. Bring the object and a blank Observe column, not “I’m bad at documents.” Correct the reason without crushing the attempt — applied to yourself. “Never correct yourself” is not this book’s rule.

Tools, including AI

Keep tools short and late. Point back to the History Refresh Hour AI box for the full allows and bans.⁴⁹ This chapter is not an AI policy paper.

After you have tried, you may ask a tool to explain Observe–Reflect–Question *to you* from a **named** Library of Congress page (title, URL or printout, today’s micro-goal). You may ask for extra isomorphic practice — blank ORQ grids and honesty-card sorts — with answers on **YOUR** page. You may ask for a labelled SCRIPT after the try: “Cover the body. Five notices. One because. One cannot-tell-me.” You may ask for a hint after an attempt. You may ask it to diagnose an Observe list you already wrote (crop to the paper — no face).

You may not ask a tool to invent a diary, letter, or speech from then as a practice primary. You may not put a model summary on the table as the source. You may not photo-to-key a worksheet or a map. You may not ask for an op-ed as the only draft. You may not treat a generated painting as archival. You hold the account; unaided first. TTS can open access to a longer chapter; it does not replace eyes on today’s piece when looking is the lesson. Strip proprietary employer data. An agent is not a first-attempt history partner.

⁴⁹Full AI allows and bans, including Bastani et al. (2025) **OFF-AGE for literacy/history**, live in *The History Refresh Hour*. Later chapters point back.

The lunch-break rule from the Hour still holds, labelled OFF-AGE for literacy/history: the model may prepare you and the next looking page; it may not do your looking when looking is the lesson.

What “done enough” looks like

Use this looking-move checklist before you move on. Placement is by skill, not birthday and not diploma year. A chatbot certificate is receipt theater — this book never invents one.

- ☐ I filled an honesty card (original / excerpt / translation / later printing / modernized / screenshot / AI-generated / account) on this week’s object.
- ☐ I wrote one Observe column — at least five concrete notices — before I Reflect.
- ☐ I can name one limitation: what this source cannot tell me.
- ☐ I said the generated-primary refuse once, and I used a credited piece instead.
- ☐ I can hear summary-before-byline and encyclopedia-as-primary as wrong twins, including from myself.
- ☐ I know the locked opening and can wait a slow three before deciding what it means.
- ☐ My exit sticky names one unexpected notice and one next cue — not a fake diploma.

When those boxes are true *unaided*, open Chapter 3 and give a feed card the later-telling test it has been waiting for. If two boxes fail, stay. A shorter excerpt still counts. The header will still be there on Thursday.

Life of the habit, in one line: revisit one Observe-only minute next Tuesday; mix last week’s header into the warm-up; space across days.⁵⁰ Short self-checks live here and in *Keeping track*. There is no extra assessment chapter. The file you keep is the dated ORQ grid and the honesty card — a stranger could follow them.

⁵⁰Dunlosky and colleagues (2013): distributed practice rated high utility — technique rating, not an adult-history programme evaluation. Useful study, not a promise that every adult will see the same result.

Chapter 3 — Feed vs primary

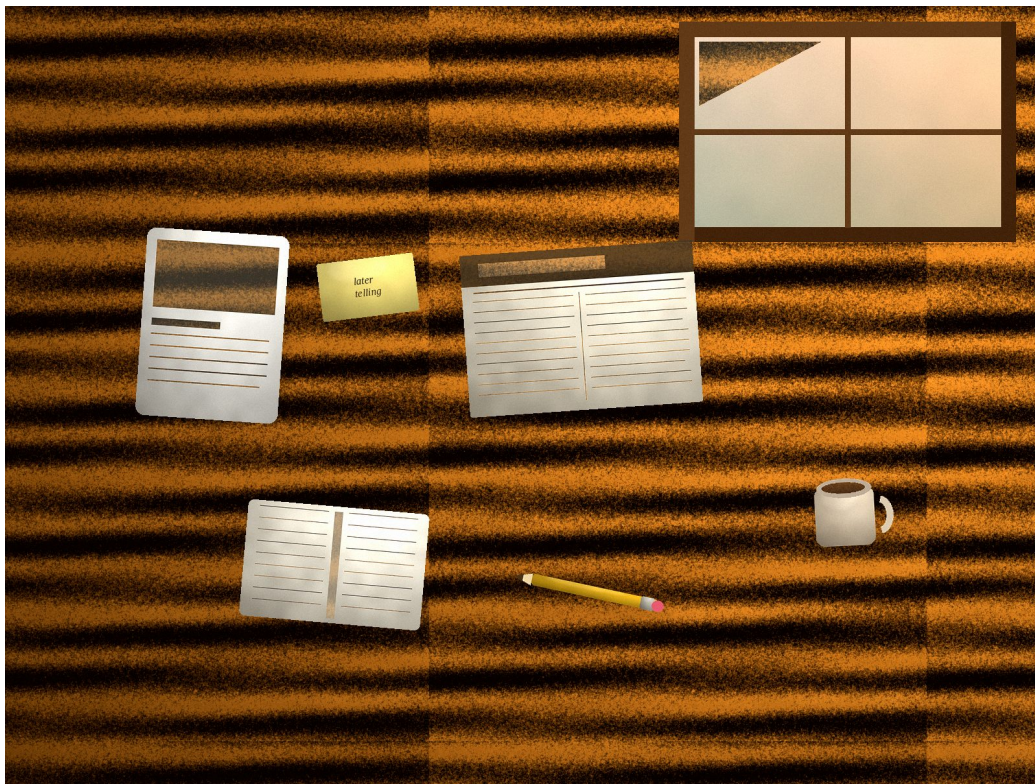


Figure 5: A still-life: phone-sized feed card described without product chrome; honesty sticky reading “later telling”; short credited newspaper scrap beside it; one new-tab note. No people. No logos. No readable UI.

Why this matters

Your default archive is often a phone. A caption arrives on the train. A host summarizes “what the Founders meant” while you wash dishes. A search snippet answers a civic question before you open any article. A chatbot offers a fluent précis of “what happened.” Each of those can be useful as a *pointer*. None of them is automatically the evidence.

This chapter owns the focus lock of the book in its adult form: **primary before feed summary**. A feed card, a push notification, a podcast host’s tidy telling, a headline, or a model summary is a **later telling** until a credited piece — or a honest hop that finds who is behind the card — comes first. Chapter 1 named the civic literacy hour. Chapter 2 taught Observe–Reflect–Question and the honesty card on a short primary. This chapter keeps the primary move and adds feed hygiene so the primary still gets a turn.

Without that flip, looking never starts. You feel informed. You share. You argue. The piece that would settle or complicate the claim stays closed. Virality feels like corroboration. A host’s compression feels like an archive. A fluent model paragraph feels like a source. Headline outrage feels like proof. Those are ordinary wrong turns, not character flaws. They are also repairable with named try-its you can run on ordinary stakes.

Civic Online Reasoning research on middle school, high school, and college students found that young people’s online reasoning needed improvement across a large task set — fifty-six tasks, thousands of responses — and taught portable moves: read laterally (open a new tab; ask who is behind this), practice click restraint, and ask what the evidence is.⁵¹ Those populations are school- and college-labelled. This is a useful study of looking moves, not a promise that every adult on a commute will see the same result, and not an adult-commute randomized trial. You borrow the *move*. You drop the classroom furniture. You apply it to the anniversary card, the workplace “history fact” forward, and the civic meme you already meet.

This chapter is not a culture-war media-studies course. It is not a substitute for looking at a historic primary when the week’s object is a document. It is not a

⁵¹McGrew, Ortega, Breakstone, and Wineburg (2017), *American Educator*: Civic Online Reasoning; 56 tasks; 7,804 responses; middle school, high school, and college populations; lateral reading, click restraint, who is behind the information. Portable *moves* for adult feed hygiene; not an adult-commute RCT. Access context for this book’s research spine: 13 September 2026.

hunt for enemies as hobby. It is hygiene so primary looking can happen: caption is not the event; one lateral hop; one minute of restraint; host summary versus transcript or primary; snippet versus body; anniversary feed versus a piece from then; model summary refused as source; headline versus body on history-adjacent news, softly.

If you can leave one civic claim this week with primary-before-feed order observed, one lateral hop recorded, and one sticky that says “later telling because...,” the chapter did its job. Place by that strip, not by whether you once took a survey course.

Many adults feel rusty around founding prose and fluent around feeds. That split is ordinary. Fluency on a phone is not the same skill as sourcing a piece. Rust on a primary is not proof you “are not a history person.” It is proof the last school hour was years ago and the feed never stopped. This chapter uses the surface you already inhabit — the card, the host, the snippet — as the practice field, then walks you back to a credited line. Commute and lunch motivate. They do not replace eyes on a piece when the claim matters.

Sister books own other rooms. *History for Emerging Adults* owns a parent Constitution-chain hour for ages 15–18 — one pointer, then teach adult refresh here. *Critical Thinking for Adults* owns myside and dual-perspective craft on present arguments — one pointer, then history looking here. *Math Refresher for Adults* loaned the commute / desk / weekend architecture and the rust-is-ordinary stance — keep PIAAC literacy separate from numeracy. *Publius* owns a Federalist deep week when you want newspaper-war depth — not this chapter’s object. FEED is adult-owned. Keep it that way.

Understand it yourself

Everyday picture. An anniversary morning. Your feed shows a commemorative image and a caption that moralizes a historic day in one sentence. You feel informed. You almost share. That feeling is the trap. The caption is a later telling — often sincere, often compressed, often modernized. The event, if you want evidence, lives in a speech, a newspaper page, a letter, a statute, a photograph with provenance, or a named archive page. The everyday question is not “Do I agree with the caption?” It is: **Is this card the evidence or a later telling?**

Precise picture. Lateral reading means you do not stay vertically inside the first

page’s self-description as gospel. You open a new tab. You ask who runs this, what kind of organization it is, whether other named sources discuss the organization or the claim. Click restraint means you wait a short minute before the reward click — write what you already know and what you would need — then click only if it is still worth it. A podcast host summary is secondary storytelling until you find the underlying document or a named historian claim and compare the compression. A search snippet is not the article. A model summary is generated secondary — never a primary, never “the source” for the week’s looking. A headline is a sales pitch for attention; the body may not carry the historical claim the headline sold.

Sourcing still comes first when you finally meet a piece: who / when / what kind / for whom / against what problem — the habit Martin and Wineburg restated from historical problem-solving research, with a labelled contrast between historians and AP seniors on how often attribution came before the body.⁵² That contrast is school research origin, portable as a *habit*, not an adult-home effect size. On a feed week, “before the body” often means before you let the caption finish your belief.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear (including from yourself).

1. “I felt informed by the caption — that’s enough.”

Belief formed before any piece opened.

What it usually means: feed-first reflex; efficiency mistaken for looking.

What you try: Cover the caption; note the image; uncover; write what evidence would be needed; open a primary or named archive page before sharing.

2. “The podcast host is the archive.”

Compression filed as primary.

What it usually means: vivid secondary storytelling stood in for a document.

What you try: Label the host summary as secondary; find one underlying line or named claim; write “Host said ; **document shows** .”

3. “The chatbot précis is basically a primary.”

Fluent generated summary filed as evidence.

What it usually means: model-summary-as-source; generate-primary temptation nearby.

⁵²Martin and Wineburg (2008) restatement of Wineburg (1991) sourcing-before-body; labelled contrast historians ~98% / AP seniors ~31% — portable habit, not adult-home effect size.

What you try: Label the output as generated secondary; check two concrete claims against a credited piece; refuse to file the précis as the week's source.

4. **“The headline outrage corroborates itself.”**

Emotional match treated as cross-check.

What it usually means: corroboration confused with agreement-in-tone.

What you try: Predict the body from the headline; read three paragraphs; note mismatch; name one primary still needed. Outrage is not a second source.

5. **“I stayed on the About page — they explained themselves.”**

Vertical reading only.

What it usually means: self-description treated as provenance.

What you try: One new tab; search the organization, not only the claim; write who is behind this — or “still unknown.”

Five-minute warm-up. Save one historic or civic claim card you already saw (screenshot OK if honesty-labelled). Cover the caption. Write three observations about image or layout. Uncover. Write: “Caption claims . ***Evidence I would need*** .” Do not share yet. Warm-up done. The locked opening for the week is already in your mouth: *Is this card the evidence or a later telling?*

Notice what the warm-up refuses. It refuses instant share. It refuses treating your first feeling as a check. It refuses letting a tool finish the sentence before you write what evidence would look like. If the card is about a remembrance day, keep the tone soft — care, not a gotcha. If the card is a workplace forward, keep stakes ordinary. If you cannot open a piece on the train, your sticky can still say “unchecked.” Unchecked is adult. Pretending the caption closed the case is not.

How to try it this week

History Refresh Hour shapes apply. This week's strip: primary before feed; later-telling sticky; one lateral hop; click restraint once; refuse model summary as source.

Session shape. Retrieve last week's attribution sticky or honesty card. One object: either a feed card treated as FEED or a short primary that answers a claim a feed made. Source before body (or hop before belief). Parallel try on a second card. Locked self-question. Mixed interloper after blocked wins (a primary sneak into

a FEED stack). Exit sticky: “later telling because...”

Commute / lunch (15–20 min). Materials: one saved card; phone note; optional second tab. Safety: private noticing, not a public sting; no proprietary employer paste into a public tool; no culture-war hunt as the try-it. Move: FEED-01 caption-not-event, or FEED-03 click-restraint minute, or FEED-05 snippet trap on a historic question you already meant to check.

Desk or shift (25–40 min). Materials: anniversary or commemorative card + one short primary from the period (speech scrap, historic newspaper header and short body, credited image); paper or note app. Safety: remembrance labelled with care — soft entry, not pamphlet hour; ordinary civic stakes. Move: FEED-06 anniversary feed vs primary (primary first, then feed); or FEED-04 host summary vs transcript/primary; or FEED-02 lateral hop soft with one honesty sentence and a stop.

Weekend deep sit (45–75 min when needed). Materials: one central question sparked by a feed; one denser primary or two short documents; optional related library/museum visit (OUT neighbor) if life allows. Move: primary looking first; feed as later telling second; thin contextualization only as needed; one dual-perspective sentence if prompted (“another fair reading of this card would be...”); claim with named source and named limit; stop while a look remains. Optional: FEED-07 model-summary refuse beside a credited piece.

Exact wording you can say to yourself.

- “Is this card the evidence or a later telling?”
- “What would I need to open before I share this?”
- “Who is behind this — and did I leave the page to find out?”
- “Host said ; **document shows** .”
- “Model claimed ; **source says** / I cannot check ____.”
- “I am not clicking yet because I need ____.”

Fade help. Caption covered for you by a habit sticky → you cover it yourself → you write the evidence-needed line before uncovering → you open a piece before any tool summarizes. Stop looking up when you can name “later telling because...” twice in a row without peeking at a model précis.

First try-it (on the go). FEED-01 on one card already in your feed. Deeper sit: FEED-06 with one primary from a free archive or OpenStax-adjacent public-domain excerpt you already hold — primary first.

Sample micro (composite). Lunch bench. Card about a founding-era anniversary — described, no product chrome. Cover caption. Notice image layout. Uncover. Sticky: *Caption claims reverence; evidence I need is a period text or named archive page.* Open a public-domain speech excerpt already bookmarked. Exit sticky: *Feed is later telling because it moralizes before I saw a line from then.* Close. No share yet.

Worked pictures you can steal (then put away)

Picture 1 — Caption is not the event (FEED-01). Cover. Observe. Uncover. Write the claim the caption makes. Write the evidence that would actually check it. Open one credited piece or mark “unchecked.” Wrong twin: sharing because the card “feels true.”

Picture 2 — Lateral hop soft (FEED-02). Unfamiliar organization linked from a feed. Do not finish the About page as gospel. New tab. Search the organization name + a neutral descriptor (who funds / what kind of group). Exit: one sentence naming who is behind the information — or “still unknown.” Stop. Wrong twin: scrolling the first site for twenty minutes and calling it research.

Picture 3 — Click restraint (FEED-03). Tempting “history fact” card. Timer 60–90 seconds. Write what you already know. Write what you would need. Then click only if still worth it. Exit: “I waited; I needed ____.”

Picture 4 — Host vs primary (FEED-04). Two minutes of a history podcast claim. Label secondary storytelling. Find a transcript line or a primary the claim rests on. Compare compression. Exit: “Host said ; **document shows** .”

Picture 5 — Snippet trap (FEED-05). Search a historic question. Top snippet looks decisive. Open two results. Source each lightly. Note disagreement. Exit: snippet vs body sticky. Refuse screenshotting the snippet as proof.

Picture 6 — Anniversary feed vs primary (FEED-06). Primary first (Observe–Reflect–Question grain from Chapter 2). Then the commemorative feed. List what the feed modernizes, omits, or moralizes. Exit: “Feed modernized ____.” Care label: remembrance, not pamphlet hour.

Picture 7 — Model summary refuse (FEED-07). App or chatbot “summary of what happened.” Label generated secondary. Check two concrete claims against a real primary or named secondary. Exit: “Model claimed ; **source says** / cannot check ____.” Never file as primary.

Picture 8 — Headline vs body (FEED-08). Current article that invokes history — ordinary stakes, not a culture-war sting. Predict body from headline. Read first three paragraphs. Note mismatch. Ask what historical claim still needs a primary. Refuse headline outrage as corroboration.

Close the pictures. Run one parallel card yourself. If your parallel card is thinner than the worked pictures, that is fine — thin cards are what the feed actually sends. The move scales down. One claim. One sticky. One hop or one opened line. That is a complete micro-session, not a failed seminar.

Practice that actually builds it

Blocked early: several caption-not-event cards; then several click-restraint minutes; then several lateral hops with a hard stop. Mixed later: a primary interloper in a FEED stack; a model-summary refuse beside a host-summary compare; a snippet trap after an anniversary desk sit.

Talk-to-yourself box

Opening (locked): “Is this card the evidence or a later telling?”

Follow-ups:

1. What do you mean, *later telling* — who told it after the fact, and how can you tell?
2. What does the header, credit line, or image show before the caption finishes your belief?
3. Is there another reading of this card that does not treat it as the event?
4. What can this card *not* tell you — even if every word feels sincere?
5. Where could someone go wrong here — and may you change your mind after a hop?

How to wait alone. After you ask, cover the caption or the feed. A slow three is a convention, not a sacrament (think-time research is classroom-origin; you translate it as pause-before-feed).⁵³ Look at the credit line you hope to find, or at the clock — not at a model answer. Rescue at one second is still rescue. Forty minutes of scrolling is not a micro-session.

⁵³Stahl (1994) think-time / Rowe (1972) wait-time — classroom-origin; adult translation = pause-before-feed / pause-before-lookup. Not an adult history RCT.

Stuck silence usually means. The question was vague (“is this true?”); wait-time one was zero; you are hunting for a vocabulary word instead of a looking move; you offered a keyword where “later telling” was asked; you think a finished-looking chatbot paragraph is already a check; anxiety is eating working memory — shorten the session, win one caption-covered sticky, come back tomorrow. Your job is to pose, wait, and point back at the card or the piece — not to fill the silence with a summary from a tool.

Named try-its

Try-it A — Caption is not the event (FEED-01) · commute / lunch

Time: 10–15 minutes.

Materials: one newsfeed or social card about a historic or civic claim; screenshot OK if honesty-labelled.

Safety: private; no share before the hop; no undercover workplace audit.

The move: Cover caption; note image/layout; uncover; ask what evidence would be needed; open a primary or reputable archive page *before* sharing. Exit: “Caption claims ; **evidence I actually checked** .”

Try-it B — Lateral hop soft (FEED-02) · micro or desk

Time: 12–20 minutes.

Materials: one unfamiliar site or organization linked from a feed; second tab.

Safety: hop to learn provenance, not to hunt enemies for sport; stop after one honesty sentence.

The move: Do not stay vertically inside the About page as gospel; open a new tab; search who runs this / funding / other named discussion of *the organization*. Exit: one sentence naming who is behind the information — or “still unknown.”

Try-it C — Click restraint minute (FEED-03) · commute / lunch

Time: 8–12 minutes.

Materials: timer; one tempting historic “fact” card.

Safety: ordinary; no doomscroll after the minute.

The move: Wait 60–90 seconds; write what you already know; write what you would need; *then* click if still worth it. Exit: “I waited; I needed ____.”

Try-it D — Podcast host vs transcript/primary (FEED-04) · desk (earbuds OK on commute if primary is pre-downloaded)

Time: 20–35 minutes.

Materials: 2–3 minutes of a history podcast summary claim; a transcript line or a

primary the claim rests on.

Safety: ordinary stakes; no live controversy as the object.

The move: Label host summary as secondary storytelling; find the underlying document or named historian claim; compare compression. Exit: “Host said ; **document shows** .” Refuse filing the podcast as archival primary.

Try-it E — Search snippet trap (FEED-05) · micro

Time: 10–15 minutes.

Materials: search results for a historic question; top snippet.

Safety: private.

The move: Snippet $\neq$ article; open two results; source each lightly; note disagreement. Exit: snippet vs body difference sticky. Refuse screenshotting the snippet as proof.

Try-it F — Anniversary feed vs primary (FEED-06) · desk

Time: 25–40 minutes.

Materials: one viral commemorative post on a public anniversary + one primary from the period.

Safety: remembrance with care; refuse turning remembrance into pamphlet hour.

The move: Primary first (DOC/AS grain); then feed; list what the feed modernizes, omits, or moralizes. Exit: “Feed modernized ____.”

Try-it G — Model summary is not a source (FEED-07) · micro or desk

Time: 15–25 minutes.

Materials: chatbot or app “summary of what happened”; one real primary or named secondary.

Safety: you hold the account; unaided looking first; no generate-primary; no proprietary paste.

The move: Label model output as generated secondary; never file as primary; check two concrete claims against a source. Exit: “Model claimed ; **source says** / cannot check ____.”

Try-it H — Headline vs body (FEED-08) · micro

Time: 10–15 minutes.

Materials: one current article that invokes history; headline vs first three paragraphs.

Safety: history-adjacent ordinary stakes; refuse culture-war sting as the try-it.

The move: Predict body from headline; read; note mismatch; ask what historical claim needs a primary. Exit: headline/body mismatch + one primary still needed. Refuse headline outrage as corroboration.

Incorrect example to diagnose.

A colleague forwards a caption: “On this day, everyone knew X.” You feel informed and almost reshare. Error type: caption-as-event / feed-first. Repair: cover the caption; write the claim; open one credited period piece or named archive page; rewrite your sticky as “later telling because the card moralizes before any line from then.” If you cannot open a piece today, mark “unchecked — not shared.”

Mixed pair. After blocked wins: FEED-01 + FEED-03 in one micro week; mid-week desk FEED-06; Friday FEED-07 interloper. Near transfer: a workplace forward about “what the law always said” treated as FEED first, then a public-domain clause or pamphlet section as the piece — ordinary stakes, not HR advice.

Spacing seed. Mon: FEED-01 + wait-before-feed. Tue: AS attribution flash on a short primary (Chapter 2 neighbor). Wed desk: FEED-06 + DOC-01. Thu: WRITE-01 source sentence first on one claim (Chapter 7 neighbor — light). Fri: exit sticky “feed is later telling because...” + diagnostic. Optional weekend: museum label honesty or library primary hunt if related (OUT neighbor).⁵⁴

Tiny record. Dated later-telling sticky; one lateral-hop sentence; one primary opened or explicitly marked unchecked. Colleague-readable. Never “History Refresh for Adults I.” Never a fake certificate of civic literacy.

Primary before feed — slowed down

Returners often remember a different choreography: see card → feel informed → decide → maybe look later. The choreography is efficient and inverted. The true story is smaller and stronger: treat the card as a pointer; put a maker, date, type, and audience (or their absence) in view; open a piece when the claim matters; only then read the feed as a later telling.

Try this drill once at a desk sit. Take one anniversary card and one short public-domain excerpt on the same day or theme.

1. Cover the card.
2. Source the primary (who / when / what kind / for whom).

⁵⁴Dunlosky and colleagues (2013): practice testing and distributed practice rated high utility as *techniques* — not an adult-history programme evaluation. Space FEED tries across days.

3. Observe–Reflect–Question lightly on the primary.
4. Uncover the card.
5. Write three lines: what the feed modernizes; what it omits; what it moralizes.
6. Exit sticky: primary-before-feed order observed — yes/no.

The contrast is the lesson. Feeling informed is not a check. Opening the piece is.

Lateral hop without doomscroll

Lateral reading fails adults in two opposite ways. One: never leave the page. Two: leave the page into an hour of tabs and call the fog “research.” The repair is time-boxed. One new tab. One question: who is behind this? One honesty sentence. Stop. If the hop reveals an advocacy group, that is useful provenance — not a licence to invent their motives, and not a substitute for checking the historic claim against a primary. If the hop ends in “still unknown,” that sentence is a win. Unknown is better than a self-description treated as gospel.

Model summary and the lunch-break rule

Point back to the History Refresh Hour AI box. After you have tried, a tool may help you explain an idea to yourself from a named page, offer isomorphic practice with *your* key, or ask revision questions after *your* note. During the attempt, a model summary is not the source. A generated diary or Founder letter is not a primary. Photo-to-key is not practice. In a high-school math field experiment (grades 9–11), an unguarded chatbot made practice look better and left students worse on the test with the window closed — labelled **OFF-AGE for literacy/history**, not an adult history RCT, and not to be blended with math-only labels elsewhere.⁵⁵ The lunch-break rule it supports: the model may prepare the next looking page; it may not do your looking, sourcing, or claim when those are the lesson.

⁵⁵Bastani and colleagues (2025), *PNAS*: high-school math field experiment, grades 9–11 — unguarded chatbot practice gains with unaided test costs. **OFF-AGE for literacy/history**. Not an adult history RCT. Lunch-break rule only: model may prepare; it may not do the looking when looking is the lesson.

Feed cluster is not a second primary

Three cards that repeat the same commemorative sentence are not three sources. They may be one telling with a copy machine. Before Chapter 4's corroboration move, practice this honesty line on a desk sit: "These cards are / are not independent because ____." If they share an image crop, a phrasing quirk, or a single upstream post, say so. Independence is a looking question, not a vibe. A pile of screenshots can still be one later telling.

Podcast and documentary as neighbors

A good history podcast can wake curiosity on a commute. A documentary can put faces and places in mind. Neither replaces a credited piece when the claim is historical. FEED-04 is the bridge: host compression on one side; transcript line or primary on the other. When the show cites a letter, open a public-domain edition or a named archive page when you can. When it cites "historians say," ask which historian and which work — then decide whether this week's hour can hold that secondary honestly. Documentaries that compress decades into a cold open are later tellings with a camera. Enjoy them. Label them. Then look.

Workplace forward, ordinary stakes

Someone sends a "fun history fact" about "what the law always said." Ordinary stakes only — not legal advice, not HR advice, not a sting. Treat the forward as FEED. Cover the caption. Ask what statute, handbook clause, or public pamphlet would check the claim. If the claim matters for your understanding, open a public text. If it is entertainment, mark "unchecked — not my looking hour." Do not paste proprietary employer language into a public chatbot to "verify." Open *your* acceptable-use page when workplace examples appear. The looking move stays the same: card is pointer; piece is evidence.

Search, snippets, and the feeling of done

Search is built to feel finished at the snippet. Your sticky fights that finish. Two results, lightly sourced, beat one snippet screenshot. Disagreement between results is not failure — it is a reason to open a primary or a named agency table. If both results are blogs summarizing each other, you still do not have independence.

Write “still need a piece from then / a named dataset / a named statute.” That sentence is adult civic literacy on a Tuesday.

What this chapter refuses (without scolding you)

You will meet people who treat virality as proof, host charm as archive, and model fluency as research. You do not need to convert them on the lunch line. You need your own order: primary before feed; hop before belief; piece before précis. This book will not rehearse live fights as content. It will not turn FEED into opposition research as virtue. It will not pretend that adulthood immunizes anyone against caption-as-event. Experts can fail digital evaluation too; the fix is still a named move, not a birthday.

A week that stays honest

Banks are menus, not calendars. A FEED-focus week might look like: Monday FEED-01 and a wait-before-feed talk turn; Tuesday a short attribution flash on a primary; Wednesday desk FEED-06; Thursday a light source sentence on one claim; Friday exit sticky plus one diagnostic repair; weekend optional related exhibit or library hunt. If life only allows three micros, keep FEED-01, one hop or restraint minute, and one refuse (model or host). Depth beats coverage. A light tour of twenty cards leaves few traces; a pattern on a few cards is what the mind can keep.

Representation before tidy story

Feeds sell tidy story. Looking asks what the representation shows before the moral lands. An image crop that hides a caption on a monument. A quote without a date. A “Founders believed” line with no named text. Your Observe minute from Chapter 2 still applies to the card as object: what do you notice that you did not expect — before you decide what it means? Then ask the Chapter 3 question: evidence or later telling? The two questions are friends. Neither is a recitation item.

If it isn't clicking

Diagnostic 1 — Lateral hop becomes doomscroll.

You open a new tab and twenty minutes later you have six tabs and no honesty sentence.

Next move: Time-box one hop (ten minutes max). Write the sentence first on a sticky: “Who is behind this: ____ / still unknown.” Close extra tabs. Stop. Schedule the primary for a desk sit, not for the same micro.

Diagnostic 2 — Click restraint feels like missing out.

Waiting sixty seconds feels like falling behind the feed.

Next move: Name one thing you are *not* clicking and why. Write “I needed ____.” If the card is still worth it after the minute, click with a purpose. FOMO is not a looking move. A micro-session that ends without a click can still be a win.

Diagnostic 3 — Model-summary temptation.

A fluent précis appears and feels like the week's work already finished.

Next move: Put a credited piece beside the précis. Check two concrete claims. Refuse the précis as source. If you used a tool to draft a summary, label it generated secondary and do the looking yourself on the piece. Point back to the Hour AI box. Shorten the session if anxiety is driving the grab.

When to slow down: new move + high-emotion anniversary — soft entry, shorter excerpt, care label. When to go ahead: you can write “later telling because...” without a tool. When to ask a human: a librarian for a primary hunt; a tutor or class if you want structured practice; a colleague only for ordinary public claims — not for proprietary data and not for a gotcha.

Correct a wrong reason without crushing the attempt — applied to yourself. “I felt informed” is a useful confession. Replace it with a sticky, not with shame. “Never correct yourself” is not this book's rule. Anxiety: short sessions, early caption-covered wins, no countdown timer as default rigor — not a therapy manual.

Tools, including AI

Keep this short. Point back to the History Refresh Hour AI box for the full allow-and-ban list.

After you try, you may: ask a tool to explain a named lesson or credited primary

to you (title, page, today’s micro-goal); generate extra isomorphic practice with answers on *your* page; ask for a labelled SCRIPT — words for *you* to say, not a paragraph to copy as your work; ask revision questions after *your* later-telling sticky; take a hint after an attempt; diagnose a note you already wrote (crop to paper — no face).

During the attempt, you may not: paste a worksheet or employer sheet for completion; treat a model summary as the source; generate a diary, letter, or speech from then as if it were real; park an unsupervised chatbot as your only partner; use photo-to-key; invent a “third eyewitness”; paste proprietary workplace data into a public consumer tool; print a civic literacy certificate from a chat.

COR-style questions — Who is behind this? What’s the evidence? What do other sources say? — are useful after the try as a checklist you apply yourself.⁵⁶ Labelled archive pages, Library of Congress Free to Use / TPS materials, and OpenStax *U.S. History* can check or explore after the try; they replace thinking when they finish the attempt for you. Podcasts and documentaries are neighbors, not primaries — FEED-04 is the bridge.

What “done enough” looks like

Before you move on, check the strip — by skill, not diploma year:

- On one civic or historic claim this week, you observed **primary-before-feed** order (piece or provenance hop before belief).
- You recorded **one lateral hop** with an honesty sentence — including “still unknown.”
- You wrote one sticky: “**later telling because...**”
- You refused at least one of: caption-as-event, host-summary-as-archive, model-summary-as-source, headline-outrage-as-corroboration.

⁵⁶McGrew, Ortega, Breakstone, and Wineburg (2017), *American Educator*: Civic Online Reasoning; 56 tasks; 7,804 responses; middle school, high school, and college populations; lateral reading, click restraint, who is behind the information. Portable *moves* for adult feed hygiene; not an adult-commute RCT. Access context for this book’s research spine: 13 September 2026.

- You can ask yourself the locked opening and wait without grabbing a précis.

A “civic literacy certificate” is a receipt someone else invented — not the work — and this book never invents one. Optional CLEP or a survey course is an edge when credit is the goal; it is not proof you finished this looking move.

Life of the habit (seed). Revisit next Tuesday with a new card. Space FEED micros across days rather than one massed Sunday dump.⁵⁷ Mix last week’s primary into a FEED stack so the interloper stays sharp. Stop while a look remains. The file you keep — later-telling stickies, hop sentences, dated notes — lives more fully in Keeping track. Place the next module by whether feed-first still owns you, not by birthday and not by “I already learned this once.”

Chapter 4 will put two accounts on one event without liar theater. You will need the FEED hygiene from this chapter when a cluster of cards pretends to be corroboration. Keep the sticky. Keep the hop. Keep opening the piece.

If this week only yields one repaired forward and one opened public-domain paragraph, that is enough to place the next sit. If the week yields twenty cards and zero pieces, the strip did not move. Honesty about dose beats a massed Sunday of scrolling labelled “research.” There is no adult commute history randomized trial at this grain. Named sessions are the ambition. Show up for the card. Leave with a sentence. Return tomorrow.

⁵⁷Dunlosky and colleagues (2013): practice testing and distributed practice rated high utility as *techniques* — not an adult-history programme evaluation. Space FEED tries across days.

Chapter 4 — Two accounts and corroboration



Figure 6: A still-life: two short credited document scraps side by side; Agree and Differ stickies; one limit note. No people. No logos. No readable UI.

Why this matters

Adult discourse often treats disagreement as proof of fraud. Two posts differ; someone must be lying. Two anniversary tellings conflict; one side is fake. A photograph and a paragraph do not match; “photos never lie,” so the text is propaganda — or the reverse. That courtroom reflex is understandable. It is also a weak looking move.

Corroboration, in the sense this book teaches, is simpler and kinder to the record. Put two short accounts of one event beside each other. Source each. List where they agree. List where they differ. Name what neither settles. Forbid “liar” as the first verb. Difference is information. Silence is sometimes information and often uncertainty. A feed cluster that copies itself is not independence. An image can show what a text cannot; a text can name what an image cannot. A witness can know an hour; a later historian can know a pattern with archives neither witness held.

Chapter 3 taught you to treat a feed card as a later telling until a piece — or a provenance hop — comes first. This chapter assumes you can open a piece. It adds a second voice. The habit is light and repeatable: same event, two voices; agree / differ / still wonder; one limitation named. It is not a weekly Document-Based Lesson dump. It is not AP exam theater. It is not a hunt for who is evil. It is not merging both voices into one tidy paragraph with the makers rubbed out.

Historians check accounts against each other as one of the core heuristics of historical problem solving — alongside sourcing and contextualization — in research that began with historians and students working the same documents.⁵⁸ Classroom programmes that scaffold excerpts around a central question supply a useful *shape* (short background, sourced looks, corroboration, close reading). That shape is portable to adult self-study when you name the move and drop the classroom furniture. A grade-11 classroom effect size is not a promise about your kitchen table or your lunch break.⁵⁹ This is a useful study of how looking can be taught, not a promise that every adult will see the same result.

⁵⁸Wineburg’s sourcing / corroboration / contextualization heuristics (1991 historical problem solving; restated in later essays). Portable adult habit: compare short accounts with makers named. School-research origin; not an adult-home effect size. Research spine access date for this book: 13 September 2026.

⁵⁹Reisman (2012) Reading Like a Historian, grade 11 classroom — shape portable (central question, short background, scaffolded excerpts, corroboration). Classroom η^2 is not a home or commute result. Useful study, not a promise that every adult will see the same result.

What this chapter unlocks is usable thickness. Ordinary adult surfaces carry it: two short news-adjacent accounts of one historic anniversary; a museum label beside a pamphlet line; a period image beside a letter scrap; a workplace “history of our trade” story beside a public report; a feed cluster beside one primary. Money, workplaces, and civic life motivate. They do not replace the looking structure. No live controversy as the object. Low-heat events first so the move can land.

If you leave one agree line and one differ line without liar language, plus one limitation named, the week did its job. Place by that strip, not by diploma year and not by how loudly you can prosecute a stranger’s post.

Rust shows up here as speed. Adults who argue for a living may be fast at prosecution and slow at mapping. Adults who avoid conflict may merge too early to keep the peace in their own head. Both patterns are ordinary. Neither is a character flaw. Both have a repair: slow the first pass; keep columns; name the question each voice answers; add a limit. You already practiced waiting before the feed. Now wait before the verdict.

Understand it yourself

Everyday picture. Two short accounts of the same street fair — composite, labelled illustration. Both say the music started late. One remembers the pie contest. One remembers the lost dog. Neither needs to be lying about the fair. Each noticed what their seat and their job made easy to notice. Corroboration starts there: match, differ, and what each account is *for*. Scale that picture to history: two newspapers on one inauguration day; a sailor’s letter and a port report; a photograph of a crowd and a paragraph naming speakers.

Precise picture. Corroboration asks: Where do these accounts thicken the record together? Where do they thin or conflict? Which question is Account A answering? Which question is Account B answering? Usefulness depends on the question you wrote down. A diary hour and a later historian’s paragraph can both be honest and still not answer the same question. A map can constrain a narrative’s geography. A silence in a source might mean genre, audience, ignorance, or strategy — mark uncertainty before you invent a conspiracy. A feed cluster is not corroboration if the cards are dependent copies.

Wineburg’s corroboration heuristic is the grown-up name for checking across

pieces.⁶⁰ You do not need lab jargon on the train. You need two columns, makers still named, and a ban on “liar” as the opening move. False balance is the twin error on the other side: “both sides equal” without asking what each can settle. Corroboration is not automatic 50/50. It is question-tied usefulness.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear (including from yourself).

1. “One must be lying.”

Disagreement becomes a villain hunt.

What it usually means: accounts treated as a single true story with one fake narrator.

What you try: Write the question each account seems to answer before you judge. List agree and differ. Delete moral verbs from the first pass.

2. “I’ll just merge them into one tidy story.”

Makers disappear; details blend.

What it usually means: corroboration collapsed into summary.

What you try: Keep two columns. Star which piece each detail came from. Exit with makers still visible.

3. “Three cards saying the same thing — corroborated.”

Dependence mistaken for independence.

What it usually means: feed cluster treated as one primary times three.

What you try: Ask whether the cards copy each other; check one primary; write “independent / not independent because ____.”

4. “Silence proves the cover-up.”

Absence promoted to certainty.

What it usually means: conspiracy-from-silence without limit language.

What you try: “Absence might mean ____ or ____; I don’t know yet.” Name what absence cannot prove.

5. “Eyewitness always wins / later historian always loses” (or the reverse slogan).

Vividness or prestige as automatic crown.

What it usually means: usefulness not tied to a named question.

What you try: For *this* question — who was in the room that hour — which

⁶⁰Wineburg’s sourcing / corroboration / contextualization heuristics (1991 historical problem solving; restated in later essays). Portable adult habit: compare short accounts with makers named. School-research origin; not an adult-home effect size. Research spine access date for this book: 13 September 2026.

helps? For *this* other question — what pattern emerged with archives — which helps?

Five-minute warm-up. Save two short cards or excerpts on one low-heat historic event (public-domain or archive-credited). Source each lightly: maker, date, type. Cover the bodies. Say the cards aloud. Uncover. Write one agree line and one differ line. Cross out any “lying” word. Warm-up done. Locked opening: *Where do these two agree — and where not — without calling a liar?*

If you only have one primary and one modern commemorative card, still run the warm-up — but honesty-label the kinds of voice. A period scrap and a feed are different instruments. Agree/differ still works; independence and time-gap notes matter more. If both “accounts” are modern feeds, you are mostly practicing Chapter 3 until a piece from then arrives. That diagnosis is useful. Do not pretend two memes equal two primaries.

How to try it this week

History Refresh Hour shapes apply. This week’s strip: two voices on one event; agree / differ; one limit; no liar theater.

Session shape. Retrieve a primary-before-feed sticky from Chapter 3. Source Account A, then Account B — attribution before either body owns the hour. Short look on each (Observe–Reflect–Question light). Locked question. Agree / differ T-chart (three lines each max). Name one thing neither settles. Exit sticky. Mixed later: slip a feed cluster into a two-primary sit and ask independence.

Commute / lunch (15–20 min). Materials: two saved short cards on one event; phone note. Safety: private; low-heat event; no public quiz that humiliates a colleague. Move: list agree / differ only — no essay. Optional: rewrite one differ line that used a moral verb.

Desk or shift (25–40 min). Materials: two short accounts (two historic newspapers, letter vs report, image vs text); paper. Safety: ordinary stakes; composite OK if labelled illustration; no culture-war pair as default. Move: CORR-01 same event two voices; or CORR-02 image vs text; or CORR-04 feed cluster vs one primary (with FEED hygiene).

Weekend deep sit (45–75 min when needed). Materials: one contemporaneous excerpt + one later historian paragraph (named); or map + short narrative; calendar

for next micros. Move: CORR-03 witness vs later historian soft with time-gap honesty; or CORR-05 map vs narrative; optional CORR-06 silence as evidence soft. Dual-perspective sentence when prompted: “Another fair reading of Account B’s purpose is ____.” Claim with named sources and a named limit. Stop while a look remains.

Exact wording you can say to yourself.

- “Where do these two agree — and where not — without calling a liar?”
- “Which question is Account A answering? Account B?”
- “What can each show that the other cannot?”
- “Are these cards independent, or copies?”
- “Absence might mean ____ or ____; I don’t know yet.”
- “You may revise without prosecuting either maker.”

Fade help. T-chart template filled with examples → blank T-chart → agree/differ in prose with makers named → optional two-source mini paragraph (Chapter 7 will deepen claim craft). Stop looking up when you can produce agree + differ + one limit without a model merging the voices for you. If you peek, peek at your own prior sticky — not at a generated reconciliation.

First try-it (on the go). Two saved cards, agree/differ sticky only. Deeper sit: CORR-01 with two short public-domain newspaper paragraphs on one anniversary — source cards first. If you cannot find two period voices today, use one period voice and one labelled later telling, and say the kinds aloud before you chart.

Sample micro (composite). Train seat. Two commemorative posts about the same historic weather disaster — soft entry, care label. Source: both modern pages, both later tellings. Agree: date and place named. Differ: one stresses rescue numbers; one stresses policy. Neither settles engineering causes. Exit sticky: *Differ without liar — different questions.* Close. Primary hunt saved for desk.

Two columns on paper beat a clever merge in your head

Working memory is small on a noisy commute. Externalize. Two columns. Finger on each piece. If you work in a note app, use two headings with makers in the titles — “Account A — *Evening Post*, 12 June (excerpt)” — so names do not evaporate. When you feel the urge to reconcile early, put the urge on a third sticky labelled “later claim?” and return to mapping. The urge is not the enemy. Acting on it before the map exists is.

Talk turns you can borrow (then put away)

Say aloud, alone: “A wants me to notice . ***B wants me to notice*** .” Say: “For my question , ***A helps by*** ; B helps by ____.” Say: “I am revising my differ line because I used a prosecution verb.” These are not recitations with one right answer. They are accountable to the texts in front of you. If a line cannot point at a word or a feature on the page, it is commentary seeking a home.

Worked pictures you can steal (then put away)

Picture 1 — Same event, two voices (CORR-01). Two short accounts. Source each. Agreements (three lines max). Differences (three lines max). Forbid “liar” on the first pass. Exit: Agree/differ T-chart. Wrong twin: picking the voice that matches your prior politics and stopping.

Picture 2 — Image vs text (CORR-02). One image + one text on the same episode. What can each show that the other cannot? Exit: “Image uniquely shows ; ***text uniquely shows*** .” Refuse “photos never lie” — crops, captions, staging, and later reuse exist.

Picture 3 — Witness vs later historian soft (CORR-03). Contemporaneous excerpt; later historian paragraph with a name. Label the time gap. What could the witness know? What could the historian know with archives? Exit: time-gap honesty sentence. Refuse automatic privilege to whichever feels vivid.

Picture 4 — Feed cluster vs one primary (CORR-04). Three related feed cards; one primary. Check dependence. Primary check. Exit: “These cards are / are not independent because ____.” Refuse screenshot pile as proof.

Picture 5 — Map vs narrative (CORR-05). Period or modern map + short narrative of movement, migration, or campaign route — ordinary historic stake. Does the narrative’s geography fit the map constraints? Exit: one fit or friction note. Refuse map as decoration only.

Picture 6 — Silence as evidence soft (CORR-06). One source that omits something you expected. Note omission. Hypothesize why (genre, audience, ignorance, strategy). Mark uncertainty. Exit: “Absence might mean ____ or ____; I don’t know yet.” Refuse conspiracy from silence alone.

Picture 7 — Wrong twin (labelled). Differ line: “Account B is lying about the crowd size.” Repair: “Account B estimates a larger crowd; Account A’s seat was

farther from the square — neither settles an official count; I still need a named tally or a reason the count matters for my question.”

Close the pictures. Build one T-chart on a parallel pair yourself. Keep the first pass under fifteen minutes even at a desk. Speed here is a feature: you are mapping, not writing the seminar paper. If the parallel pair is thinner than the worked pictures, good — thin pairs are what life sends. One agree. One differ. One limit. That is a complete sit.

When you finish, ask once: did I leave the makers on the page? If the names vanished, rewrite the exit sticky until they return. Nameless thickness is just a new summary.

Practice that actually builds it

Blocked early: several agree/differ micros on saved cards; then image vs text; then one feed-cluster independence check. Mixed later: two primaries + one FEED interloper; silence-soft after a clean CORR-01; map friction after a narrative sit.

Talk-to-yourself box

Opening (locked): “Where do these two agree — and where not — without calling a liar?”

Follow-ups:

1. What do you mean, *agree* — same fact, same emphasis, or same question?
2. What does each header, credit line, or image show before the body argues?
3. Is there another legal reading of this difference — genre, seat, audience — without a moral verb?
4. What can neither source tell you?
5. Where could someone go wrong — liar theater, false balance, or merge-without-names — and may you revise?

How to wait alone. Cover the bodies after you source the cards. Slow three. Look at the two credit lines, not at a chatbot merge. Rescue at one second is still rescue. If silence is hard, point your finger at Account A’s first line, then Account B’s — physical pointing counts.

Stuck silence usually means. The question was “who wins?” in disguise; wait-time one was zero; you are searching for a vocabulary word; you think disagreement requires a villain; a finished-looking model paragraph already “reconciled” them; anxiety — shorten, win one agree line, return tomorrow.

Named try-its

Try-it A — Agree / differ on two saved cards · commute / lunch

Time: 10–15 minutes.

Materials: two short cards on one event.

Safety: private; low-heat.

The move: Source lightly; three agree lines max; three differ lines max; no liar language. Exit sticky.

Try-it B — Same event, two voices (CORR-01) · desk

Time: 25–40 minutes.

Materials: two short accounts (newspapers, letter vs report, etc.).

Safety: ordinary stakes; labelled composite OK.

The move: Source each; agreements; differences; forbid “liar” as first move. Exit: Agree/differ T-chart. Refuse courtroom theater; refuse picking the voice that matches your politics as the whole method.

Try-it C — Image vs text (CORR-02) · desk

Time: 20–35 minutes.

Materials: one image + one text on same episode (archive-credited).

Safety: soft entry; no graphic harm as the week’s object.

The move: What can each show that the other cannot? Exit: unique-show sentences. Refuse “photos never lie.”

Try-it D — Feed cluster vs one primary (CORR-04) · desk or weekend micro-stack

Time: 25–40 minutes.

Materials: three feed cards making related claims; one primary.

Safety: Chapter 3 hygiene; no opposition-research hobby.

The move: Cluster is not corroboration if they copy each other; check dependence; primary check. Exit: independence sentence.

Try-it E — Witness vs later historian soft (CORR-03) · weekend

Time: 40–60 minutes.

Materials: one contemporaneous excerpt; one later historian paragraph (named).

Safety: name the historian; no invented “eyewitness.”

The move: Label time gap; what could witness know; what could historian know with archives. Exit: time-gap honesty sentence. Refuse automatic privilege to vividness.

Try-it F — Map vs narrative (CORR-05) · desk

Time: 25–40 minutes.

Materials: period or modern map + short narrative.

Safety: geography as constraint, not culture-war color map as Hour.

The move: Fit or friction note. Refuse map as decoration only.

Try-it G — Silence as evidence soft (CORR-06) · desk

Time: 20–30 minutes.

Materials: one source that omits something you expected.

Safety: uncertainty allowed; no conspiracy essay.

The move: Note omission; hypothesize why; mark uncertainty. Exit: “Absence might mean ____ or ____; I don’t know yet.”

Try-it H — Weekend two-source mini (optional bridge toward Chapter 7)

Time: 45–75 minutes.

Materials: CORR-01 pair; paper.

Safety: claim with limit; no AP DBQ dump as weekly spine.

The move: Agree/differ; one dual-perspective sentence; three-to-five sentence claim that names both sources and one limit. Stop while a look remains.

Incorrect example to diagnose.

Account A and Account B disagree on whether rain stopped a parade. Your note: “Account B is lying to protect the organizers.” Error type: liar theater. Repair: rewrite without moral verb — “Account B, written for a city booster audience, reports the parade completed; Account A, a private letter, reports rain and early dispersal; neither settles official attendance; I still need a named municipal report if my question is attendance.”

Mixed pair. After blocked CORR-01 wins: add CORR-04 independence check; then CORR-06 silence soft. Near transfer: anniversary week with FEED-06 primary-first, then CORR-01 on two period voices.

Spacing seed. Mon: agree/differ micro. Tue: DOC image pair neighbor. Wed: CORR-01 desk. Thu: ARG-06 limit your claim light (Chapter 7 neighbor). Fri: exit sticky + liar-theater diagnostic repaired. Weekend optional: CORR-03 or map

vs narrative.⁶¹

Tiny record. Dated T-chart; makers named; one limit sentence. Stranger-readable. Never “History Refresh for Adults I.” Never a fake certificate.

Difference without prosecution — slowed down

Returners often remember debate club rules: find the flaw, crown a winner, move on. Looking across historical accounts uses a different first pass. You are not yet writing a closing argument. You are mapping the record’s thickness. Moral evaluation of past harms can come later, with care, and is not identical to “this newspaper is a liar.” Collapsing those tasks produces heat without light.

Try this drill once. Take a differ line that uses a moral verb. Rewrite it three ways: (1) audience/purpose difference; (2) seat/access difference; (3) question-each-answers difference. Keep the version that stays closest to the pieces. Delete the prosecution verb unless you have separate evidence of fabrication — and fabrication claims need their own sources, not a vibe.

False balance is not corroboration either

“Both sides” can be as lazy as “one side lies.” If Account A is a same-day shipping ledger and Account B is an anonymous meme, they are not equal instruments for a tonnage question. Write the question. Then ask which piece can speak to it. Corroboration can conclude that one account is far more useful for *this* question while still refusing liar theater on the first pass. Usefulness is not a personality prize.

Feed cluster, revisited

Chapter 3 warned that virality is not corroboration. Here the same warning becomes a method. Sort cards by upstream dependence. Same crop, same misspelling, same odd statistic — mark dependent. Then put one primary on the table. The cluster may still be interesting as a study of later tellings. It is not three witnesses.

⁶¹Dunlosky and colleagues (2013): distributed practice high utility as technique rating — not an adult-history programme evaluation. Space pairs across days.

Silence, uncertainty, and adult patience

Absence is tempting because it feels like a secret the record dropped in your lap. Sometimes omission is strategic. Sometimes the genre never included what you wanted (a love letter may not report crop prices). Sometimes the maker did not know. Your exit line protects you from overclaim: two hypotheses and an “I don’t know yet.” Chapter 6 will deepen their-world context. Here, keep the soft limit. Conspiracy from silence alone is a wrong twin you should be able to hear in your own draft.

Sister rooms, one pointer each

History for Young Minds practices light corroboration for ages 11–14 with parent facilitation — adapt the sticky-note spirit, do not reprint the kitchen scripts. *History for Emerging Adults* deepens multi-document school shapes for 15–18 — one pointer, then adult self-study here. *Critical Thinking for Adults* owns two-source judgment on present ordinary stakes — one pointer; this hour keeps makers in the past on the table. Stanovich myside batteries stay in their own book — not inside a historic newspaper T-chart. Looking first. Claim craft next chapter-but-one.

Building a T-chart that stays honest

A good agree/differ chart is small on purpose. Three lines each keeps you from rewriting the encyclopedia. Star the piece that supplies each line. If a detail appears in both, it can live under Agree — still name both makers in a parenthetical once (“both A and B note the late start”). If a detail is only in one, it lives under Differ, not under a silent merge.

Adults sometimes overfill Differ with commentary (“B is biased”). Bias language can come later as a careful claim with evidence. On the first pass, prefer descriptive differ lines: larger crowd estimate; omits the rain; written next day vs written that evening; booster audience vs private letter. Description before prosecution. Chapter 7 will ask for warrants. This chapter asks for map-making.

Question each account answers

Lee’s teaching point, carried lightly: accounts are not only right or wrong; they answer different questions from different standpoints. Your kitchen — train seat

— translation is ordinary. Under each credit line, write one question in six to ten words. “What did the parade look like from the square?” “What should out-of-town readers believe about order restored?” When different lines quarrel, check whether the questions quarrel. Often they do. That is thickness, not failure.

Image, text, and the body as instrument

CORR-02 is not an art class. It is a reminder that representation has limits. A photograph can show arrangement, clothing, weather, distance — and still not name speakers, motives, or off-frame events. A paragraph can name and still invent scale. Captions on images are themselves later tellings when added by an archive, a newspaper, or a feed. Source the image’s credit. Source the caption’s maker if different. “Photos never lie” is a slogan that erases crops, staging, selection, and reuse across decades. “Texts always clarify” is the twin slogan. Ask what each instrument uniquely affords for *your* question.

Time gap without romance

Contemporaneous voices feel authentic because they were close. Later historians feel authoritative because they had more boxes to open. Neither automatic crown survives a written question. A witness may not see the pattern. A historian may misread a witness. CORR-03’s exit sentence — time-gap honesty — keeps both gifts and both limits on the table. If you only ever trust diaries, schedule one sit with a named secondary that cites archives. If you only ever trust later synthesis, schedule one sit that returns to a same-day scrap. Flexibility is not cheating. Slogan loyalty is.

Map friction as corroboration

Geography is a quiet second voice. A narrative that marches an army farther than roads and seasons allow needs a friction note. A migration story that ignores ports and rivers needs one too. You do not need to become a cartographer. You need one fit-or-friction sticky. Chapter 6 owns maps and timelines more fully. Here, the map is a corroborating instrument — or a constraint that thins a confident paragraph. Decoration on a slide are not yet looking.

From two voices to a limit

Agree + differ without a limit still leaves you overconfident. Add one sentence: “Neither settles ____.” Attendance. Motive. Off-frame decisions. Legal meaning. Causal weight. The limit is not modesty theater. It is accuracy about what your pair can do. When you later write a short civic claim, that limit travels with you. Adults who skip it sound certain and travel poorly.

Low-heat defaults (and why)

Default to ship arrivals, market days, weather disasters told softly, school openings, parades, bridge dedications, soft anniversary tellings, trade-history forwards with ordinary stakes. Soft entry on hard past still applies when you eventually choose harder material: everyday life, tools, tickets, streets and work before atrocity as the first pair. Graphic violence is not the week’s piece box. Culture-war pairs stay out as the default object. The move must land before the temperature rises. If your life hands you a high-heat card, practice the move first on a parallel low-heat pair, then return — or wait a week. Looking under adrenaline often becomes prosecution.

A CORR-focus week that stays honest

Banks are menus. A hypothesized week: Monday agree/differ micro; Tuesday image pair; Wednesday CORR-01 desk; Thursday one limit sentence on yesterday’s pair; Friday exit sticky plus liar-theater repair; weekend optional witness vs historian or map vs narrative. If life allows only three sits, keep agree/differ, one independence or image check, and one limit. Depth beats a tour of ten half-finished pairs.

Representation before tidy reconciliation

Feeds and chatbots love reconciliation: “Here is what really happened.” Your job in this chapter is prior. Keep makers. Keep questions. Keep limits. Reconciliation may come later as a careful claim with warrants — and even then, some differences remain. A tidy story that erases makers is a later telling wearing a lab coat. You already know what to do with later tellings.

What corroboration is not

It is not a weekly AP Document-Based Question. It is not a SHEG packet dump as identity. It is not automatic citizenship virtue — looking can improve without minting dispositions by magic; teach looking because it is how history works, and point elsewhere for citizenship craft when that is the aim.⁶² It is not a licence to harass colleagues with “gotcha” pairs. It is not false balance. It is not liar theater. Hold the center: two short accounts, makers named, agree, differ, limit.

If it isn’t clicking

Diagnostic 1 — Liar theater.

Every difference becomes a moral verdict.

Next move: Rewrite the differ line without a moral verb. Force the question each account answers. If you still suspect fabrication, list what *separate* evidence would be required — then go find a source for that claim, or mark it unproven.

Diagnostic 2 — Collapse to one story.

You produce a smooth paragraph and cannot say which detail came from which piece.

Next move: Force two columns. Star sources. Only then write three sentences that keep names visible. If a tool merged them for you, discard the merge as a draft of looking — it is not your check.

Diagnostic 3 — Conspiracy from silence / false balance swing.

You over-read absence, or you declare “both equal” to escape judgment.

Next move: For silence — use the CORR-06 exit line with two hypotheses and uncertainty. For false balance — write the question; name which account can speak to it and which cannot. Limits are strength.

When to slow down: high-emotion topic — switch to a low-heat parallel event and practice the move. When to go ahead: agree + differ + limit without prosecution verbs. When to ask a human: librarian for a second period voice; tutor for structured pairs; colleague only on public ordinary claims.

⁶²Wilke and colleagues (2022) caution: inquiry gains do not automatically transfer to democratic dispositions. Teach looking; point to citizenship craft elsewhere when that is the aim — including one pointer to *Critical Thinking for Adults* / *Publius* as fits, without making this refresh their understudy.

Correct yourself without crushing the attempt. “I went to liar theater” is a useful sticky. Replace the verb. Keep the looking. Anxiety: shorter T-chart, one agree win, stop — not a therapy manual.

If none of the three diagnostics fit, check a quieter failure: you never wrote the central question. Without a question, every difference feels like a fight and every agreement feels like victory. Write the question in one line at the top of the page. Then return to agree and differ. Many “stuck” sits are questionless sits.

Tools, including AI

Point back to the History Refresh Hour AI box.

After you try, you may: explain the agree/differ pattern to yourself from a named pair; request isomorphic practice pairs with answers on *your* page; ask for a labelled SCRIPT of questions for *you* to ask yourself; request revision questions after *your* T-chart; take a hint after an attempt; diagnose a note you already wrote.

During the attempt, you may not: invent a third “eyewitness”; ask a model to reconcile two accounts into one true story as your only draft; generate a missing diary to fill silence; paste proprietary materials; treat a model merge as corroboration; photo-to-key a worksheet.

A practice sheet with two accounts + your key is allowed after you have tried a parallel unaided item. Labelled archives and OpenStax chapters can supply pairs after you know what you are looking for. They replace thinking when they finish the T-chart for you.

If you use audio because dense prose is heavy — PIAAC literacy context reminds many adults that complex informational text is hard work, not a character test — listen to a public-domain reading *after* you have sourced the cards and tried one agree line unaided.⁶³ Audio is access. Audio that replaces looking at today’s two pieces is a different choice. Keep the pages open even when a voice reads along.

Library and museum visits motivate pairs: two labels on one object; a pamphlet beside a plaque. They do not replace the T-chart. OUT-bank neighbors in Resources

⁶³PIAAC / Survey of Adult Skills U.S. literacy highlights (2023 cycle): adult skills context only — U.S. mean near 258; Level 1 or below near 28% in published highlights — keep excerpts short; scaffolds are access. Not a finding that this book raises PIAAC levels. Exact figures live in the research spine; body keeps them light.

point to \$0 first doors. Bring the move with you. Leave with makers named.

What “done enough” looks like

Before you move on:

- You listed **one agree** and **one differ** on a real pair without liar language.
- You named **one limitation** (what neither settles, or what absence cannot prove, or which question each can answer).
- You refused at least one wrong twin: liar theater, merge-without-names, feed-cluster-as-independence, silence-as-conspiracy, vividness-as-automatic-crown.
- Optional weekend: a two-source mini with makers still visible.
- You can ask the locked opening and wait.

A certificate is not the work. Optional CLEP edges remain optional. Place next work by whether disagreement still triggers prosecution as your first move.

Life of the habit (seed). Revisit next week with a new pair. Space corroboration sits — do not mass five pairs on Sunday and call it done.⁶⁴ Mix a FEED independence check into a clean primary week so the interloper stays honest. File the T-charts in Keeping track. Chapter 5 will meet civic texts as documents with makers — you will need the habit of audience and purpose you practiced when two voices disagreed without becoming a trial.

If this week only yields one repaired differ line, that is a real win. Thickness returns one pair at a time.

Self-placement probe (skill strip, not diploma year): Can you source two short accounts before reading for victory? Can you produce agree + differ without moral verbs on the first pass? Can you name one limit? Can you spot a dependent feed cluster? If yes, you are ready to mix corroboration into civic-text weeks and claim weeks. If no, stay here with thinner pairs and shorter sits. A graduate can still

⁶⁴Dunlosky and colleagues (2013): distributed practice high utility as technique rating — not an adult-history programme evaluation. Space pairs across days.

prosecute on contact. A GED-holder can run a clean T-chart. No diploma required to open this chapter; no diploma finishes it either.

Chapter 5 — Civic texts as documents



Figure 7: A still-life: short civic excerpt as object on a page; maker/audience sticky; then-meaning note; no campaign props. No people. No logos. No readable UI.

Why this matters

Adults often meet civic texts as slogans, memes, and campaign props. A phrase from a preamble arrives already moralized. An amendment arrives as a blank check for a present desire. A rights word arrives with today's argument loaded into yesterday's sentence. Reverence skips attribution. Outrage skips audience. Both skip the document.

This chapter restores a quieter meeting. A civic text is still a **sourced historical object**: makers, date, genre, audience, then-meaning — as far as a short sit can honestly go. You will work a Preamble phrase, one amendment in one sit, a short Article or section close read, a Declaration sentence softly, a rights word then/now, and the micro-habit that even a beloved excerpt still gets a sourcing card. You will refuse pledge-theater and a party-platform spine. You will refuse an Article-by-Article dump and a Constitution-chain table of contents reprinted from a teen parent Hour.

History for Emerging Adults owns Declaration → Articles → Constitution → Bill of Rights → Federalist/Brutus as a parent kitchen spine for ages 15–18. One pointer, then teach adult refresh here. Adapt objects. That chain is not this book's weekly identity. When you want a Federalist/Brutus deep week — newspaper war, Publius as persona, sustained argument across essays — open *Publius*. This chapter will point once and will not rewrite that book here.

Looking at civic texts does not automatically mint citizens. Inquiry can improve while dispositions stay stubborn; teach looking because it is how documents work, and treat citizenship craft as a related aim you may pursue elsewhere.⁶⁵ Annenberg and Pew recall items are labelled population context in this book's front matter — not this chapter's finish line and not a three-branch flashcard graduation. Dense founding prose is hard work for many adults; keep excerpts short. Scaffolds are access, not a verdict on your character.⁶⁶

What this unlocks is usable respect for the page: maker before slogan; then-meaning attempted once; audience named; what a line restrains; a modern

⁶⁵Wilke and colleagues (2022): inquiry gains need not transfer automatically to democratic dispositions. Teach looking; point elsewhere for citizenship craft when that is the aim. Research spine access date for this book: 13 September 2026.

⁶⁶PIAAC / Survey of Adult Skills U.S. literacy highlights (2023 cycle): adult skills context — U.S. mean near 258; Level 1 or below near 28% in published highlights — keep excerpts short; scaffolds are access. Not a claim this book raises PIAAC levels.

misunderstanding checked against text without a rant. Ordinary surfaces carry the practice: phone PDF of a public-domain amendment; ballot pamphlet clause; courthouse plaque; museum label beside a founding excerpt; workplace claim about “what the law always said” met first as a document question — ordinary stakes, not legal advice.

If you leave one civic excerpt sourced (maker / date / audience), one then-meaning attempt, one pledge-theater refuse, and the knowledge that *Publius* owns Federalist depth, the chapter did its job.

Rust here often sounds like two voices in one head: “I should already know this” and “this prose is impossible.” Both can be true as feelings and false as placement tests. Knowing a fragment from a school assembly is not sourcing. Finding prose difficult is not proof you missed a civic birthday. Place by the strip: can you put maker and audience on a recited line? Can you attempt then-meaning on one word without a platform chant? That is the gate — not whether you remember every amendment number in order.

Understand it yourself

Everyday picture. An amendment on your phone as a PDF. You can recite a fragment from school. A meme overlays today’s slogan on the same words. The everyday trap is to treat the meme’s meaning as the document’s meaning. The everyday repair is smaller: open the public-domain text; name who made it, when, for whom; attempt then-meaning of one key term; ask what the line restrains; refuse to use the page as a loyalty test.

Precise picture. Genre matters. A constitution is not a speech. A declaration of principles and grievances is not a statute. A preamble states purposes; it is not a blank warrant for every later hope. An amendment is words with a ratification history and an audience of institutions and persons the text meant to bind or protect — then. Rights words shift. “Commerce,” “domestic,” “people,” “arms,” “press,” “religion” — pick one in context, not as a weaponized ambiguity game. Then-sense comes from surrounding lines and named references when needed; modern false friends get a sticky. You separate understanding from approving when the practice in view is one you reject — Chapter 6 deepens that move; here you keep audience and restraint visible.

C3 civics and history pathways map skills like explaining perspectives and using

evidence; they are a standards map, not a home statute and not a promise about your week.⁶⁷ Your adult version this week is smaller: one excerpt, sourced; then-meaning sticky; pledge-theater refused.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear (including from yourself).

1. Pledge-theater.

The text becomes a loyalty test or campaign chant.

What it usually means: maker and audience erased; reverence or outrage replaced looking.

What you try: Run a full sourcing card even if you can recite the lines. Genre + audience sentence. “This is still a source because ____.”

2. “They meant exactly what my party means.”

Present platform loaded into historic words.

What it usually means: then-meaning skipped; slogan absorption.

What you try: Then-meaning sticky; who was meant to be restrained; check one modern misunderstanding against the text without a rant.

3. Article-by-Article dump as the week.

Coverage theater returns.

What it usually means: depth replaced by tour.

What you try: One section. List powers/limits written; mark silence; one claim tied to text. Stop.

4. Federalist monograph creep.

This chapter tries to become *Publius*.

What it usually means: deep-week hunger without a deep-week book.

What you try: Keep one excerpt here. Put Federalist/Brutus depth on a pointer card to *Publius*. Schedule that week separately.

5. Reverence skipping attribution (or contempt skipping attribution).

Beloved or despised lines float free of makers.

What it usually means: civic text treated as atmosphere.

What you try: Who / when / what kind / for whom — same ladder as any primary.

Five-minute warm-up (CIV-06). Take any beloved civic excerpt you can recite. Fill a sourcing card anyway: maker, date, genre (petition, constitution, speech,

⁶⁷NCSS C3 Framework (2013) Dimension 2 civics/history pathways — standards map, not a home RCT and not a statute for your week.

declaration), audience if known. Write one sentence: “This is still a source because ____.” Warm-up done. Locked opening: “What did this word mean *then*, to *whom* — as a document, not as a slogan?”

If the only excerpt you have is a meme screenshot, honesty-label it as screenshot / later telling, then open a public-domain edition of the same lines before you attempt then-meaning. The meme can wait. The document cannot if the week’s object is civic-as-source. If you feel silly sourcing something you “already know,” that silliness is the point of CIV-06 — attribution is a looking move, not a prize for ignorance.

How to try it this week

History Refresh Hour shapes apply. This week’s strip: civic text as sourced object; then-meaning; audience/restraint; refuse pledge-theater; know the *Publius* door.

Session shape. Retrieve agree/differ or later-telling sticky. One short civic excerpt — public-domain or archive-credited. Source before body. Observe–Reflect–Question light. Locked opening on one word or phrase. Then-meaning sticky. Exit: genre + audience, or restraint/audience. Mixed later: FEED interloper that sloganizes the same line — primary (civic text) before feed.

Commute / lunch (15–20 min). Materials: phone PDF or saved excerpt; sticky note. Safety: private; no culture-war sting; no photographing strangers. Move: CIV-06 still-a-source; or CIV-05 rights word then/now on one word; or CIV-01 Preamble phrase paraphrase.

Desk or shift (25–40 min). Materials: one Bill of Rights amendment (or state analogue) + short surrounding context card; paper. Safety: ordinary stakes; not legal advice; not campaign speech. Move: CIV-02 one amendment one sit; invite CTX-03 word that shifted on a key term; then-meaning sticky; who was meant to be restrained.

Weekend deep sit (45–75 min when needed). Materials: one short Constitution section (enumerated powers slice or similar); optional TIME-02 chain chronology card invitation for ratification timing — light. Move: CIV-03 Article/section close read — written / silent / my claim; or CIV-04 Declaration sentence soft with occasion card (1776 audience) — principle vs grievance label. If hunger for Federalist depth appears, write the pointer card to *Publius* and stop this book from swallow-

ing that deep week. Dual-perspective sentence when prompted. Claim with named source and named limit. Stop while a look remains.

Exact wording you can say to yourself.

- “What did this word mean *then*, to *whom* — as a document, not as a slogan?”
- “Who made this, when, for whom — and what genre is it?”
- “What does this line restrain — and whom?”
- “Then-sense of ____ vs modern false friend ____.”
- “Written / silent / my claim (labelled inference).”
- “For Federalist deep week, open *Publius* — not a dump inside this sit.”

Fade help. Full sourcing template → you write the card from memory of the ladder → then-meaning with a gloss sticky → unaided paraphrase accountable to a starred line. Stop looking up when you can source and attempt then-meaning without a model essay on “what the Founders meant.” If you peek, peek at the public-domain lines you starred — not at a feed that already moralized them. Two clean sits in a row with audience named is enough signal to mix a FEED interloper next.

First try-it (on the go). CIV-06 on a recited fragment. Deeper sit: CIV-02 on one amendment with words first. If the deeper sit stalls, fall back to CIV-06 and a single starred word — still a win. Escalation is optional; attribution is not. Schedule the amendment again within three days while the frustration is fresh and useful rather than shaming.

Sample micro (composite). Kitchen table after kids asleep. First Amendment text open as public-domain excerpt — ordinary look, not a pamphlet hour. Source: Congress proposed; states ratified; genre constitutional amendment; audience institutions and persons bound by the National government frame. Pick “abridging.” Then-meaning sticky in plain language tied to surrounding words. Exit: *Still a source — genre amendment, audience then.* Close. No campaign overlay.

Sample desk (composite). One amendment sit on a different clause next week — words first for twelve minutes before any commentary tab. Write who is restrained in one sentence. Write one modern misunderstanding you have heard (labelled as hearsay until checked). Check it against the starred lines only. If the text does not settle the modern fight, say so. That “does not settle” sentence is then-meaning’s cousin: a limit. Save the fight for a claim chapter with warrants, or for a different book if the fight is live controversy this volume refuses as example content.

Worked pictures you can steal (then put away)

Picture 1 — Civic text is still a source (CIV-06). Beloved excerpt. Full sourcing card. Genre + audience sentence. Refuse reverence skipping attribution.

Picture 2 — Preamble phrase as source (CIV-01). Source the text. Pick one phrase. Paraphrase then-purpose. One question. Exit: phrase + then-purpose + question. Refuse pledge-theater and campaign slogan swap.

Picture 3 — One amendment, one sit (CIV-02). Words first. Then-meaning of key term. Who was meant to be restrained. One modern misunderstanding to check against text (not a rant). Exit: restraint/audience sticky. Refuse amendment as blank check for any present desire.

Picture 4 — Article/section close read (CIV-03). One short section. List powers/limits actually written. Mark silence. One claim tied to text. Exit: written / silent / my claim. Refuse reading hopes into silences without labelling inference.

Picture 5 — Declaration sentence soft (CIV-04). One sentence; 1776 occasion card. Audience/purpose. Principle vs grievance if present. Then-meaning. Exit: principle vs grievance label. Refuse treating Declaration as statute; refuse pamphlet cherry-pick.

Picture 6 — Rights word then/now (CIV-05). One rights word in historic text and modern usage. Then-sense from context; now-sense; overlap and gap. Exit: overlap/gap T-chart. Refuse equating words across centuries without work.

Picture 7 — Publius pointer card (not a chapter dump). Sticky: “Federalist/Brutus deep week → *Publius*. This sit keeps one excerpt.” Wrong twin: pasting essay summaries as if this chapter owned the newspaper war.

Picture 8 — Wrong twin (labelled). Note: “This amendment means my party’s platform plank exactly.” Repair: open text; star the words; write then-audience; write one checked misunderstanding; label today’s platform as today’s platform.

Close the pictures. Run one phrase or one amendment yourself. Keep the first desk sit to one amendment even if ambition argues for three. Ambition can schedule next Tuesday. Tonight’s win is words first, then-meaning once, audience named once. If your paraphrase drifts into a speech, cut it back to two sentences accountable to starred words. Speeches are Chapter 7’s temptation; this chapter’s craft is smaller and stricter.

Gloss honesty without outsourcing meaning

When archaic syntax blocks you, a modern gloss can be a bridge — after you star the original word. Write both: “Starred word: ; ***gloss I am using:*** ; risk: gloss may smuggle present sense.” That risk sentence is adult. A chatbot paraphrase that erases the starred word and hands you a platform paragraph is not a gloss. It is a later telling. Label it and return to the page.

Practice that actually builds it

Blocked early: CIV-06 micros; then one Preamble phrase; then one amendment desk sit. Mixed later: civic excerpt + FEED slogan interloper; rights word then/now after a clean CIV-02; silence mark inside CIV-03 after CORR-06 habit.

Talk-to-yourself box

Opening (locked): “What did this word mean *then*, to *whom* — as a document, not as a slogan?”

Follow-ups:

1. What do you mean, *then* — which decade, which ratification moment, which audience?
2. What does the header, title, or surrounding clause show before the slogan lands?
3. Is there another legal reading of this line that still stays on the page?
4. What can this excerpt *not* settle — even if every word feels sacred or suspicious?
5. Where could someone go wrong — pledge-theater, party-means-exactly-this, dump, *Publius* creep — and may you revise?

How to wait alone. Cover modern commentary. Slow three. Look at the starred word on the public-domain page — not at a chatbot “Founders meant.” Rescue at one second is still rescue. If dense prose freezes you, shorten the excerpt to one sentence and keep the card.

Stuck silence usually means. The question was a recitation item (“what are the five freedoms?”) in disguise; wait-time one was zero; you are hunting a vocabulary quiz answer; pledge-theater anxiety; model *précis* already “explained” the

clause; dense-prose freeze — shorter excerpt, gloss honesty, one phrase only; return tomorrow.

Named try-its

Try-it A — Civic text is still a source (CIV-06) · commute / lunch

Time: 8–12 minutes.

Materials: any beloved civic excerpt.

Safety: private; reverence allowed, attribution required.

The move: Full sourcing card even if you can recite it; note genre. Exit: genre + audience sentence. Refuse reverence skipping attribution.

Try-it B — Preamble phrase as source (CIV-01) · micro or desk

Time: 15–25 minutes.

Materials: Preamble (or analogous charter opening); highlighter.

Safety: ordinary; no campaign swap.

The move: Source; pick one phrase; paraphrase then-purpose; one question. Exit: phrase + then-purpose + question.

Try-it C — One amendment, one sit (CIV-02) · desk

Time: 25–40 minutes.

Materials: one Bill of Rights amendment or state analogue; short context card.

Safety: not legal advice; not a rant.

The move: Words first; then-meaning; who restrained; one modern misunderstanding checked against text. Exit: restraint/audience sticky. Optional: CTX-03 word that shifted on a key term.

Try-it D — Rights word then/now (CIV-05) · micro

Time: 10–15 minutes.

Materials: one rights word in historic text and in a modern sentence you write.

Safety: refuse weaponizing ambiguity.

The move: Then-sense; now-sense; overlap/gap T-chart.

Try-it E — Article/section close read (CIV-03) · weekend

Time: 40–60 minutes.

Materials: one short Constitution section.

Safety: no Article-by-Article dump; label inferences.

The move: Written powers/limits; silence marked; one claim tied to text. Exit: written / silent / my claim. Optional TIME-02 invitation for a five-node chronology card around the section's adoption — dates as tools, not trivia.

Try-it F — Declaration sentence soft (CIV-04) · desk

Time: 25–40 minutes.

Materials: one Declaration sentence; 1776 occasion card.

Safety: soft entry; refuse statute confusion; refuse cherry-pick pamphlet.

The move: Audience/purpose; principle vs grievance; then-meaning. Exit: principle vs grievance label.

Try-it G — Slogan interloper (civic + FEED) · desk

Time: 25–35 minutes.

Materials: one civic excerpt + one feed card sloganizing it.

Safety: Chapter 3 order — text before feed.

The move: Source the text; then label the card later telling; note what modernizes.

Exit: primary-before-feed on a founding line.

Try-it H — Publius pointer (when hunger appears) · micro

Time: 5–10 minutes.

Materials: sticky; calendar.

Safety: Federalist essays stay out of this chapter's sit — point to *Publius* instead.

The move: Write “Deep week → *Publius*”; schedule separately; return to one excerpt here. Exit: pointer known.

Incorrect example to diagnose.

You read an amendment and write: “This proves my side’s entire platform.” Error type: pledge-theater / party-means-exactly-this. Repair: star the words on the page; write audience then; write what the line restrains; label platform claims as today’s claims needing today’s warrants; keep the document as a document.

Mixed pair. After CIV-06 and CIV-02: add CIV-05; then CIV-03 on a weekend. Near transfer: workplace “what the law always said” met with a public pamphlet section first — ordinary stakes.

Spacing seed. Mon: CIV-06. Tue: CIV-02 + word that shifted. Wed: talk-to-yourself on a starred line. Thu: CIV-01. Fri: then-meaning exit sticky. Optional weekend: CIV-03 + light chronology card; *Publius* pointer if deep week next.⁶⁸

Tiny record. Dated sourcing card; then-meaning sticky; restraint/audience sentence. Stranger-readable. Never “History Refresh for Adults I.” Never “Certified Civic Literacy.” Optional: a photograph of a plaque as object in your notes —

⁶⁸Dunlosky and colleagues (2013): distributed practice high utility as technique rating — not an adult-history programme evaluation.

no brand logos needed — with the same sourcing lines you would give any later telling. The file you keep is the habit made visible.

Edges, not a high-school dump — slowed down

Coverage pressure will whisper that one amendment is “not enough.” Depth is the hour. A light tour of the whole charter leaves few traces; a pattern on a few sourced objects is what the mind can keep. Wineburg’s warning about coverage theater travels here: crazy for coverage is not the same as crazy for history.⁶⁹ Your adult promise is usable looking on excerpts you actually meet — ballot, plaque, PDF, pamphlet — not a secret second AP course.

Emerging Adults needed a chain because a parent and a teenager were building a year-shaped civic spine together. You are building a refresh habit alone on the go. Chain edges are enough: Preamble phrase; one amendment; one section; one Declaration sentence; one rights word. The rest of the map lives in Resources and in optional survey courses. CLEP American Government or History is an edge when credit is the goal — not this chapter’s spine.

Then-meaning without a sermon

Presentism is the mind at rest.⁷⁰ When you hear “they were stupid / they meant my slogan,” do not deliver a culture-war counter-sermon. Ask what the word meant then, to whom, in this genre. Use surrounding lines. Use a named glossary or context card if needed — after you try. Separate understanding from approving when needed. You can understand a restraint design and still reject a past exclusion; you can approve a principle and still refuse to fake its then-audience. Honesty about gap is adult.

Dense prose freeze (access, not shame)

If the sentence will not parse, shorten it. One phrase. Gloss honesty (“I am using a modern gloss; the starred word is ____”). Audio of a public-domain reading after a sourcing attempt is allowed as access. A model essay that replaces your look

⁶⁹Wineburg “Crazy for History” grain (via research spine / sister streams): coverage is a map; depth is the hour.

⁷⁰Wineburg on presentism as “psychological condition at rest” (1998/1999 grain): interrupt with their-world / then-meaning questions, not culture-war sermons.

is not. PIAAC literacy context says many adults find complex informational text hard — implication for this book: short excerpts, honest scaffolds — not a claim this book raises survey scores.⁷¹

What this chapter refuses

Party platform as spine. Culture-war pamphlet as Hour. Article-by-Article dump. Constitution-chain TOC reprint. Federalist monograph creep. Generated “lost Federalist.” Model summary as the meaning of a clause. Three-branch flashcard as graduation. Live controversy as the worked example. Legal advice dressed as literacy. Campaign speech dressed as then-meaning.

Sister pointers (once each, then teach)

History for Emerging Adults — teen chain Hour. *History for Young Minds* — early civic texts gently. *History for Little Thinkers / History for Homeschooling* — younger or broad maps. *Publius* — Federalist deep week. *Critical Thinking for Adults* — myside / dual-perspective on present arguments. *Math Refresher for Adults* — rust-is-ordinary architecture; keep literacy separate from numeracy. One pointer each. Then the excerpt in front of you.

You may notice the temptation to rebuild *Emerging Adults*’ year map in your evenings “more seriously.” That temptation respects the material and still misplaces this book. Adult refresh is session-shaped: micro, desk, deep. It is not a secret high-school redo with better coffee. If you want a year-long survey, choose a survey path in Resources and keep these looking moves as the way you read it. The moves travel. The teen TOC does not need to.

One phrase is a complete object

Adults who last saw founding prose in eleventh grade often assume the only serious move is “read the whole thing.” Whole-charter ambition returns coverage theater through the side door. One phrase, sourced and paraphrased for then-purpose, is a complete micro-object. One amendment, words first, is a complete desk object. The mind keeps patterns. It does not keep tours. If you finish a sit restless because

⁷¹PIAAC / Survey of Adult Skills U.S. literacy highlights (2023 cycle): adult skills context — U.S. mean near 258; Level 1 or below near 28% in published highlights — keep excerpts short; scaffolds are access. Not a claim this book raises PIAAC levels.

you “only” did the Preamble’s opening purpose clause, name the restlessness as coverage hunger — then file the sticky anyway. Restlessness is not a grading rubric.

Audience then is not audience now

A line addressed to states, to Congress, to courts, to persons under a jurisdiction, or to a reading public in a crisis year is not automatically addressed to your group chat. Write audience then in plain words. You may also write why the line still matters to you now — that is a separate sentence, labelled as yours. Collapsing the two sentences produces slogan absorption. Keeping them apart produces adult looking. When a feed erases audience, your repair is to put audience back before you argue.

Restraint is a looking question

Many civic lines are about what an institution may not do, or what a process must include. “Who was meant to be restrained?” keeps the document from becoming a wish list. You can still argue, later, about how later courts, statutes, or amendments changed the field. That later argument needs later sources. This sit asks what the text in front of you attempts. If your note only lists what you wish the text provided, you are reading silence as hope — label inference or return to written words (CIV-03 exit).

Principle vs grievance (Declaration soft)

A Declaration sentence may state a principle, list a grievance, or do both nearby. Soft practice: label which. Principles travel in argument; grievances name concrete injuries to a then-audience. Treating every rising line as eternal statute confuses genre. Treating every line as disposable rhetoric confuses genre the other way. Occasion card (year, war/crisis context in one or two sentences of background max) is enough. No pamphlet cherry-pick that lifts a principle and hides the grievance list — or the reverse — without saying what you lifted.

Rights words and false friends

Words drift. A then-sense sticky is not a lecture on linguistic relativity. It is a warning label: do not equate centuries without work. Surrounding lines first. Named

reference second if still stuck. Overlap/gap chart third. Weaponizing ambiguity — “the word could mean anything, so my side wins” — is a wrong twin. So is “the word never changes.” Adults can hold a gap without turning the gap into a gotcha.

Ballot pamphlet and plaque as civic objects

You do not need a rare book room. A ballot pamphlet explains measures in modern prose — later telling about law, useful, still not the statute itself when the claim is “what the law says.” A courthouse plaque compresses founding or local civic history into bronze — later telling with a maker (committee, date if given). Run CIV-06 habits: genre, audience, what evidence would check the claim. OUT-bank neighbors live in Resources. Bring the move. Leave with a sticky, not with a selfie campaign.

Workplace “what the law always said”

Ordinary stakes only. Someone asserts a timeless legal story to end a conversation. Your looking move is not to play lawyer on break. It is to ask which public text would check the claim, and to refuse model summaries as that text. If the claim matters, open a public statute section, a public agency page, or a pamphlet — and still know you are not giving legal advice. If it does not matter enough to open a text, mark “unchecked” and decline the myth fight. Proprietary policy stays inside acceptable-use rules; public consumer chat is not your employer’s counsel’s office.

Federalist hunger without monograph creep

Some readers, once then-meaning feels good, want the full newspaper war: Publius, Brutus, ratification heat, essay against essay. That hunger is legitimate. It is also a different book’s job. *Publius* owns a Federalist deep week as its object. This chapter’s job is edges: enough document habit to meet civic texts without slogan brain. Write the pointer. Schedule the deep week. Essay digests do not belong inside your CIV-02 sit as then-meaning. Digests are later tellings. You know the FEED rule.

A CIV-focus week that stays honest

Banks are menus. Hypothesized week: Monday CIV-06; Tuesday CIV-02 with a word-that-shifted sticky; Wednesday talk-to-yourself on a starred line; Thursday

CIV-01; Friday then-meaning exit; weekend optional CIV-03 with a light chronology card; *Publius* pointer if next week goes deep. Three sits only? Keep still-a-source, one amendment, one refuse (pledge-theater or feed slogan). Depth beats a silent read-through of all amendments in one Sunday guilt session.

Representation before tidy ideology

Founding pages are often taught as destiny. Looking asks what the representation shows: title, article label, amendment number, ratification note, surrounding restraints. Ideology may come later as your claim with warrants. Ideology that arrives before attribution is pledge-theater in either direction — patriotic or contemptuous. Both skip the document. Both are repairable with the same card.

What “civic literacy” means in this chapter

Not a flashcard crown. Not Annenberg percentages as your personal scoreboard. Not a fake certificate. It means you can meet a short civic excerpt as a document with makers, attempt then-meaning, name a limit, and know when you need another book for depth. That is usable on a ballot week, a museum day, and a workplace myth. It is enough to place Chapter 6’s context tools under a story you are already looking at.

If it isn’t clicking

Diagnostic 1 — Dense-prose freeze.

The page will not move; anxiety rises.

Next move: Shorter excerpt — one sentence or one phrase. Gloss honesty. CIV-06 sourcing card only today. Come back tomorrow for then-meaning. Access tools after try; no shame.

Diagnostic 2 — Present-grid only.

Every word snaps to today’s fight.

Next move: Return to then-audience. Write “audience then: ____.” CTX-03 word that shifted on one term. Cover the meme. Star the historic line. Check one misunderstanding against text without a rant.

Diagnostic 3 — Pledge-theater / *Publius* creep / dump hunger.

Reverence or coverage appetite eats the sit.

Next move: CIV-06 refuse; restate audience then; one section only; write the *Publius* pointer card and close the coverage tour. Schedule deep week separately if you want it.

When to slow down: high-emotion civic fight in your feed — practice on a cooler clause first. When to go ahead: sourced excerpt + then-meaning attempt + pledge-theater refused. When to ask a human: librarian for a reliable public-domain edition; community-college noncredit civics door when local; tutor for dense prose strategies — not for a generated Founder letter. A good librarian question sounds like: “I need a short public-domain text of X with clear attribution — I’m practicing sourcing, not writing a brief.” That sentence keeps the hour honest.

Correct yourself without crushing the attempt. “I sloganized” is a useful sticky. Replace with a sourcing card. Anxiety: one phrase win, stop — not a therapy manual.

A fourth quiet failure: you treated the Declaration as a statute, or a preamble phrase as a freestanding warrant for any policy. Genre mix-ups feel like then-meaning but skip the document’s job. Repair: return to Picture 4 or 5; label genre; rewrite the claim as “this text states ____ / it does not by itself enact ____.” Limits again. Limits travel.

Tools, including AI

Point back to the History Refresh Hour AI box.

After you try, you may: ask a tool to explain a *named* clause from a *named* public-domain page (title, URL or edition, today’s micro-goal); isomorphic paraphrase practice with *your* key; labelled SCRIPT of self-questions; revision questions after *your* then-meaning sticky; a hint after an attempt; diagnose a card you already wrote.

During the attempt, you may not: generate a “lost Federalist” or Founder letter as if real; write an op-ed as the only draft; put a model summary on the table as the meaning of the clause; photo-to-key a civic packet; paste proprietary employer policy into a public chat to “compare to the Constitution”; print a literacy certificate; park an agent as partner for the first look.

OpenStax *U.S. History* and Library of Congress materials can supply context cards after you look. They replace thinking when they finish then-meaning for you.

Podcasts that “explain the Founders” are FEED neighbors — host vs text still applies.

Community-college noncredit civics or American government doors, when local, can give you conversation partners and a syllabus map without making AP the adult default. Use them as neighbors to this habit, not as a replacement for unaided looking on short excerpts. CLEP American Government remains optional credit architecture — sitting an exam is not finishing this chapter’s strip. Resources will sort fit, not rank.

If you keep a physical pocket Constitution or a printed amendment page, mark it. Underline once. Sticky once. The object in the bag beats a thousand unread apps. Still source it. Printings have dates and publishers; honesty cards still apply.

What “done enough” looks like

Before you move on:

- One civic excerpt **sourced** (maker / date / audience / genre).
- **Then-meaning** attempted once on a word or phrase.
- **Pledge-theater refused** once (reverence or contempt without attribution caught and repaired).
- *Publius* **pointer known** if you want Federalist/Brutus depth.
- You can ask the locked opening and wait without a platform chant.

Optional: one written / silent / my claim card on a short section. Optional: rights word overlap/gap chart. A certificate is not the work. Survey courses and CLEP remain edges.

Life of the habit (seed). Revisit next Tuesday with a different phrase. Space civic sits across days.⁷² Mix a FEED slogan interloper so primary-before-feed stays sharp on founding lines. File sourcing cards in Keeping track. Chapter 6 will add their-world context, maps, and timelines as tools under a story already being

⁷²Dunlosky and colleagues (2013): distributed practice high utility as technique rating — not an adult-history programme evaluation.

looked at — including the civic stories you began here. Bring your then-meaning stickies forward. Context without a sourced line becomes lecture. A sourced line without any then-world becomes slogan again. You now have the document habit. Next you will place it in a world that is not automatically yours.

If this week only yields one honest genre sentence on a recited fragment, that is enough to place the next sit. Documents return meaning when makers return to the page. Keep the pointer card. Keep the sticky. Keep one excerpt at a time.

Self-placement probe: source before slogan? Then-meaning attempted without party-means-exactly-this? Dump refused? *Publius* door known? If a graduate still pledge-theaters, stay on CIV-06 until attribution sticks. If a new reader sources cleanly and attempts then-meaning, go ahead to context tools — skill strip, not diploma year. No diploma required to open this chapter. No diploma finishes looking.

Chapter 6 — Context, maps, and timelines on the go



Figure 8: A still-life: credited excerpt with a “their world” sticky, annotated outline map, timeline card under an owned story. No people. No logos. No readable UI.

Why this matters

What would have to be true in *their* world — and where / how long as tools, not trivia?

That is not a capitals quiz. It is not a wall of centuries. It is not a sermon about how people in the past were “dumb,” “corrupt,” or “just like us with worse phones.” It is the question that turns background into a tool under a piece you are already looking at. A letter about delay only makes sense if you can feel how long news took. A plaque about a harbor only makes sense if you can point at water and roads. A date only helps after a story has a job and a maker.

You already practiced source before body, Observe–Reflect–Question, feed versus primary, two accounts without liar theater, and civic texts as documents with makers. This chapter adds the next strip: thin contextualization — place and time under a story you own. Presentism is the mind at rest, including for able adults who finished school long ago.⁷³ A period map is a source with a maker. A modern overview map is often a later telling. Dates attach after the story is owned. Process duration and change-and-continuity soft deepen time without turning the hour into a trivia contest.

What this idea unlocks is usable context on the go. On the commute you can catch your own “they were stupid” sentence and rewrite it as one their-world condition. At a desk or on a break you can annotate where on a simple outline map, flag a memoir written later, or stretch an “overnight” event into a credible duration. On a weekend you can treat a period map as a source and build a short chronology card under one owned story. Coverage is a map. Depth is the hour.⁷⁴ You do not need a continent wall this week.

This is worth the struggle because ordinary adult life keeps offering present grids and wallpaper dates. A feed card compresses a century into a caption. A workplace claim about “what the law always said” skips how long a process took. A museum label names a place without asking who commissioned the marker. Context, maps, and timelines are tools under looking — not decoration, not a second textbook, not a culture-war color map.

⁷³Wineburg (1998/1999 grain): presentism as “psychological condition at rest”; historical thinking against the grain of ordinary cognition. Labelled contrast and classroom-origin patterns; not an adult commute RCT. Access pathway via memo 01 / primaries; access date 13 September 2026.

⁷⁴Wineburg (“Crazy for History,” 2004 grain via sister streams): light-rail coverage leaves few traces; depth needs repeated passes. Coverage is a map; depth is the hour.

You do not need to be a geographer or a chronologist. You do need to interrupt presentism without a scold, put one place that belongs to this week's piece on the table, and add one date only under a story already owned. Hearing a deficit-past jab, an atlas slog with no story, or a memoir treated as a same-day witness without a later flag is the work. Filling the silence with a forty-minute lecture is not.

Picture two Fridays. In one, a printed world map hangs over the kitchen table and no one has pointed at the harbor the excerpt actually names. In the other, a simple coast sketch sits under a credited piece; one sticky marks "near here"; a short chain card names three linked events you already looked at; you say what would have to be true about distance and delay for the argument to make sense. Both rooms look busy. Only one built tools you can reuse next Tuesday.

This week you can learn to catch a presentist sentence, write one their-world condition, annotate one place that belongs to the piece, and attach one date under an owned story. Today you can answer the locked opening out loud once and leave with a sticky a stranger could almost follow. Geography appears as maps under stories. Chronology appears as tools under stories. The C3 Framework folds related ideas under an inquiry map; this chapter borrows the tool shape, not a full course and not a statute.⁷⁵ A path through ordinary civic life includes this strip. A fake certificate does not.

If you last opened a founding text in eleventh grade, rust on ratification order or travel times is ordinary. Adulthood is not a civic birthday. Place yourself by the looking-move strip — can you interrupt presentism, use place as constraint, and date after story? — not by diploma year.

Understand it yourself

Everyday picture. You open a short credited excerpt — a letter, a newspaper header, a founding clause you already sourced — and your first private sentence is: "They were stupid not to have [modern tool]," or "They were just corrupt," or "Anyone with common sense would have done X." Stop. Ask: "What would have to be true in *their* world for this to make sense?" Write three constraints:

⁷⁵C3 Framework (NCSS 2013): standards map for inquiry, including history and geography neighbors — not a home RCT, not this book's table of contents, not a statute. Borrow tool shape; refuse curriculum dump.

technology, law, belief, distance, risk. Then put a simple map of the places named on the table, or a date card under the story you just owned. The map did a job. The date did a job. Neither replaced the piece.

Another everyday picture: you walk past a civic plaque on lunch. The bronze says a date and a tidy sentence. You treat the plaque as the whole story. The adult move is MAP-03: who commissioned it, when was it erected, what does it claim, what primary would check it? The plaque is a later telling with a maker. It is still useful. It is not the archive.

Precise picture. *Contextualization* here means reconstructing conditions in *their* world — distance, delay, audience, word meanings, who was and was not at the table — without drowning the excerpt in a lecture and without a deficit-past sneer.⁷⁶ A *period map* is a source: someone made it, for a purpose; what it includes and leaves out is part of the look. A *modern outline map* you annotate is a tool you made; source whether it is period or modern before you treat lines as GPS truth. A *chronology card* is a short line of owned events or documents under one question, not a generated “complete world timeline.” *Process not snap* means many events told as a single day took weeks or years; name one precursor and one aftermath. *Separate understanding from approving* means one sentence that reconstructs reasons in their world and a separate sentence that keeps your present judgment — without collapsing explanation into endorsement, and without replacing looking with pure denunciation.

Wineburg’s familiar-versus-strange warning still holds: even strong readers default to now-sense.⁷⁷ Classroom work has often found sourcing and corroboration easier to move than contextualization; do not pretend one their-world prompt installs period expertise.⁷⁸ That is a useful study pattern, not a promise that every adult will see the same result. Then teach. Knowledge nearby helps — a tiny story

⁷⁶Contextualization as Wineburg heuristic (sourcing, corroboration, contextualization) — space and time under documents; reconstruct conditions without deficit sneer. Classroom studies often find contextualization harder to move than sourcing/corroboration (Nokes et al. 2007 grain; Reisman 2012 classroom-origin shape) — useful pattern, not a promise every adult will see the same result.

⁷⁷Wineburg (1998/1999 grain): presentism as “psychological condition at rest”; historical thinking against the grain of ordinary cognition. Labelled contrast and classroom-origin patterns; not an adult commute RCT. Access pathway via memo 01 / primaries; access date 13 September 2026.

⁷⁸Reisman (2012) Reading Like a Historian: grade 11 classroom; Historical Thinking $\eta p^2 = .09$ (labelled classroom-origin; shape only). Materials $\neq$ automatic discussion. Not an adult history RCT.

the piece can carry — without a light-rail tour of the century.⁷⁹

Think of three layers you can actually hold in one sitting. Layer one is the piece: who made it, when, for whom. Layer two is thin context: one distance, one delay, one word sense, one absent group labelled evidenced or guessed. Layer three is the tool card: a place sticky, a duration sticky, a chronology of three nodes max. If layer three arrives without layer one, you have wallpaper. If layer two arrives as a scold, you have a sermon. If all three stay under one question, you have an hour.

A composite illustration (labelled as such — not a reported workplace or court case): you read a short historic newspaper notice about a delayed shipment. Your first thought is “why didn’t they just call?” CTX-02 asks how long news and goods took; MAP-04 asks what route or port constrained them; TIME-05 asks whether “delayed” was a day or a season. You still may judge the decision. You first rebuild the world the decision sat in.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **Deficit-past sermon.** “They were dumb / primitive / just corrupt.” Repair: the their-world prompt; one condition stated without sneer; point back at the line. Presentism is rest, not a character flaw.⁸⁰
2. **Atlas wallpaper.** Capitals colored, continents named, no story owned, no sticky on a place the piece actually cares about. Repair: one question the map can answer; annotate where for *this* excerpt only.
3. **Dates as trivia.** Year-first freeze, or a fluent century chant with no owned story. Repair: date after story — own the narrative, *then* attach the date as a tool and ask what the date changes.
4. **Memoir as same-day witness without a later flag.** A reminiscence written decades later treated as if it were a diary from the day. Repair: double-date honesty card — event date and composition date; name memory and politics risks softly.

⁷⁹Wineburg (“Crazy for History,” 2004 grain via sister streams): light-rail coverage leaves few traces; depth needs repeated passes. Coverage is a map; depth is the hour.

⁸⁰Wineburg (1998/1999 grain): presentism as “psychological condition at rest”; historical thinking against the grain of ordinary cognition. Labelled contrast and classroom-origin patterns; not an adult commute RCT. Access pathway via memo 01 / primaries; access date 13 September 2026.

5. **Culture-war color map / excuse-everything reverse.** A modern political color scheme pasted onto the past as the hour's spine — or the opposite: “understanding” used to excuse every practice without a separate judgment line. Repair: period or outline map under *this* piece; CTX-06 when a practice you reject appears — understand and approve are different verbs.

Five-minute warm-up

Before any try-it, cover this page and work aloud:

- Catch one presentist sentence you have said (or almost said) this month about “people back then.” Rewrite it as: “What would have to be true in their world for ____ to make sense?”
- Name three candidate constraints (technology, law, belief, distance, risk). Keep the ones that touch *this* piece.
- Point at one place the piece names — even if only on a phone map sketch — and say one sentence: “Near here / along this route / across this water mattered because ____.”
- Cover every year. Tell the story in one sentence. Only then uncover one date and ask what changes.
- Write the locked opening on a sticky. Cut any second continent you do not need.

That is enough for tomorrow's micro-session.

How to try it this week

Use the History Refresh Hour shapes you already have. This week's idea is context, place, and time as tools under a story. Struggle before rescue. Try unaided first. Knowledge first: know the their-world prompt and “date after story” well enough to hear wallpaper and deficit sneers, then practice on surfaces you already meet.

Session shape across bands

Commute / lunch (about 15–20 minutes).

Warm-up retrieval (3–4 minutes): one presentist sentence rewritten; one place

sticky; one “date after story” card.

Short model (3–4 minutes): a solved their-world sticky under a short credited line you already sourced — three constraints, one without sneer.

Your attempt (5–6 minutes): CTX-01 on a puzzling action in a primary, or TIME-01 on a short narrative without dates first, or MAP-03 on a plaque photo you already took.

One good self-question: the locked opening; wait a slow three.

Mixed glance (2 minutes): TIME-04 — does this memoir show a composition date later than the events?

Exit sticky (1 minute): one their-world condition *or* one owned date under a story *or* one place annotation with a reason.

Desk or shift (about 25–40 minutes).

Warm-up mixed from last week’s civic or corroboration strip plus one their-world sentence (5 minutes).

Look first (8–12 minutes): source the piece; Observe–Reflect–Question lightly; then one CTX move (CTX-02 technology/distance gap, CTX-03 word that shifted, CTX-04 who else in the room, or CTX-05 process not snap).

Short model / fade a step (5 minutes): annotate where on a simple outline map (MAP-01) or rewrite a “why didn’t they just...” complaint without deficit (CTX-02). Cover the model answer and try it yourself.

Two tries plus one interloper (10–12 minutes): one clean their-world sticky; one map or duration sticky; one interloper that offers atlas wallpaper or a year chant with no story.

Self-question + wait + written reason (3 minutes).

Exit ticket: “their-world / place / date-after-story.”

Weekend deep sit (about 45–75 minutes when needed).

Diagnostic wrong twin (10 minutes): present grid only — repair with CTX-01 and, if needed, CTX-06.

Longer look (15–20 minutes): MAP-02 period map as source (ORQ; what makers emphasized; what is distorted for purpose) *or* TIME-02 chain chronology card under three linked events you already own.

Thin context weave (10 minutes): one route/port constraint (MAP-04) or one change-and-continuity pair (TIME-03).

Mixed set (15–20 minutes): pair MAP-02 with TIME-02; or plaque photo (MAP-03 / OUT-03) with a their-world sentence and a check plan against a primary.

Done-enough checklist.

Schedule three micro cues for next week on a calendar (their-world catch; date

after story; local marker). Spacing across days beats a Sunday dump.⁸¹

Exact wording you can say to yourself

When a present grid arrives, or a map hangs unused, or a year sits before any story:

“What would have to be true in *their* world — and where / how long as tools, not trivia?”

Then wait. Cover the answer if you drafted one. Look at the credit line, the map, the plaque, or the clock — not at a feed summary or a chatbot précis. After you answer, ask one follow-up from the box below. Then try a parallel item with a new piece.

Other lines that help:

- “What three constraints would make this action make sense then?”
- “Is this map period or modern — and who made it?”
- “What question can this map answer — and what can it not?”
- “Own the story first. Attach the date second. What does the date change?”
- “I understand X as . ***I do not approve because .***” (CTX-06 — two sentences, not one mush)
- “Event date ____ / written later ____.” (TIME-04)

First try-it this week

On the go — their-world catch (15 minutes).

Materials: one sticky, a pen, one short primary or civic excerpt you already hold (public-domain or archive-credited), or a puzzling line from a historic newspaper page.

Safety: ordinary stakes; no culture-war sting; no public quiz of a colleague; no pasting proprietary employer text into a public tool.

The move: Catch your own presentist snap if it appears. Ask the locked opening. Write three constraints. Circle one that the piece actually needs. Exit: three-constraint sticky without sneer. That is CTX-01.

Deeper sit — period map + chronology under one story (45–60 minutes).

Materials: one period map with maker/date (library, LOC Free to Use, museum

⁸¹Dunlosky et al. (2013): practice testing / distributed practice high utility — technique ratings, not an adult-history RCT of this book’s objects. Spacing across days is honest ambition.

site) or a modern outline map you will label as modern; three short linked documents or events you already looked at this month; paper.

Safety: credit the map; do not file a generated “period map” as an archival primary; composite illustrations labelled as such.

The move: Run ORQ on the map (MAP-02). Annotate where for the week’s story (MAP-01). Order the three events; label each link as cause?, precondition?, or later memory? — with a hedge (TIME-02). Attach dates only after the order is owned (TIME-01). Exit: purpose/distortion sticky + ordered chain with link labels.

How to fade help

First week of this strip: full templates (“three constraints / place sticky / story → date”).

Next: blank sticky — you supply the labels.

Then: one spoken their-world sentence and one place or date tool, no template.

Stop looking up when you can interrupt a presentist sentence and attach one date or place under an owned story without peeking at this chapter’s wording. When a tool is tempting mid-attempt, point back to the History Refresh Hour rule: unaided first.

Talk-to-yourself box

Opening (locked):

“What would have to be true in *their* world — and where / how long as tools, not trivia?”

Follow-ups:

1. What do you mean, *their* world — which constraint are you naming? (*meaning*)
2. What does the map / credit line / plaque show before the body? (*representation*)
3. Is there another reading of this distance, delay, or word that still fits the piece? (*alternative*)
4. What can this map or this date *not* tell me? (*check*)

5. You may change your mind — where could someone go wrong with wall-paper dates or a deficit sneer? (*revise / diagnose*)

How to wait alone. After you ask, cover any answer you drafted. Count a slow three.⁸² If you stop mid-reason, wait again before peeking. Look at the credit line, the map, the plaque, or the clock — not at the phone’s answer key or the feed. Rescue at one second is still rescue. Abandonment for forty minutes of scrolling is not a micro-session.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was vague; wait-time 1 was zero; you are hunting for a year you think a teacher wants; you offered a keyword where a looking move was asked for; atlas anxiety is eating working memory; a finished-looking chatbot “context paragraph” feels like a check — shorten the session, win one their-world sticky or one date-after-story card, come back tomorrow. Your job is to pose, wait, and point back at the object — not to fill the silence with a model summary of the century.

Practice that actually builds it

Plaques, period maps, and short owned stories **are** the practice — they still do not replace the structure: their-world before sneer, place as constraint, date after story. Tips and tricks below are teachable moves, not slogans. Banks are menus, not calendars.

Named try-its (CTX, MAP, TIME)

1. CTX-01 Their World Prompt — commute / lunch or desk

Time: 15–20 minutes.

Materials: one puzzling action or belief in a primary; sticky.

Safety: no scold; no culture-war sermon; ordinary stakes.

The move: Ask what would have to be true in *their* world. Write three constraints (technology, law, belief, distance, risk). Exit: three-constraint sticky. Refuse presentism sermon and excuse-everything sermon alike.

⁸²Stahl (1994) think-time / Rowe (1972) wait-time — classroom-origin; adult translation = pause before lookup. Keep it labelled classroom-origin — not an adult history RCT. A slow three is a convention, not a sacrament.

2. CTX-02 Technology / Distance Gap Without Deficit — commute / lunch

Time: 10–15 minutes.

Materials: a labelled travel-time or communication-speed estimate card (estimate, not gospel).

Safety: estimates labelled estimates; no sneer at past actors.

The move: How long for news or people to move? Rewrite a “why didn’t they just...” complaint as a question without deficit. Exit: revised question.

3. TIME-01 Date After Story — commute / lunch

Time: 10–15 minutes.

Materials: short narrative with dates covered first.

The move: Own the story in one or two sentences. *Then* attach dates as tools. Ask what the date changes. Exit: story → date card. Refuse date trivia before any story.

4. TIME-04 Memoir Written Later Flag — commute / lunch or desk

Time: 10–15 minutes.

Materials: memoir or reminiscence dated long after events (archive-credited).

The move: Flag composition date vs event date. Name memory and politics risks softly. Exit: double-date honesty card. Refuse memoir as instantaneous primary without flag.

5. MAP-03 Local Marker Spot — on the go (OUT-adjacent)

Time: 15–20 minutes (walk or photo you already have).

Materials: local historical marker or courthouse/civic plaque (photo OK).

Safety: ordinary noticing; no sting; no cold public quiz of strangers; consent for people in photos.

The move: Who commissioned? When erected? What is claimed? What primary would check it? Exit: commissioning = sourcing note. Pair with OUT-03 when you are at a courthouse or civic building. Refuse plaque as final word.

6. CTX-06 Separate Understanding from Approving — desk (care)

Time: 20–30 minutes.

Materials: primary that includes a practice you reject; care with holiday/remembrance labels when relevant.

Safety: no live controversy as the object; no graphic harm; public-domain or archive-credited text.

The move: Explain in their-world terms. Explicitly separate *understand* from *endorse*. One ethical line of your own without rewriting their motives as yours. Exit: “I understand X as ; ***I do not approve because*** .” Refuse collapsing

explanation into endorsement — or into pure denunciation without looking.

7. CTX-03 Word That Shifted — desk

Time: 20–25 minutes.

Materials: one word in a civic or historic text whose sense shifted (for example “domestic,” “commerce,” or another word the surrounding lines can carry — skip inventing a lexicon page — use context and a named reference if needed).

The move: Surrounding lines; possible then-senses; modern false-friend warning; named reference if needed after you try. Exit: then-sense vs false-friend sticky. Refuse weaponizing ambiguity.

8. CTX-04 Who Else Was in the Room — desk

Time: 20–25 minutes.

Materials: narrative that names one hero or villain.

The move: List unmentioned groups or roles; mark which are evidenced vs guessed. Exit: two evidenced absences + one guess labelled guess. Refuse inventing people to fit a pamphlet.

9. CTX-05 Process Not Snap + TIME-05 Process Duration — desk

Time: 25–35 minutes.

Materials: event often told as a single day.

The move: Stretch into weeks or years; name one precursor and one aftermath (CTX-05). Minimum credible duration; what had to be built or negotiated (TIME-05). Exit: process timeline (five nodes max) + duration sticky. Refuse instant-revolution myth as the only story and snap-history for shareable feed arcs.

10. MAP-01 Annotate Where — desk

Time: 20–30 minutes.

Materials: blank or outline map; this week’s events.

The move: Place 3–5 sites; one arrow for movement; source the map itself (modern vs period). Exit: photo or sticky of annotated map. Refuse map without sourcing whether period or modern.

11. MAP-04 Route / Port Constraint — desk

Time: 20–30 minutes.

Materials: route narrative + map.

The move: Time/distance constraint; rewrite an impossible “they easily...” line. Exit: constraint sentence. Refuse ignoring terrain or sea as flavor text.

12. MAP-05 Border Line Soft — desk

Time: 20–30 minutes.

Materials: map showing a disputed or changing border (historic, credited).

The move: What changed; for whom; on whose authority labelled. Exit: change note + uncertainty. Refuse present border as eternal. No culture-war color map as the hour.

13. TIME-02 Chain Chronology Card — desk or weekend

Time: 25–40 minutes.

Materials: three linked events or documents you already looked at.

The move: Order them; name the link (cause? precondition? later memory?) with a hedge. Exit: ordered chain with link labels. Refuse causation from sequence alone without hedge.

14. TIME-03 Change and Continuity Soft — desk or weekend

Time: 25–35 minutes.

Materials: two moments on the same theme.

The move: One change; one continuity; evidence for each. Exit: change/continuity pair. Refuse “everything changed” / “nothing changed.”

15. MAP-02 Period Map as Source — weekend deep sit

Time: 40–60 minutes.

Materials: period map with maker/date (library, archive site, LOC Free to Use).

The move: Observe–Reflect–Question; what did makers emphasize?; what is distorted for purpose? Exit: purpose/distortion sticky. Refuse period map as GPS truth. Optional weekend pair: MAP-02 + TIME-02 under one owned story.

16. OUT-03 plaque with MAP-03 — weekend or lunch walk

Time: 20–40 minutes.

Materials: local plaque; phone for attribution photo if allowed.

Safety: public space; ordinary noticing; no undercover audit.

The move: MAP-03 steps; optional civic-clause link if a founding line is quoted. Exit: commissioning + claim check plan against a primary later.

Talk-to-yourself while you practice

TALK-03 Their World Round (desk). Use CTX-01 as talk: speak three constraints; wait; add a fourth or revise. Exit: revised constraint list. Refuse monologue denunciation.

Keep TALK-01 energy from earlier chapters: attribution before plot summary when a new piece arrives. This chapter’s talk load is their-world and place/time

tools — not a second feed chapter.

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked (new move). One their-world prompt *or* one map annotation *or* one date-after-story card. CTX-01, MAP-01, or TIME-01 alone. No second continent. No extra century chant “for enrichment.”

Mixed (when the move is stable). Pair MAP-03 with a their-world sentence the same day. Pair CTX-02 with MAP-04. Pair MAP-02 with TIME-02 on a weekend. Pair CTX-05 with TIME-05. Pair CTX-06 with a careful primary when you are ready — still one focus.

Hypothesized week menu (composite — not a calendar)

Monday: CTX-01 on a short primary. Tuesday: TIME-01 date after story. Wednesday: MAP-03 local marker on a lunch walk. Thursday: CTX-06 when a careful primary needs the two-sentence exit. Friday: exit sticky — “their-world / place / date.” Optional weekend: MAP-02 + TIME-02. That shape is ambition, not an RCT. Pick one focus if the week is hard.

One incorrect example to diagnose (composite illustration)

Feed card (described, no product chrome): “Why people in the 1700s were too stupid to solve [tidy modern problem] — a 40-second explain.”

Your private note: “Yeah, they should have just...”

Later: you open a credited letter about delay and distance. You still keep the sneer.

What went wrong. Present grid first; feed summary as floor; no their-world constraints; place and time treated as trivia or ignored.

Repair. Cover the feed. Source the letter. Ask the locked opening. Write three constraints without sneer. Annotate where. Attach the date after the story. Label the feed card a later telling. The letter is the look; the card is not.

If it isn't clicking

No shame. Correct a wrong reason without crushing the attempt — applied to yourself. Short sessions and early wins beat a countdown timer as default “rigor.” This is not a therapy manual.

1. Context becomes a lecture.

Symptom: you are ten minutes into background and have not asked a their-world question about *this* piece; or you pasted a chatbot “context paragraph” as the hour.
Next move: one their-world sentence only (CTX-01). Cover the encyclopedia voice. Point back at the line. If dense prose is the blocker, shorten the excerpt, then return to the looking move. Slow down here. Do not add a second continent to “enrich” a stuck Monday.

2. Map as decoration.

Symptom: a pretty map on the table; no sticky; no question the map can answer; or a modern overview treated as the whole past.
Next move: one question the map can answer (MAP-01 or MAP-02). Source whether period or modern. Annotate one place that belongs to this week's story. Ask what the map cannot tell. Then stop. Do not scold yourself for “not being a map person.”

3. Date-trivia anxiety.

Symptom: silence while you hunt a year; or a fluent century with no owned story; or memoir dates collapsed into event dates.
Next move: cover every date. Own one story (TIME-01). Attach one date. Ask what changes. If a memoir is in play, run TIME-04 double-date. Say aloud: “I do not need a year someone else is waiting for. I need a their-world condition or a place I can show.”

When to slow down. One sticky and a their-world sentence are not stable. Archaic place-names are the blocker — scaffold the reading, then return. Living-memory or family-artifact work needs consent you do not yet have — skip those versions until you do. Anxiety is eating working memory — shorten to one micro; early win; return tomorrow.

When to go ahead. You state a their-world condition without sneer, place a sticky with a reason from the line, attach a date after the story, and separate understanding from approving once when the piece needs it. Then MAP-02, TIME-02, MAP-05, or a weekend OUT plaque is fair.

When to ask a human. A librarian can help you find a period map or a local marker’s commissioning history. A tutor or community class can sit with archaic place-names. A colleague can be a second pair of eyes on a public plaque — not a quiz victim. Ask for help locating sources and checking a sticky. Do not ask anyone to finish your looking for you.

Tools, including AI

Optional helpers. Keep this short. Point back to the History Refresh Hour AI box. Do not turn this chapter into an AI policy paper.

After you have tried, you may:

- Explain a their-world constraint *to yourself* from a named lesson, page, or credited primary (title, page, today’s micro-goal).
- Extra isomorphic practice with answers on **your** page (blank outline map + your key; chronology card + your key).
- A labelled SCRIPT after you tried — a short spoken sequence for *you* to say, not a paragraph to copy as your work.
- A hint after an attempt. A hint is not the finished answer.
- Diagnose a sticky or annotated map you already made (crop to paper — no face).

You may not during the attempt:

- Paste tonight’s map packet or employer sheet and ask a tool to complete it (photo-to-key).
- Ask a model to generate a “period map” or a “complete chronology” and file it as archival fact without credit.
- Put a model summary on the table as the source of context.
- Generate a diary or letter from then as if it were a real primary.
- Park an unsupervised chatbot as your only partner during the attempt.
- Paste proprietary employer data into a public consumer tool.

Labelled archive / LOC / OpenStax pages may check or explore **after** the try; they replace thinking when they finish the attempt. Blank timeline and map practice with **your** key after looking is fair. Invented chronology filed as archival fact is not.

One mechanism sentence, labelled OFF-AGE for literacy/history: in a high-school math field experiment, an unguarded chatbot made practice look better and left students worse on the test with the window closed.⁸³ **Not an adult history RCT. Not this history band.** The lunch-break rule it supports: the model may prepare you and the next looking page; it may not do your looking, sourcing, contextualization, claim, or map annotation when those are the lesson.

What “done enough” looks like

Short looking-move checklist before moving on. Placement by skill, not diploma year. A “civic literacy certificate” is a receipt this book never invents — and is not the work.

You are done enough with this chapter’s strip when you can honestly check most of these:

- ☐ I interrupted presentism once with a their-world sentence (three constraints or one strong condition) without a sneer.
- ☐ I used where or how long as a **tool** under a story I owned — not as wallpaper and not as trivia.
- ☐ I sourced a map as period or modern (or a plaque as commissioned) at least once.
- ☐ I attached a date **after** a story at least once — or flagged a memoir’s composition date vs event date.
- ☐ I separated understanding from approving once when a practice I reject appeared (or I know the two-sentence exit and can run it next).
- ☐ I refused atlas wallpaper, deficit-past sermon, and generated-map-as-primary at least once in practice.
- ☐ My exit sticky could almost be shown to a stranger: their-world / place / date-after-story.

Life-of-the-habit tip (not a ninth teaching chapter). Revisit next Tuesday: one their-world catch on the commute; one plaque or map sticky when life allows;

⁸³Bastani et al. (2025), *PNAS*: Turkish high-school math, grades 9–11, nearly 1,000 students; unguarded chatbot helped practice scores and hurt unaided post-test relative to control patterns reported in that study — **OFF-AGE for literacy/history**; not an adult history RCT. Lunch-break rule only.

space across days. Mix last week's piece. Stop while a look remains. Keeping track of dated stickies lives in Chapter 8.

Self-placement probe (skill strip, not diploma year): Can you catch a presentist sentence and rewrite it without a sneer? Can you ask one question a map can answer before you decorate it? Can you attach one date after one owned story — and flag a memoir written later? If yes on most days this week, the strip is moving. If not, stay here. Do not leap to a short civic claim chapter to “catch up” while presentism still writes your first sentence.

Optional bridge: if credit is your goal later, chronology and map tools support survey courses and optional CLEP edges — they are not the spine of this hour, and sitting an exam is not finishing looking practice.

You do not need to be a historian. You do need to hear “they were stupid,” a map with no question, and a year before any story — and to ask the locked question before you nod. You can do this on the commute and in a deeper sit.

Chapter 7 — Talking and writing a short civic claim



Figure 9: A still-life: dated notebook with claim / evidence / warrant / limit labelled, short credited excerpt, pencil. No people. No logos. No readable UI.

Why this matters

What do I claim — which named source shows it — and what does this claim not settle?

That is not a timed Advanced Placement essay. It is not a request for a fluent paragraph a machine could have written. It is not a campaign speech. It is the question that turns looking into a sentence another person can check. A claim without a source is a vibe. A source named with no claim is a caption. A warrant that only restates the claim is a shrug in fancy clothes. A claim with no limit pretends one excerpt finished the fight. History talk for an adult on the go is a claim that points. History writing for an adult on the go is the same claim, slower, on a dated page — with a warrant and a named limit.

You already practiced source before body, Observe–Reflect–Question, feed versus primary, two accounts without liar theater, civic texts as documents, and context/maps/time as tools. This chapter is the exit strip for the teaching arc: short claim craft after looking — not instead of looking. Writing here is claim + named source + warrant + limit. It is not a weekly AP Document-Based Question. An occasional weekend two-source mini-argument is enough when paragraphs are stable. Dual perspective appears when prompted — one other-side best point — not as an unprompted demand every exit.⁸⁴

What this idea unlocks is usable civic speech and a short written claim you could almost show a stranger. On the commute you can write a source sentence first, point to a line, or limit an overwide claim. At a desk you can add a warrant, paraphrase a civic clause without smuggling a platform, and refuse a model summary as the source of your paragraph. On a weekend you can weave two sourced notes into 120–180 words with a limit — still not a five-paragraph costume.

This is worth the struggle because ordinary adult life rewards fluency and punishes pointing. You can talk for five minutes about a founding dispute without touching a line. A feed card finishes the moral for you. A chatbot offers a tidy précis that feels like homework done. Looking without a short claim leaves you fluent at noticing and silent at deciding what the piece can support. A short claim without looking is theater. The hour needs both — in that order.

⁸⁴Kuhn & Udell / Kuhn & Crowell grain (via memo 01/02): dual perspective when prompted; unprompted dual-function is not the adult default even under favorable conditions. Prompt add-one; do not assume. Not an adult history RCT of this book's objects.

You do not need to be a historian. You do need to hear a thesis without evidence, a copied model summary filed as your claim, dual-function demanded unprompted every time, and AP-DBQ-as-weekly-identity — and to ask the locked question, then wait. Hearing those wrong turns is the work. Filling the silence with a perfect paragraph from a window is not.

Picture two Fridays. In one, the notebook holds a tidy summary that could have come from any review page — or from a chat window. In the other, a short paragraph names a credited excerpt, points at a starred line, warrants why that line counts, and admits what the claim does not settle. Both pages look like writing. Only one is civic looking on paper.

If you used *Critical Thinking for Adults*, you already practiced myside and dual-perspective craft on ordinary present stakes. One pointer — then history: a spoken or written claim about a *past* piece, with the maker in the sentence. Keep judgment batteries in that book — this hour stays on history claim craft.⁸⁵ Monte-Sano's neighbor grain for historical writing is the spine here: claim, evidence, corroboration, contextualization of evidence — taught, not hoped into existence by rewriting the same summary.⁸⁶ That is a useful study pattern, not a promise that every adult will see the same result. Then teach.

This week you can learn to model one claim sentence that names the source, one warrant stem, one limit sentence, and — when prompted — one other-side best point. Today you can write: “According to [credit], ... because This evidence counts because This claim does not settle” A path through ordinary civic life includes this strip. A fake certificate does not. Optional credit exams live later if credit is your goal. For now: one good question, one starred line, one cautious sentence.

Wilke and colleagues caution that inquiry looking does not automatically mint democratic dispositions.⁸⁷ Looking still matters. Citizenship is not a button this

⁸⁵*Critical Thinking for Adults* holds myside / dual-perspective argument craft on ordinary present stakes — one pointer, then history. Stanovich myside batteries, CCTST, and Watson–Glaser stay in *Critical Thinking for Adults* — not in this chapter's body.

⁸⁶Monte-Sano neighbor (historical argument writing): instruction toward claim, evidence, corroboration, contextualization of evidence; regular summary writing alone does not install those features. Useful pattern; not a promise every adult will see the same result. Solo check: delete the quotation; does the claim still stand?

⁸⁷Wilke, Depaepe, Van Nieuwenhuyse (2022 grain via memo 01): inquiry / historical thinking practice ≠ automatic democratic dispositions. Looking is still the hour's work; citizenship is not minted by finishing a claim sticky.

chapter presses. The promise is usable claim craft on pieces you actually meet — ballot pamphlet language, museum caption honesty, a short founding excerpt as a sourced object, a workplace policy claim about “what the law always said” at ordinary stakes. Money, workplaces, and civic life motivate. They do not replace the looking move.

Understand it yourself

Everyday picture. You have an opinion about a founding dispute, a plaque sentence, or a historic newspaper fight. You can talk for five minutes. Someone asks, “Which line shows that?” You gesture at the air. The adult repair is TALK-02 and ARG-01: finger or cursor on the supporting line; if you cannot point, retract or hedge. Then WRITE-01: first sentence names maker, date, type; second sentence may interpret. Then ARG-02: “This counts as evidence because ____.” Then ARG-06: what this claim does not settle.

Another everyday picture: a chatbot offers a fluent paragraph about “what the document meant.” You paste it into your note as your draft. WRITE-05 is the refuse: strike any sentence that only rests on the model; replace from the primary; redline. The model may ask revision questions **after** your draft. It may not be the only draft.

Precise picture. A *claim* here is a sentence about the past (or about what a civic text says as a historical object) that could be wrong and that the piece can speak to. *Evidence* is a starred line — something another person can find. A *warrant* ties the evidence to the claim: why *this* line counts for *that* claim (genre, proximity, corroboration, audience) — not a restatement of the claim. A *limit* is one honest sentence about what this source cannot tell or what the claim does not settle (time, place, population, or source hedge). A *source sentence first* opener names maker/date/type before interpretation. *Quote vs paraphrase*: quote only if the words uniquely matter; otherwise paraphrase and cite; never orphan fragments. *Add-one* (TALK-04): force one additional interpretation consistent with the same evidence; mark which fits better and why. *Counter soft* (ARG-03): steelman one pressure on your claim; adjust scope — without burning a strawman.

Talk is not a luxury before writing. Authentic questions — questions where you

have not already scripted the answer for yourself — are the spirit of the talk box.⁸⁸ Materials do not discuss themselves. Wait before the feed when the urge to share arrives (TALK-05). Stuck silence gets a diagnosis, not forty minutes of scrolling (TALK-06). Accountable to the text soft (TALK-07): what in *this* text would change your mind? If nothing could, you are not doing history this hour.

A composite illustration (labelled as such — not a reported workplace): you meet a policy memo that says “the statute has always required X.” Your first draft is a three-paragraph rant. The adult sequence is different. Source the statute text or a short historic excerpt the memo gestures at (if public). WRITE-01. Star the line that actually speaks to X. ARG-01. ARG-02 — why that line counts (genre, date, who is restrained). ARG-06 — what the claim does not settle (later amendments, agency guidance you have not opened, cases not on the table). Optional ARG-05: what did the memo’s maker want you to believe? You still may disagree with the policy. You first refuse vibe citations and model summaries as the floor.

Without a teacher, adults skip warrants (“the quote is obvious”). ARG-02 and TALK-02 exist because *you* are the easy audience to con.⁸⁹ Practice alone is not enough if practice means rewriting the same summary. The solo check stays: delete the quotation; does the claim still stand? If yes, the quote was decoration.

Wrong answers you should be able to hear

1. **Thesis without evidence.** “They wanted liberty.” No clause, no maker. Repair: “Which named source shows it?” Star a line or return to the source card.
2. **Copied model summary as claim.** Fluent encyclopedia voice; précis filed as primary or as the week’s evidence. Repair: WRITE-05; close the window; write from the piece in view; tool only after a real draft, as revision questions — not a rewrite.
3. **Warrant that only restates the claim.** “This supports my claim because

⁸⁸Authentic / accountable talk neighbors (Nystrand; Accountable Talk checklist grain via sister streams): questions without a prescribed recitation answer; debt to the text (“how do you know?”). Borrow as craft. Do not treat professional-development checklists as an adult history trial.

⁸⁹Monte-Sano neighbor (historical argument writing): instruction toward claim, evidence, corroboration, contextualization of evidence; regular summary writing alone does not install those features. Useful pattern; not a promise every adult will see the same result. Solo check: delete the quotation; does the claim still stand?

my claim is true.” Repair: “Why does *that line* count for *that claim*?” One warrant stem (ARG-02).

4. **Dual-function demanded unprompted / myside fluency without limit.**

You require a full other-side essay every micro-session — or you never name a limit. Repair: prompt one other-side best point when the week holds two voices (TALK-04); always run ARG-06 once; point to *Critical Thinking for Adults* once for myside craft — keep judgment batteries in that book.^{90 91}

5. **AP DBQ as weekly identity / write-my-op-ed as practice.** Five-paragraph costume; timed multi-document every Wednesday; “write my op-ed” as the only draft. Repair: ARG-04 / WRITE-04 as occasional weekend stretch when sourced paragraphs with warrant are stable; refuse DBQ dump as spine; ban write-op-ed as only draft.

A sixth worth hearing: **quote salad** — three copied lines and no sentence of your own. Repair: WRITE-02; sentence 1 names writer, date, type; then one claim; then one support; then warrant; then limit.

Five-minute warm-up

Before any try-it, cover this page and work aloud:

- Star one line in a short credited excerpt you already hold. Write one claim that would *weaken* if that line vanished (ARG-01).
- Write a source sentence first: maker, date, type (WRITE-01). Only then write one interpretive sentence.
- Add one warrant stem: “This counts as evidence because ____.”
- Add one limit: “This claim does not settle ____.”
- Point to the line with finger or cursor. If you cannot point, retract.
- Write the locked opening on a sticky. Cut any second excerpt you do not need for a first claim.

That is enough for tomorrow’s micro-session.

⁹⁰Kuhn & Udell / Kuhn & Crowell grain (via memo 01/02): dual perspective when prompted; unprompted dual-function is not the adult default even under favorable conditions. Prompt add-one; do not assume. Not an adult history RCT of this book’s objects.

⁹¹*Critical Thinking for Adults* holds myside / dual-perspective argument craft on ordinary present stakes — one pointer, then history. Stanovich myside batteries, CCTST, and Watson–Glaser stay in *Critical Thinking for Adults* — not in this chapter’s body.

How to try it this week

Use the History Refresh Hour shapes you already have. This week's idea is talk and a short civic claim after looking. Struggle before rescue. Try unaided first. Knowledge first: know claim / evidence / warrant / limit well enough to hear vibe citations, then practice on pieces you already meet.

Session shape across bands

Commute / lunch (about 15–20 minutes).

Warm-up retrieval (3–4 minutes): one source sentence; one starred line; one limit stem.

Short model (3–4 minutes): a solved two-sentence opener (WRITE-01) under a line you already sourced — then cover it.

Your attempt (5–6 minutes): WRITE-01, TALK-02 point to the line, ARG-06 limit your claim, or TALK-05 wait before feed on a history-adjacent card you already saw.

One good self-question: the locked opening; wait a slow three.

Mixed glance (2 minutes): delete the quotation in your head — does the claim still stand? If yes, the quote was decoration.⁹²

Exit sticky (1 minute): “According to [credit], ... because ...; this does not settle ...”

Desk or shift (about 25–40 minutes).

Warm-up mixed from last week's context or civic strip plus one source sentence (5 minutes).

Look first (8–12 minutes): source the piece; short Observe–Reflect–Question; star one line.

Short model / fade a step (5 minutes): ARG-01 claim from starred line + ARG-02 warrant; cover the model and try yourself.

Two tries plus one interloper (10–12 minutes): one clean claim+warrant; one limit

⁹²Monte-Sano neighbor (historical argument writing): instruction toward claim, evidence, corroboration, contextualization of evidence; regular summary writing alone does not install those features. Useful pattern; not a promise every adult will see the same result. Solo check: delete the quotation; does the claim still stand?

sentence; one interloper that is a model précis tempting you to file it as source (WRITE-05 refuse).

Self-question + wait + written reason (3 minutes).

Exit ticket: claim / named source / warrant / limit.

Weekend deep sit (about 45–75 minutes when needed).

Diagnostic wrong twin (10 minutes): thesis without evidence — repair from a starred line.

Longer write (20–30 minutes): ARG-04 two-source mini-argument (≤ 150 words) or WRITE-04 two-source paragraph (120–180 words) with warrant and limit.

Add-one / counter soft (10 minutes): TALK-04 one other-side best point or ARG-03 steelman + scoped claim.

Revision pass (10–15 minutes): WRITE-06 evidence weave on *your* draft — high-light claims without evidence; add or cut; one corroboration phrase if available.

Done-enough checklist.

Schedule three micro cues for next week (source sentence first; point to the line; limit sentence). Spacing across days beats a Sunday dump.⁹³

Exact wording you can say to yourself

When you are about to summarize, share, or “just write”:

“What do I claim — which named source shows it — and what does this claim not settle?”

Then wait. Cover any answer you drafted. Look at the credit line or the starred line — not at the feed or a chatbot précis. After you answer, ask one follow-up from the box below. Then try a parallel item.

Other lines that help:

- “According to [maker / title / date], ...”
- “Point to the line — or retract.”
- “This counts as evidence because ____.”
- “This claim does not settle ____.”
- “What’s the other interpretation that still fits this evidence?”
- “What in *this* text would change my mind?”

⁹³Dunlosky et al. (2013): practice testing / distributed practice high utility — technique ratings, not an adult-history RCT. Spacing across days is honest ambition.

- “I do not need a pretty paragraph. I need a named source, a warrant, and a limit.”

First try-it this week

On the go — source sentence first (15 minutes).

Materials: blank note or sticky; one short credited primary or civic excerpt.

Safety: public-domain or archive-credited text; no proprietary paste into a public tool; no live controversy as the object.

The move: First sentence must name maker/date/type. Second sentence may interpret. Exit: two-sentence opener (WRITE-01). Refuse interpretation-first paragraph.

Deeper sit — claim, warrant, limit from a starred line (30–40 minutes).

Materials: primary with one starred sentence; paper.

Safety: composite examples labelled if you invent a workplace-policy claim about “what the law always said” — ordinary stakes, not HR advice.

The move: Write a claim that depends on the starred line (ARG-01). Add warrant (ARG-02). Add limit (ARG-06). Point to the line (TALK-02). Optional: one add-one interpretation (TALK-04). Exit: claim + citation + warrant + limit.

How to fade help

First week of this strip: full frame — “I claim ____ because [name] shows . ***This evidence counts because*** . This claim does not settle ____.”

Next: blank sticky — you supply the four parts.

Then: one spoken claim that names a source, plus a limit, no frame.

Stop looking up when you can refuse a vibe citation and write a limit without peeking at this chapter’s wording. When a tool is tempting mid-attempt, point back to the History Refresh Hour: unaided first; revision questions after *your* draft only.

Talk-to-yourself box

Opening (locked):

“What do I claim — which named source shows it — and what does this claim not settle?”

Follow-ups:

1. What do you mean by the claim — can you say it in one sentence? (*meaning*)
2. What does the credit line / starred line show before your interpretation? (*representation*)
3. Is there another legal or historical reading of this line that still fits? (*alternative*)
4. What can this source *not* tell me — what does the claim not settle? (*check*)
5. You may change your mind — where could someone go wrong with a decorative quote or a model précis? (*revise / diagnose*)

How to wait alone. After you ask, cover any answer you drafted. Count a slow three.⁹⁴ If you stop mid-reason, wait again before peeking. Look at the credit line, the plaque, the starred line, or the clock — not at the phone's answer key or the feed. Rescue at one second is still rescue. Abandonment for forty minutes of scrolling is not a micro-session.

What a stuck silence usually means. The question was vague; wait-time 1 was zero; you are hunting for a vocabulary word; you are guessing what a textbook wants; you offered a keyword where a looking move was asked for; a finished-looking chatbot paragraph feels like a check; blank-page anxiety is eating working memory — shorten the session, win one WRITE-01 opener from one starred line, come back tomorrow. Your job is to pose, wait, and point back at the object — not to fill the silence with a model summary.

Practice that actually builds it

Pamphlets, plaques, short civic excerpts, and two sourced notes **are** the practice — they still do not replace the structure: claim that points, warrant that explains, limit that hedges. Tips and tricks below are teachable moves, not slogans. Banks are menus, not calendars.

⁹⁴Stahl (1994) think-time / Rowe (1972) wait-time — classroom-origin; adult translation = pause before lookup / before feed share. A slow three is a convention, not a sacrament. Keep it labelled classroom-origin — not an adult history RCT.

Named try-its (TALK, WRITE, ARG)

1. WRITE-01 Source Sentence First — commute / lunch

Time: 10–15 minutes.

Materials: blank note; one credited piece.

The move: First sentence names maker/date/type; second may interpret. Exit: two-sentence opener. Refuse interpretation-first paragraph.

2. TALK-02 Point to the Line — commute / lunch

Time: 10–15 minutes.

Materials: a claim you just made; the piece in view.

The move: Finger or cursor on the supporting line; if you cannot point, retract or hedge. Exit: point-or-retract. Refuse vibe citations.

3. ARG-06 Limit Your Claim — commute / lunch

Time: 10–15 minutes.

Materials: an overwide claim you drafted earlier (or a feed sentence you almost believed).

The move: Add time, place, population, or source-limit hedges. Exit: before/after claim. Refuse universal slogans as history claims.

4. TALK-05 Wait Before Feed — commute / lunch

Time: 5–10 minutes.

Materials: urge to reply or share a history-adjacent card.

Safety: ordinary stakes; no rage-share as civic virtue; no live controversy as the try-it object.

The move: Timer 3–5 seconds minimum (classroom-origin wait-time translated); ask whether the card is evidence or later telling; then decide. Exit: shared / not shared + reason.

5. TALK-01 Source Before Summary Round — commute / lunch or desk

Time: 10–15 minutes.

Materials: any short primary or civic object.

The move: Say aloud (or write) attribution before any plot summary; wait 3+ seconds; then one Observe. Exit: audio note or sticky proving order. Refuse summary-first habit.

6. ARG-01 Claim from a Starred Line — desk

Time: 20–25 minutes.

Materials: primary with one starred sentence.

The move: Write a claim that depends on that line; if the line vanished, the claim should weaken. Exit: claim + starred citation. Refuse decorative quote. Solo check: delete the quotation; does the claim still stand?

7. ARG-02 Warrant Sentence — desk

Time: 15–20 minutes.

Materials: claim + quotation already chosen.

The move: Add “This counts as evidence because ____” (genre, proximity, corroboration, audience). Exit: warrant sentence. Refuse quotation dump without warrant.

8. WRITE-03 Civic Clause Paraphrase — desk

Time: 20–30 minutes.

Materials: short civic excerpt (public-domain).

The move: Paraphrase in plain adult prose; check against words; note remaining ambiguity. Exit: paraphrase + ambiguity flag. Refuse paraphrase that smuggles a modern platform.

9. WRITE-02 Quote vs Paraphrase Soft — desk

Time: 15–20 minutes.

Materials: one quotation you want.

The move: Quote only if words uniquely matter; otherwise paraphrase + cite; never quote orphan fragments. Exit: quote-or-paraphrase decision note. Refuse quote salad.

10. WRITE-05 Model Summary Is Not a Source — desk

Time: 20–30 minutes.

Materials: a model/chatbot paragraph (generated for this drill); your WRITE-01 opener; the primary in view.

Safety: you hold the account; unaided look first; do not file the model as primary.

The move: Strike any sentence that only rests on the model; replace from the primary. Exit: redlined draft. Refuse model-summary-as-source.

11. ARG-05 Audience and Purpose in Argument — desk

Time: 20–30 minutes.

Materials: argumentative primary (pamphlet, editorial; Publius/Anti-Federalist soft optional — point to *Publius* for a Federalist deep week; do not rewrite it here).

The move: What did the maker want the reader to do or believe? How does that shape evidence selection? Exit: purpose→selection note. Refuse “biased = false.”

12. TALK-04 Add-One Protocol — desk

Time: 15–25 minutes.

Materials: your first interpretation; the same evidence.

The move: Force one additional interpretation consistent with the same evidence; mark which fits better and why. Exit: two interpretations ranked. Refuse first-thought lock-in. This is dual-perspective when prompted — not a demand for unprompted dual-function every micro.⁹⁵

13. ARG-03 Counter Soft — desk

Time: 20–25 minutes.

Materials: your claim; one source that pressures it.

The move: Steelman the counter in one sentence; adjust claim scope. Exit: scoped claim. Refuse ignoring the counter; refuse burning a strawman.

14. TALK-07 Accountable to the Text Soft — desk

Time: 15–20 minutes.

Materials: a favorite prior belief about the topic; today's piece.

The move: What in *this* text would change your mind? If nothing could, you are not doing history this hour. Exit: falsifier sticky. Refuse unfalsifiable identity claims as hour products.

15. TALK-06 Stuck Silence Repair — any band

Time: 5–15 minutes when you froze.

The move: Diagnose: mushy question / too-hard prose / fear of being wrong. Repair the question or scaffold one sentence (often WRITE-01). Exit: diagnosis + repair. Refuse abandoning the sit for scrolling.

16. TALK-03 Their World Round — desk (bridge from ch06)

Time: 15–20 minutes.

Materials: CTX-01 prompt under a claim you are forming.

The move: Speak three constraints; wait; add a fourth or revise; then ask whether your claim still fits. Exit: revised constraint list under the claim. Refuse monologue denunciation.

17. ARG-04 Two-Source Mini-Argument — weekend

Time: 45–60 minutes.

Materials: two sourced excerpts on one question.

The move: Claim; evidence from each; one warrant; one limit. Exit: ≤150-word

⁹⁵Kuhn & Udell / Kuhn & Crowell grain (via memo 01/02): dual perspective when prompted; unprompted dual-function is not the adult default even under favorable conditions. Prompt add-one; do not assume. Not an adult history RCT of this book's objects.

paragraph. Refuse five-paragraph costume without warrants. Still not weekly AP DBQ.

18. WRITE-04 Two-Source Paragraph — weekend

Time: 45–75 minutes.

Materials: two sourced notes.

The move: Claim; evidence weave; warrant; limit (Monte-Sano neighbor grain).⁹⁶

Exit: 120–180 words. Refuse parallel book reports glued together.

19. WRITE-06 Revision Pass — Evidence Weave — weekend

Time: 30–45 minutes.

Materials: *your* draft paragraph (not a model rewrite).

The move: Highlight claims without evidence; add or cut; one corroboration phrase if available. *Exit:* before/after highlight photo. Refuse longer = better.

Tool may ask revision questions after — not rewrite as only draft.

Talk-to-yourself while you practice

Keep the locked opening in your mouth. On micro days, TALK-02 and TALK-05 carry more weight than a full paragraph. On desk days, point to the line before you polish. On weekend days, add-one and counter soft earn their minutes only after a claim already names a source.

Blocked, then mixed

Blocked (new move). One source sentence *or* one point-to-the-line *or* one limit sentence. WRITE-01, TALK-02, or ARG-06 alone. No second document. No op-ed.

Mixed (when the move is stable). Pair ARG-01 with ARG-02. Pair WRITE-01 with ARG-06. Pair WRITE-05 refuse with a real primary beside the précis. Pair TALK-04 with ARG-03 when two voices are on the table. Pair ARG-04 with WRITE-04 on a weekend — still occasional.

⁹⁶Monte-Sano neighbor (historical argument writing): instruction toward claim, evidence, corroboration, contextualization of evidence; regular summary writing alone does not install those features. Useful pattern; not a promise every adult will see the same result. Solo check: delete the quotation; does the claim still stand?

Hypothesized week menu (composite — not a calendar)

Monday: WRITE-01. Tuesday: TALK-02. Wednesday: ARG-01 + ARG-02. Thursday: WRITE-05 refuse. Friday: claim+limit sticky. Optional weekend: ARG-04 + WRITE-04. Ambition shape, not an RCT.

One incorrect example to diagnose (composite illustration)

Notebook paragraph: “The Founders clearly meant [modern slogan]. As everyone knows, the document proves it. [chatbot précis pasted, no credit line, no starred words from a primary]. Therefore the debate is over.”

What went wrong. Thesis without a named source you opened; model summary as source; no warrant; no limit; pledge-theater energy on a civic text; looking skipped.

Repair. Delete the pasted précis. Open a credited public-domain excerpt. WRITE-01. Star a line. ARG-01. ARG-02. ARG-06. Optional TALK-04 one other-side best point. The debate is not “over.” The claim is scoped.

If it isn’t clicking

No shame. Correct a wrong reason without crushing the attempt — applied to yourself. Short sessions and early wins beat a countdown timer as default rigor. This is not a therapy manual.

1. Blank page.

Symptom: you stare; you rewrite the same summary; you open a chat window to “get started.”

Next move: star one line → WRITE-01 source sentence → one claim that depends on the line (ARG-01). One paragraph is enough. If dense prose is the blocker, shorten the excerpt (PIAAC literacy is adjacent reading stock, not a history talent label).⁹⁷ Slow down here. Do not assign ARG-04 to “enrich” a stuck Monday.

⁹⁷PIAAC 2023 U.S. literacy context (mean 258; Level 1 or below 28%; ages 16–65) — adjacent reading stock, not historical thinking, not a talent label, not teen NAEP. Shorter excerpts are mercy when dense prose freezes the page.

2. Myside fluency without limit.

Symptom: a confident paragraph that never hedges; or a victory lap that never points at a line; or dual-function demanded of yourself as shame when a micro only needed a source sentence.

Next move: ARG-06 one limit sentence; TALK-02 point to the line; prompt one other-side best point only when the week holds two voices (TALK-04). Point once to *Critical Thinking for Adults* for myside craft — then return to this piece.⁹⁸

3. Tool wrote it.

Symptom: the only draft is a model rewrite; detector anxiety; fluent voice with no starred line in view.

Next move: delete; unaided re-draft from the piece; then revision questions after *your* draft (WRITE-06). Do not detector-grade your own unaided write-up — false positive rates on human writing can be severe.⁹⁹ Do not trust a fluent citation without opening the paper.¹⁰⁰ Photo-to-key stays banned during the attempt.

When to slow down. Source sentence and point-to-the-line are not stable. Anxiety is eating working memory — shorten to one micro; early WRITE-01 win; return tomorrow. Archaic prose is the blocker — scaffold access, then return to claim craft.

When to go ahead. You can write a claim that names a source, a warrant that is not a restatement, and a limit — and you refused a model summary as source once. Then ARG-04 / WRITE-04 weekend stretch is fair. Still not weekly DBQ identity.

When to ask a human. A librarian can help you find a second short primary for ARG-04. A tutor or community class can sit with warrant stems. A trusted reader can ask “where is the line?” — not rewrite your claim for you. Ask for help locating sources and hearing missing warrants. Do not ask anyone to finish your looking or to paste a model paragraph as yours.

⁹⁸*Critical Thinking for Adults* holds myside / dual-perspective argument craft on ordinary present stakes — one pointer, then history. Stanovich myside batteries, CCTST, and Watson–Glaser stay in *Critical Thinking for Adults* — not in this chapter’s body.

⁹⁹Liang et al. (2023): detector false-positive rate 61.22% on human TOEFL essays — adult-side caution against detector-grading your own unaided write-up.

¹⁰⁰Walters & Wilder (2023): GPT-3.5 ~55% / GPT-4 ~18% fabricated citations in tested conditions — open the source; do not trust fluent citation lists.

Tools, including AI

Optional helpers. Keep this short. Point back to the History Refresh Hour AI box.

After you have tried, you may:

- Explain this claim structure *to yourself* from a named lesson / page / credited primary (title, page, today's micro-goal).
- Extra isomorphic practice with answers on **your** page (claim frames + your key).
- A labelled SCRIPT after you tried — a short spoken or written sequence for *you* to say, not a paragraph to copy as your work.
- Revision questions after *your* claim / essay / labelled op-ed draft — not a rewrite as the only draft.
- A hint after an attempt. A hint is not the finished answer.
- Diagnose work you already did (crop to paper or note — no face).
- Discussion questions you vet and ask yourself.

You may not during the attempt:

- Paste tonight's worksheet, civic packet, or employer sheet and ask the tool to complete it (photo-to-key).
- Ask "write my essay / op-ed" or "fix to publishable" as the only draft.
- Generate a diary, letter, or speech from then as if it were a real primary.
- Put a model summary on the table as the source.
- Park an unsupervised chatbot as your only partner during the attempt.
- Detector-grade your own unaided write-up.¹⁰¹
- Invent research or trust a fluent citation without opening the paper.¹⁰²
- Paste proprietary employer data into a public consumer tool.
- Print a certificate of civic literacy from a chatbot.

One mechanism sentence, labelled OFF-AGE for literacy/history: in a high-school math field experiment, an unguarded chatbot made practice look better and left students worse on the test with the window closed.¹⁰³ **Not an adult history RCT.**

¹⁰¹Liang et al. (2023): detector false-positive rate 61.22% on human TOEFL essays — adult-side caution against detector-grading your own unaided write-up.

¹⁰²Walters & Wilder (2023): GPT-3.5 ~55% / GPT-4 ~18% fabricated citations in tested conditions — open the source; do not trust fluent citation lists.

¹⁰³Bastani et al. (2025), *PNAS*: Turkish high-school math, grades 9–11, nearly 1,000 students; unguarded chatbot patterns reported in that study — **OFF-AGE for literacy/history**; not an adult history RCT. Lunch-break rule only.

Not this history band. The lunch-break rule it supports: the model may prepare you and the next looking page; it may not do your looking, sourcing, claim, essay, or op-ed when those are the lesson.

What “done enough” looks like

Short looking-move checklist before moving on. Placement by skill, not diploma year. A “civic literacy certificate” is a receipt this book never invents — and is not the work.

You are done enough with this chapter’s strip when you can honestly check most of these:

- ☐ I wrote one claim that names a source (maker/date/type or clear credit).
- ☐ I pointed to a starred line that the claim depends on — or I retracted.
- ☐ I wrote one warrant that is not a restatement of the claim.
- ☐ I named one limit (what this claim does not settle).
- ☐ I refused a model summary as the source of a written claim at least once.
- ☐ Optional: I added one other-side best point when prompted (add-one), without demanding full dual-function every micro.
- ☐ Optional weekend: one two-source paragraph or mini-argument with warrant and limit — still not weekly AP DBQ.
- ☐ My exit sticky could almost be shown to a stranger: claim / source / warrant / limit.

Life-of-the-habit tip (not a ninth teaching chapter). Revisit next Tuesday: one WRITE-01 on the commute; one point-to-the-line at the desk; space across days. Mix last week’s piece. Stop while a look remains. Dated claim notes and looking-move strip logs live in Chapter 8. Optional CLEP or college survey edges are bridges when credit is the goal — not the spine, and never titled History Refresh for Adults I.

Self-placement probe (skill strip, not diploma year): Can you cover a body until attribution is said, open a piece before a thread, hold a second side for one sentence when prompted, and name one limit? If yes on most days this week, the teaching arc’s exit strip is moving. If not, stay with the missing move — often WRITE-01 or ARG-06 — before you chase a longer essay.

Work product a stranger can read: a dated short claim with named source, warrant, and limit — inside a skill title a stranger understands (the looking move, the civic object, or a college course name if credit is the path). Never History Refresh for Adults I. Never a fake certificate of civic literacy. Optional CLEP score report belongs only if you chose that bridge and an institution recognizes it — sitting the exam is not finishing this book.

You do not need to be a historian. You do need to hear a claim with no source, a source with no claim, and a fluent précis offered as your work — and to ask the locked question before you nod. You can do this on the commute and in a deeper sit.

Access date for cited pathways and fetches: **13 September 2026.**

Chapter 8



Figure 10: Dated notebook with a looking-move strip and a museum-label scrap — still-life, no diploma seal, no people, no logos.

Keeping track

There is often **no** “History Refresh for Adults I” as a job title, and this book will not invent one. A stranger — a colleague who missed the huddle, a tutor you might hire later, a college registrar, a future you on a Tuesday — already reads work they understand: a dated looking note, an annotated excerpt, a two-source card, a skill named in ordinary language, an optional official score report. Never History Refresh for Adults I. Never Emerging Adults History I. Never Certified Civic Literacy. Never a fake certificate printed by a chatbot.

This chapter is the file you keep. The teaching chapters rebuilt looking moves. Here you place yourself by the looking-move strip, log what you practiced, leave a dated line someone else could almost follow, and — only if credit is your goal — decide honestly whether an optional exam is worth the fee.

Life of the habit lives here as *trace*, not as a ninth teaching chapter. Same kind of object next Tuesday, new date. That is enough.

What you are making

You are making a **looking-move strip log**, a **self-placement habit**, and a **dated looking note** (often with an annotated excerpt or a two-source corroboration card). Stacked over months, that file is the honest adult work product. You are not making a national diploma. You are not making a teen Records transcript. You are not manufacturing Carnegie units unless you separately enroll in a credit course or sit CLEP for an institution that asked for it.

Titles a stranger already understands:

- the **looking move** (source before body; primary before feed; Observe–Reflect–Question; corroborate; civic text as sourced object; claim with named source and named limit)
- the **civic / life artifact** (plaque check; ballot pamphlet read; museum label honesty; feed claim checked against a piece from then)
- a **college course name** only if the work maps (U.S. History survey; American Government; Western Civilization; World History; Civics)
- an **optional CLEP** exam name if you sat it and the receiving college cares

Combining objects is allowed. Combining does not mint a franken-title. An OpenStax chapter plus a LOC Free to Use strip plus a dated museum note is still the looking-move file — not “Online History Refresh for Adults I.”

Here is an illustration, labelled as such, not a reported workplace or court case:

13 September 2026. Band: desk. Object: courthouse plaque photo (dedication date on plaque; no brand). Move: Observe–Reflect–Question, then source before body. Observed: bronze plate; dedicated 1987; names a single cause for a local bridge. Reflected: whose story is centered; what materials the plaque itself is. Question: what would a second source or a newspaper from the year add? Claim: the plaque asserts one cause; it does not settle competing causes. Limit: I have not yet opened a contemporary newspaper page. Minutes: 25. Next cue: Chronicling America neighbor or library local-history shelf — same question.

That is readable by a tutor who was not in the room. It is not a badge. Place by looking move, not by brand.

The looking-move strip log

Keep a simple table or checklist you will actually reopen. Columns that earn their keep:

Date	Band (com- mute / desk / week- end / mu- seum / library)	Object (plaque / pam- phlet / primary / feed card...)	Move prac- ticed	One claim + named source	One limit	Minutes	Next cue
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Looking moves this book uses (match the teaching chapters):

1. Source before body (who / when / what kind / for whom / against what problem)
2. Primary before feed (open a piece from then — or a named secondary with provenance — before the host summary)
3. Observe–Reflect–Question on a short object (honesty card: original / excerpt / translation / later printing / modernized / screenshot / AI-generated)
4. Corroborate two accounts (agreement, tension, limit — without calling a liar)
5. Civic text as sourced object (Preamble phrase, one amendment, short founding excerpt — makers named; not a slogan)
6. Claim + named source + warrant + named limit
7. Survey / CLEP edges (optional — chronology breadth and institutions only when credit is the plan)

You do not need every move every week. A shift worker may live in source-before-body, primary-before-feed, and one claim sentence on commute cards. A returning student may add corroboration and civic-as-source deep sits. Placement is by life demand and looking skill, not by a podcast that said “everyone needs Western Civ.”

Rebuild week vs maintenance week. A rebuild week opens a rusty or new move: more honesty cards, a deeper sit, blocked practice before mixing. A maintenance week revisits last month’s plaque or feed check with three micros and one mixed interloper — no heroics. Adults who only rebuild and never maintain will re-rust. Adults who only maintain and never rebuild will not open the next gate. Name both in the log (“R” or “M” in the Next cue column is enough).

Life of the habit, here: the note is how the habit leaves a trace. “I used to treat the anniversary caption as the event; now I open a piece first” is growth. It is not a diploma ceremony.

Self-placement by looking move (not diploma year)

A college graduate can still treat a feed caption as the event. A GED-holder can source a plaque cleanly. **No diploma was required** to open this book, and no diploma year places the next module.¹⁰⁴

Use short probes — mirrors, not oracles. Vendor placement tools (OpenStax chapter previews, DIG lesson central questions, CLEP practice guides, community-college placement, commercial adaptive platforms, citizenship-test prep apps) place by content familiarity; they are not IES-certified RCTs of this book.¹⁰⁵ Annenberg and Pew civic-fact surveys describe a national recall pond. They are not your pretest, not your posttest, and not a grade for your notebook.¹⁰⁶

Probe ladder (self-check, not a published test):

- **Source before body.** Cover the body of a short piece or a feed card. Name who / when / type / audience before you decide what it means. If you still leap to the tidy story, stay here.
- **Primary before feed.** Given a viral claim or a podcast host's tidy sentence, open one short primary (or a named secondary with provenance) before judging the feed. Fail shape: the host's sentence becomes "what happened."
- **Observe–Reflect–Question.** One object (photo, poster, short letter, plaque photo). Concrete observations → questions → inferences with honesty about incompleteness.
- **Corroborate.** Two short accounts of one event. Where they agree; where not; one limit — without liar theater.

¹⁰⁴National Mathematics Advisory Panel, *Foundations for Success* (2008), Finding 15: readiness depends on prior opportunity to learn — adult flip continuity from *Math Refresher for Adults*: place by looking-move strip, not "too old," not diploma year. Access date for sources in these notes: 13 September 2026.

¹⁰⁵Vendor placement tools (OpenStax previews, DIG central questions, CLEP practice, commercial adaptive systems, college guided self-placement, citizenship-test prep apps) are mirrors. IES / What Works Clearinghouse does not certify them as RCTs of this book.

¹⁰⁶Annenberg Public Policy Center Constitution Day Civics Survey 2025 and Pew Research Center short-read government knowledge items (2023) are labelled population recall context — not a pretest/posttest of this book and not historical thinking.

- **Civic text as source.** One amendment or Preamble phrase: makers, then-meaning sticky, what the line can and cannot settle. Refuse pledge-theater.
- **Claim + warrant.** One sentence claim; named source; why the source supports it; one limit.
- **Survey / CLEP edges (optional).** Chronology breadth; government institutions — only for adults whose study plan needs credit.

Rule of thumb: if you cannot yet name who made a feed card before absorbing its caption, you are not ready to skip to a 120-question survey sit. If a civic excerpt still arrives as a slogan, you are still in civic-as-source work, whatever your diploma. Patch the hole in front of the next real task. You may be Band F at work (clean claim on a workplace policy citation) and Band A on weekend feeds in the same month — that is ordinary, not a character flaw.

Dated looking note / annotated excerpt / two-source card

Keep what a stranger can use.

A dated looking note. Object named. Band named. Move practiced. One claim with a named source. One limit. The date is 13 September 2026 or whatever day it actually was — not “Q3 civics.”

An annotated excerpt with an honesty card. Mark original / excerpt / translation / later printing / modernized / screenshot / AI-generated. Credit line first. What you noticed before you decided.

A two-source corroboration card. Same question; two short voices; agreement; tension; limit. Difference is not proof someone lied.

Optional museum / library visit notes. Observe–Reflect–Question on a label or object; one claim; one limit; optionally corroborate later with a second label or a short library source. A museum hour is not a transcript line and not a certificate.¹⁰⁷

¹⁰⁷Library of Congress Teaching with Primary Sources Getting Started and Free to Use and Reuse sets (opened / captured 13 September 2026): primaries as raw materials; Observe–Reflect–

What not to keep as the proof: a random PDF “certificate of completion” from a site that is not transcript credit; a LinkedIn badge; a chatbot fluency seal; a franken-title; a teen Records export mashed onto adult self-study. Those can be receipts at best. They are not the work.¹⁰⁸ Prefer: dated keeping-track file; community-college noncredit completion letter on letterhead if you earned one; official CLEP score report if you chose that path; actual college transcript.

How much is enough? A line after a micro-session is enough for a first week. A stack of dated looking strips over a quarter is enough for a later reader. A binder labelled “History Refresh for Adults, Level 2” is not more lawful than the line. Frequency the evidence actually supports at the commute grain for *this* book is unknown — there is no adult commute history RCT at this exact grain. The honest pitch is often enough that the question is familiar, and dated enough that next Tuesday can find last Tuesday.

If writing itself is the wall, keep the parts anyway: move, object, claim, source, limit, date. A human colleague or librarian who already writes clear notes can help with the writing shape. You still own the looking question.

Workplace honesty: a completed OpenStax chapter is preparation, not a license. A DIG lesson checkmark is practice, not a hiring credential. A podcast streak is motivation, not evidence. Redact proprietary employer details before you share a work sample.¹⁰⁹

What employers and colleges already read

Most workplaces do not have a line item called “history refresh.” They have plaques, policy claims about “what the law always said,” ballot pamphlets, museum captions you might cite in conversation, and feed cards about founding

Question; incomplete snippets. Museum / historical-site admission and free days are local objects — do not invent a national free-museum guarantee.

¹⁰⁸Fake certificates and invented course titles (History Refresh for Adults I / Emerging Adults History I / Adult History I / Certified Civic Literacy) are refused as stranger-readable proof. Prefer dated looking notes, letterhead completions, official score reports, transcripts.

¹⁰⁹Workplace proprietary-data caution: redact employer sheets and confidential details before sharing a sample or pasting into a public consumer tool. Clarity on a cited regulation section is not legal advice.

clauses. Put the dated look inside those objects. Clarity, not legal advice. Noticing, not a sting.

Colleges read transcripts, placement results, and sometimes CLEP. They do not need a homemade course code branded after this book. If you completed a local noncredit refresher, keep the letter on letterhead — and read what that letter actually is on the college page before treating it as portable.¹¹⁰ If you sat CLEP and credit posted, keep the official report. If you only used this book and free looking, say that honestly when someone asks how you prepared — the log is still the proof of *practice*, not a substitute transcript.

PIAAC literacy describes an adjacent adult reading pond. It is not your history grade and not a cut score for this notebook.¹¹¹

Optional CLEP — honesty, not spine

CLEP is **optional** credit-by-exam. It is a bridge when a specific institution will grant credit. It is not required to refresh looking for a plaque, a pamphlet, a museum caption, or a feed claim. Sitting CLEP $\neq$ finishing this book. Most Tuesday plaque checks do not require a 120-question sitting.

Opened College Board pages (13 September 2026): History of the United States I (Early Colonization to 1877), History of the United States II (1865 to the Present), American Government, Western Civilization I, Western Civilization II, and Social Sciences and History list at **\$97.00** each, plus a test-center administration fee or a remote-proctor fee. College Board Quick Reference Guide for Educators 2026–27 lists remote proctoring at **\$30**.¹¹²

Rough shapes (opened listings): U.S. History I and II about **120** questions in **90**

¹¹⁰Community-college noncredit “certificates of completion” are local objects — read the college page for what they actually certify.

¹¹¹National Center for Education Statistics / IES, PIAAC 2023 literacy highlights: U.S. adult literacy mean **258**; Level 1 or below **28%**. Adjacent reading pond, not a history RCT and not this book’s cut score.

¹¹²College Board CLEP exam pages for History of the United States I / II, American Government, Western Civilization I / II, and Social Sciences and History, opened 13 September 2026: fee **\$97.00** each plus administration or remote-proctor fee. Quick Reference Guide for Educators 2026–27: remote proctoring **\$30**. Confirm live fees before you budget.

minutes each (some pretest unscored); American Government about **100** questions in **90** minutes; Western Civilization I and II about **120 / 90** each. ACE recommendation notes on several pages point to credit-granting score **50** and **3** semester hours — institutions may differ. Social Sciences and History appears on the exam index at **\$97**; treat live topic percentages as something to confirm on the details page before you prep deeply.¹¹³ Credit-granting scores and hours are **institution-set**. Sitting without checking transfer rules wastes money — say that plainly.

DANTES funding for eligible service members is a neighboring path — confirm locally. AP U.S. History, AP World History: Modern, and AP U.S. Government and Politics remain high-school exam objects with coordinator logistics — not the adult default year. Mention once if you already teach or sit near a school; then return to adult fit.¹¹⁴

If your goal is credit, prep from the looking moves and survey gaps you still miss, confirm the receiving college, then sit. If your goal is a cleaner plaque or pamphlet read next Tuesday, skip the fee and keep the log.

If a later reader asks

A manager who sees “History Refresh for Adults I, A” has been given a slogan. A manager who sees “Aug–Sep 2026 looking log: source-before-body on three feed cards; two museum ORQ notes; one claim with named primary and named limit” has been given a month they can use.

A registrar who sees an official CLEP score report and a catalog match has a credit question. A registrar who sees a chatbot PDF certificate has a paperweight.

Export inside the skill description or a real college course name only when the work maps. Adding “Certified Civic Literacy Practitioner” to a résumé does not make the year more lawful. It may confuse the next stranger.

¹¹³Opened CLEP listings (13 September 2026): U.S. History I/II ~**120 Q / 90 min**; American Government ~**100 / 90**; Western Civ I/II ~**120 / 90**; ACE notes often score **50 / 3** semester hours — institutions may differ. Social Sciences and History topic detail: confirm on the live details page (thin/JS on some accesses).

¹¹⁴AP U.S. History, AP World History: Modern, and AP U.S. Government and Politics are high-school exam objects — not the adult refresher default. Do not confuse AP score reports with CLEP.

When you want a Federalist newspaper-war deep week as its own object, that record belongs under the work you actually did with *Publius* — not under a home-made title branded after this book.¹¹⁵

You try this week

Open one page in a notebook or a plain file. Date it. Name the looking move you touched. Name the object (plaque, pamphlet, short primary, feed card). Write one claim with a named source and one limit. Mark rebuild or maintenance. Write one next cue for Tuesday.

If you have three dated lines already, glance back: which move reappears? That move may need a maintenance week. Which move never appears though life keeps asking for it — a caption you keep swallowing, a civic line you keep sloganizing? That move may need a rebuild week.

That is the record. It is not a diploma. It is not a teen transcript. You can stop when the next life demand is met — and you can return without starting from shame.

¹¹⁵*Publius* owns the Federalist newspaper war as a book-length object. Point for a Federalist deep week; do not rewrite it here. Export that week under the work you did, not under this book's brand as a credit title.

Chapter 9



Figure 11: Three fit cards (\$0 library, local class, optional exam) with a library card and a museum label — still-life, no logos, no readable UI.

Resources

This chapter names programs a working adult actually meets. It does not rank them. It does not sell them. Fit is cost shape, time shape, social shape, credential shape, depth, and tone — whether a commute, a desk, a museum hour, or a weekend sit can use the object this week.

Library and museum **\$0** first. A free primary and a free survey text before any paid platform. Confirm a current price on the live page before you buy; this chapter does not invent list prices it did not open. Access date for the opened pages named below: **13 September 2026**.

No opened WWC report crowns OpenStax, DIG, LOC, COR, or any podcast for adult self-study of history. School-labelled looking shapes transfer as *shape* — not as a kitchen franchise and not as a diploma.¹¹⁶

Never a fake certificate as the year's proof. Never History Refresh for Adults I as a credit title. Combining two honest objects does not mint one.

How to read a program

Six questions do the work.

Cost shape. Nothing tonight? Free digital text? Local museum admission or free day? Local adult-ed fee? Tuition? Exam fee (\$97 plus proctor for CLEP)? Subscription?

Time shape. Asynchronous twenty minutes? Commute audio? Scheduled evening class? Gallery hour? One sitting after weeks of prep?

Social shape. Alone? Librarian? Instructor? Cohort? Docent?

Credential shape. None? Local completion letter? Transcript credit? Optional CLEP score report?

¹¹⁶Institute of Education Sciences / What Works Clearinghouse: no opened adult self-study crowning report for OpenStax *U.S. History*, DIG, LOC TPS, or COR in this research stream. School-labelled looking research transfers as shape only. Access date for sources in these notes: 13 September 2026.

Depth shape. Plaque check? Survey semester? Western Civ breadth? Federalist newspaper-war deep week?

Tone shape. Patient refresh? College-credit pace? Contest / AP grain?

What a stranger can still read is the looking move you practiced or the college course you actually took. Rank never. Fit first.

Library and museum — \$0 first

Library hour — fit card. Cost: \$0. Mode: history and biography shelves, quiet desk, printing when needed, research help, sometimes a local-history room or digitized newspaper access, interlibrary loan when a survey title is not on the shelf. Credential: none. Strength: quiet, print, community, ILL. Weakness: variable hours; thin primary selection in some branches. Evidence: no national “average library history minutes” study for working adults opened here — quality and hours still vary by branch.¹¹⁷

Museum / historical-site / gallery hour — fit card. Cost: local admission, free day, or parking (local objects — **omit** a national free-museum guarantee). Mode: outing. Credential: none. Strength: objects and labels force Observe–Reflect–Question. Weakness: travel time; one-visit tourism without a dated strip teaches little. Pair with a keeping-track note.¹¹⁸

Kitchen \$0 without platforms. Pencil, paper, phone photo of a plaque you already stand in front of, public-domain PDF, library print. Fit when bandwidth or login fatigue is the blocker. Still skill-based. Title: the looking move or the civic object — never History Refresh for Adults I.

Adult use. Pick one short item. Run source before body or ORQ. Write one claim and one limit. Come back Tuesday.

Not. A diploma. A certificate. A substitute for opening a piece from then.

¹¹⁷Public library as first \$0 social fit — hours and holdings vary. Do not invent national adult history-minutes averages. NCES homeschool outing stats are school-age household objects — sister pointers only; do not paste as adult census.

¹¹⁸Museum / historical-site admission and free days are local. Pair Observe–Reflect–Question with a dated keeping-track note. A museum hour is not a transcript line.

Library of Congress — Free to Use / Teaching with Primary Sources

Fit card. Cost: **\$0**. Mode: web + optional print. Credential: none. Strength: real primaries; Free to Use and Reuse sets; TPS Getting Started analysis shape (primaries as raw materials created at the time under study; Observe–Reflect–Question; incomplete snippets that force further questions).¹¹⁹ Weakness: choice overload; easy to browse without a claim sentence.

Adult use. Pick one short item. Run the analysis shape alone. Keep a dated strip. Chronicling America is a neighboring historic-newspaper door when a local story needs a page from then.

Not. A diploma. WWC-proven adult self-study. A franchise titled after this book.

OpenStax *U.S. History* — \$0 survey backbone

Fit card. Cost: **\$0** digital (low-cost print editions exist per OpenStax higher-ed pattern — confirm live print price if you need paper). Mode: introductory college survey scope with end-of-chapter questions. Credential: none unless a college adopts it inside a credit course. Strength: stable survey spine when you want a book that stays put. Weakness: college density; requires self-pacing; not a looking franchise by itself.¹²⁰

Adult use. Read a short section. Pair with one primary looking strip (LOC, library, or public-domain excerpt). Keep a dated claim / limit log. Do not treat chapter completion as a license.

¹¹⁹Library of Congress Free to Use and Reuse sets and Teaching with Primary Sources Getting Started (opened / captured 13 September 2026): primaries as raw materials; Observe–Reflect–Question; incomplete snippets.

¹²⁰OpenStax *U.S. History* (Rice University nonprofit OER): free digital survey backbone; catalogue consensus for introductory college scope. Live details pages can be script-thin — open the chapter you need. Not a diploma by itself.

Not. A diploma by itself. “WWC-approved OpenStax history” — no such opened report. Never the credit title on a résumé.

DIG and COR — looking-move neighbors (school-labelled)

DIG *Reading Like a Historian* — fit card. Cost: often \$0 with an account (confirm live). Mode: document lessons with a central question and short sources. Credential: none. Strength: lesson *shape* — question, short docs, corroboration invitation. Weakness: classroom furniture; organization impact copy on their public pages is still organization copy, not your commute RCT. Occasional weekend use.¹²¹

COR / lateral reading — fit card. Cost: free curriculum materials on the public site (confirm live). Mode: feed practice — who is behind this, evidence, other sources, click restraint. Credential: none. Strength: portable FEED moves for anniversary cards and host summaries. Weakness: school/college task origin (McGrew et al. 2017 grain — portable as shape, not an adult-commute trial). Must not replace primary-looking weeks.¹²²

Adult use. Borrow the shape. Run it on *your* feed card or *your* dual-document set. Log the strip. Do not export “DIG” or “COR” as a credit line.

Not. A diploma. A weekly SHEG dump as the spine of this book. A replacement for opening a piece from then.

¹²¹Stanford History Education Group / *DIG Reading Like a Historian*: document-lesson shape; school-labelled origin; adult-portable as occasional weekend shape. Organization impact figures on org pages are organization copy.

¹²²Civic Online Reasoning (cor.stanford.edu) and McGrew et al. 2017 lateral-reading research: school/college populations — portable FEED moves, not an adult-commute RCT.

Podcasts and documentaries — neighbors, not primaries

A host's tidy summary, a documentary voiceover, and a viral "history fact" card are **later tellings** until you open a piece from then (or a named secondary with provenance) and check the claim.

History podcast — fit card. Cost: often \$0 with ads or library-app access (local; **omit** unverified subscription prices). Mode: commute audio. Credential: none. Strength: topic interest; repeated exposure to names and eras. Weakness: host framing is a later telling; easy to confuse narrative polish with evidence; hard to pause for Observe–Reflect–Question while driving (safety: audio-only awareness is not a looking session behind the wheel).¹²³

Documentary — fit card. Cost: library, broadcast, or platform access (**omit** unverified prices). Mode: weekend sit. Credential: none. Strength: motivation; maps of questions to ask. Weakness: voiceover confidence is not an archive.

Adult move after listening or watching (not while driving): write one claim the host or narrator made; open one short primary or named secondary; mark match / tension / unknown. Do not list a podcast season as a primary-source log. Do not cite "as heard on [show]" as archive evidence in a keeping-track file without the underlying document. This chapter does not crown any named show.

Not. A primary. CLEP. An archive substitute.

Pairing shape

Library shelf for survey and biography context; LOC / archive item for looking; museum for object-and-label practice; quiet desk for the claim sentence; podcast or doc for motivation *after* or *beside* — never instead of — a piece from then. None replaces a community-college transcript if you need credit. None replaces the talk-to-yourself wait before the feed or the chatbot.

¹²³Podcasts and documentaries motivate and map questions; they are later tellings until a piece from then is opened. Not CLEP. Not primaries. Omit unverified show or platform prices.

Community college — noncredit and credit doors

Noncredit refresher / adult education / library lecture series — fit card. Cost: local (**omit** invented national averages). Mode: scheduled or flexible. Credential: sometimes a local completion letter on letterhead. Strength: human instructor, peers, a door into credit pathways. Weakness: calendar, transport, and the stigma some adults feel walking into a “refresher” room — stigma is social weather, not a measure of your skill.¹²⁴

Credit U.S. History / American Government / Western Civilization — fit card. Cost: tuition plus time. Credential: transcript progress when successful. Strength: paced survey; graded writing. Weakness: bureaucracy; coverage pressure. Not identical to a kitchen LOC hour.

Adult use. Walk through the local door when the calendar and stigma budget allow — and keep the looking-move log anyway. Read what a noncredit “certificate of completion” actually is before treating it as portable.

Not. A reprint of high-school dual-enrollment or athletic-eligibility machinery. One pointer to *History for Emerging Adults* or *History for Homeschooling* if you also guide a teen — then return to your adult load.¹²⁵

CLEP — optional credit bridge

Fit card. Cost: **\$97** per exam plus test-center or remote-proctor fee; Quick Reference 2026–27 remote proctoring **\$30** (opened 13 September 2026).¹²⁶ Mode: one sitting after prep. Credential: possible transcript credit if the receiving college accepts the score and maps it. Strength: fast bridge for adults who already know

¹²⁴Community-college noncredit / adult-ed / library lecture fees are local — omit invented national averages. Noncredit completion letters are local objects; read the college page.

¹²⁵*History for Emerging Adults* and *History for Homeschooling* own teen / 1–12 transcript and dual-enrollment grain. One pointer if you also guide a teen — then return to adult self-placement. This book is not a reprint.

¹²⁶College Board CLEP pages opened 13 September 2026: History of the United States I / II, American Government, Western Civilization I / II, Social Sciences and History at **\$97.00** each plus administration or remote-proctor fee. Quick Reference Guide for Educators 2026–27: remote proctoring **\$30**. Institution sets credit. Confirm live fees before budgeting.

the survey material. Weakness: no credit if the institution says no; survey breadth without looking depth unless prep included sources; sitting anxiety.

Titles adults most often mean here:

- **History of the United States I** (Early Colonization to 1877) — ~120 Q / 90 min; ACE notes often 50 / 3 hours
- **History of the United States II** (1865 to the Present) — ~120 / 90; ACE 50 / 3
- **American Government** — ~100 / 90; ACE 50 / 3
- **Western Civilization I / II** — ~120 / 90 each; ACE 50 / 3 each
- **Social Sciences and History** — listed at \$97; confirm live topic detail before deep prep

Check transfer **before** you pay. DANTES funding for eligible service members — confirm locally. Sitting CLEP $\neq$ finishing this book. CLEP $\neq$ a fake certificate. Institution sets credit.

AP is not the adult default. AP U.S. History, AP World History: Modern, and AP U.S. Government and Politics are high-school exam objects with coordinator logistics. Special case if you already teach or sit near a school; then stop. Do not build the adult refresher year around AP. Do not confuse AP score reports with CLEP.¹²⁷

Free civics organization neighbors (not this book's franchise)

Annenberg Classroom and Civics Renewal Network neighbors offer free public / teacher-facing civics resources (Constitution Day free-resource neighbors named on survey releases). Fit: short civic texts and explainers as *objects to source*, not

¹²⁷AP U.S. History, AP World History: Modern, and AP U.S. Government and Politics are high-school exam objects — not the adult refresher default.

as three-branch flashcard graduation. Credential: none. They are organization neighbors — not this book's franchise and not Annenberg/Pew as your looking grade.¹²⁸

Naturalization civics prep — edge, not spine

For eligible adults on the USCIS naturalization path, official civics prep is a high-stakes legal process with its own rules. Credential: naturalization when the legal process completes — not a bookstore certificate. Omit unverified coach prices. Edge for that population; not the default refresher spine for a Tuesday plaque check.¹²⁹

Point to *Publius* for a Federalist deep week

When you want the Federalist newspaper war as a book-length object — *Publius*, Brutus, the ratification fight as its own sit — that work lives in *Publius*. This book may borrow a short civic excerpt with makers. It will not rewrite that book. One pointer. Then return to adult refresh on ordinary stakes: plaque, pamphlet, museum label, feed claim, short founding line as sourced object.¹³⁰

One pointer each, then teach, also holds for *History for Emerging Adults*, *History for Young Minds*, *History for Little Thinkers*, *History for Homeschooling*, *Critical Thinking for Adults* (myside / dual-perspective craft), and *Math Refresher for Adults* (commute / desk / weekend architecture). Different objects. Shared respect for rust.

¹²⁸Annenberg Classroom / Civics Renewal Network free resources are organization neighbors for civic texts as objects — not this book's franchise; not Annenberg/Pew recall as a looking grade.

¹²⁹USCIS naturalization civics is a legal path for eligible adults. Omit unverified coach prices. Not the default refresher spine.

¹³⁰*Publius* owns the Federalist newspaper war as a book-length object. Point for a Federalist deep week; borrow a document; do not rewrite.

Homeschool / HS history brands — incidental adult fit

Notgrass, All American History, Mystery of History, and cousins carry age and parent-homeschool packaging on their sites. Adult fit is incidental. Check age labels. Do not default to them over library / OpenStax / LOC without a reason (offline preference, pedagogy you already trust). 2026 kit prices omitted unless you open a specific product page. *History for Emerging Adults* owns those cards for ages 15–18 — one pointer, then stop.¹³¹

What not to chase

- Fake PDF certificates and invented course titles (**History Refresh for Adults I, Adult History I, Adult Civics I**, “Certified Civic Literacy”).
- “WWC-proven OpenStax history” or “WWC-approved DIG” for kitchen self-study — no such opened report.
- Podcast-as-primary; documentary-as-archive; host summary as CLEP substitute.
- APUSH / AP World / AP Gov as the default adult year.
- Three-branch flashcard graduation as civic literacy done.
- Invented claims that most employers require CLEP History or a commercial civic badge.
- Teen NAEP percentages written as if they measured working adults.
- NCES homeschool prevalence mashed as an adult civic census.¹³²
- Treating this book as a replacement for a college catalog — it can prepare you to walk in less afraid; it does not rewrite the catalog.

If you want proof, prefer the dated looking note, a letterhead completion, an official score report, or a real transcript.

¹³¹Homeschool / HS history kit brands: check age labels; omit 2026 prices unless a specific product page is opened. *Emerging Adults 03* owns those cards for ages 15–18.

¹³²Do not mash NCES homeschool prevalence (3.4% / ~1.765M in *Emerging Adults* locks) into Annenberg, PIAAC, or adult civic literacy. Do not write teen NAEP as the working-adult measure.

Choosing without ranking — a five-minute decision

1. What looking move is in front of you this week?
2. Do you need **credit**, or do you need **usable looking** for a plaque, pamphlet, museum label, or feed claim?
3. If looking only: start library / museum **\$0**, LOC Free to Use / TPS, or OpenStax paired with one primary strip.
4. If credit: open the receiving college's CLEP and placement pages *before* paying an exam fee.
5. If a local class or gallery hour fits your calendar, walk through that door — and keep the looking-move log anyway.
6. If a podcast or doc sparked the question, write the host's claim, then open a piece from then.

Fit is personal. A night-shift adult and a remote analyst can both be right with different rows of the table below.

Fit table (use; do not rank)

Tonight's need	Object	Load	Note
Nothing spent	Library / kitchen \$0 + dated note	Low	Not a fake certificate.
Object + label practice	Museum / historical site	Low–moderate	Local admission; pair with strip.
Free primaries + ORQ	LOC Free to Use / TPS	Low–moderate	\$0; claim sentence required.
Free survey text	OpenStax <i>U.S. History</i>	Moderate	\$0 digital; pair with a primary.
Document-lesson shape	DIG <i>Reading Like a Historian</i>	Moderate	School-labelled; occasional.

Tonight's need	Object	Load	Note
Feed lateral practice	COR neighbors	Low–moderate	School/college origin; neighbor.
Motivation / map of questions	Podcast or documentary	Low	Neighbor, not primary.
Human instructor / local door	CC noncredit or adult ed	Moderate–high	Local fees; letter sometimes.
Transcript progress	Credit survey / gov course	High	Tuition; coverage pressure.
Optional credit-by-exam	CLEP History / Gov / Western Civ / SSH	Prep + sitting	\$97 + fees; check college first. ¹³³
Federalist deep week	<i>Publius</i>	Deep sit	Point; do not rewrite here. ¹³⁴
High-stakes legal path	USCIS naturalization civics	High / gated	Edge population; not default spine.
HS contest / AP year	APUSH / AP Gov	HS logistics	Not adult default. ¹³⁵

You try this week

Name *why* tonight's object fits — usually library / museum **\$0** or LOC / OpenStax before paid. Open one free primary or one short survey section that matches the looking move in front of you. Do one unaided parallel try on a plaque, pamphlet, feed card, or short civic excerpt. Date the line.

¹³³College Board CLEP pages opened 13 September 2026: History of the United States I / II, American Government, Western Civilization I / II, Social Sciences and History at **\$97.00** each plus administration or remote-proctor fee. Quick Reference Guide for Educators 2026–27: remote proctoring **\$30**. Institution sets credit. Confirm live fees before budgeting.

¹³⁴*Publius* owns the Federalist newspaper war as a book-length object. Point for a Federalist deep week; borrow a document; do not rewrite.

¹³⁵AP U.S. History, AP World History: Modern, and AP U.S. Government and Politics are high-school exam objects — not the adult refresher default.

If credit is on the table, open *one* receiving-college page and write the CLEP or placement rule in your notebook before you spend \$97. If credit is not on the table, do not let an exam brochure become this week's homework.

If a podcast filled the commute, write the host's claim before you sleep — then open a piece from then on the next desk sit. The file is still the proof. Fit first. Rank never. Start free when free will do. Return to the looking-move strip when a catalog page starts to feel like shopping.

A Note on Sources

Studies named in the chapters are listed in Notes, in one series at the back. That is where the full citations live, so the teaching pages can stay a teaching voice.

Some items the research behind this book did not open stay out of the teaching voice. I did not invent a coefficient, a statute, or a product feature to fill a hole. If a study is in the chapter, it is in the notes. If we could not open it, it is not used as a finding here.

Program hours, exam fees, and product descriptions in the resources chapter are taken from the companies' or agencies' own pages. Access date 13 September 2026.